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No need to worry about US Section 301, we will tackle it... confident of a good trade deal: Goyal

Asks India Inc to get out of 'comfort zone', look for opportunities at home, abroad

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 7

DAYS AFTER the Trump administration proposed 12.5% tariffs on India and 53 other countries after a United States Trade Representative (USTR) trade investigation under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974 declared that these countries failed to impose a legal prohibition on "importation of goods produced wholly or in



part with forced labour", Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said Sunday he



Union Minister Piyush Goyal in Mumbai, Sunday. SANKHADEEP BANERJEE



didn't think there was any need to worry about Section 301, and that "we will tackle it".

The proposed tariffs have been announced while US and Indian negotiators are finalising a bilateral trade agreement.

Speaking at the *Financial Express* India's Best Banks Awards in Mumbai, Goyal said US Trade Representative Jamie Greer will visit India in the next two weeks for further discussions on the trade deal. Earlier, he had indicated an agreement could be reached by July.

"So this (Section 301 investigation) is really a mechanism

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SECOND PRICE REVISION SINCE CRISIS IN WEST ASIA

LPG cylinder price up Rs 29; OMCs still losing Rs 700: Govt

Ministry: Price of household cylinder lower than that in neighbouring countries

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, June 7

THE PRICE of a 14.2-kg domestic LPG cylinder was raised by Rs 29 effective Sunday, the second such price revision since the start of the war in West Asia which triggered a supply crisis.

The increase follows a Rs 60-per-cylinder hike on March 7, taking the cumulative hike to Rs 89 per 14.2-kg domestic cylinder. It will now cost Rs 942 in Delhi — corresponding changes in price have been effected in other parts of the country.

Beneficiaries of the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana (PMUY) will continue to pay an effective Rs 642 per cylinder after receiving a subsidy of Rs 300 per refill on the first four refills annually, down from 9 refills announced last year.

Despite the hike, public sector oil marketing companies (OMCs) continue to absorb under-recoveries of about Rs 700 per 14.2-kg cylinder as the market-linked price of the fuel is over Rs 1,600 per cylinder, the Petro-



LPG cylinders being delivered in Nadia, West Bengal, Sunday. PTI

E. EXPLAINED

Consumption down

India's LPG consumption stood at about 90,000 tonnes a day before the West Asia war. But with the disruption in flows through the Strait of Hormuz and seasonal dip in demand, LPG consumption has declined to about 72,000 tonnes a day, according to recent estimates.

leum Ministry said Sunday.

It also said that the price of domestic LPG in India continues to be lower than in neighbouring countries as the government and the OMCs have been shielding house

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Opp targets Govt: 'Why are BJP leaders not protesting now?'

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 7

THE OPPOSITION on Sunday targeted the BJP-led Central government over the domestic LPG price hike, saying it reflects the failure of its economic policies and asked if BJP leaders would hit the streets in protest like they did during the UPA years. The BJP, meanwhile, defended the increase in price, pointing to global factors.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said the cost of LPG cylinders had increased by Rs 89

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

PROBE INTO PLANTATION WORKS 15 months & counting, Rajasthan Forest Dept sits on its probe that exposed graft within

2025 report alleged forged bills, fabricated records, fake signatures

Jay Mazoomdaar
New Delhi, June 7

ONE INTERNAL report alleged corruption, including illegal money transfers, forged bills; this report gathers dust until a year later, a second report is ordered which says that the payment was in bank transfers, not cash, so there was no need for a probe. Now, everyone's waiting for a third report.

This is the unusual case of the Rajasthan Forest department sitting on its own enquiry's recommendation — 15 months and counting — to initiate an Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) investigation into alleged embezzlement in

plantation works, according to records reviewed by *The Indian Express*.

Key to the case are alleged illegal withdrawals of Rs 17 crore for advance soil work during 2023-24 in a single forest range of the Alwar division. Forest department sources, however, said an ACB probe could expose deeper systemic irregularities in a state that has spent an estimated Rs 600-800 crore annually on plantation schemes in recent years.

Based on internal evaluations of advance soil and plantation works carried out by seven Village Forest Protection and Management Committees

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Some MPs out of reach, Mamata in Delhi amid fears of rebellion

Manoj CG & Ravik Bhattacharya
New Delhi, Kolkata, June 7

BELEAGUERED TRINAMOL Congress (TMC) chief Mamata Banerjee landed in Delhi on Sunday with the avowed objective of resurrecting the INDIA bloc — which she was once critical of and maintained a distance from — amid indications that a section of her Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha MPs are getting ready to chart a separate course.

TMC sources said efforts were on to replicate the Kolkata model of MLAs breaking away and forming a separate group and electing a new leader in the parliamentary wing of the party. The TMC's organisational leadership is said to be making a last-ditch attempt to prevent a split in the parliamentary party, but several MPs are incommunicado, it is learnt.

"There is a possibility and the process has already started as far as the Lok Sabha is concerned. What has happened in the West Bengal Assembly will be repeated in Lok Sabha so far as our party is concerned,"

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TMC chief Mamata Banerjee with AAP convenor Arvind Kejriwal and TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee in New Delhi, Sunday. ANI



"Two people destroyed the India Bloc alliance: Mamata Banerjee and Arvind Kejriwal"

SANJAY JHA
JD(U) WORKING PRESIDENT
PAGE 14

Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



The four from Ballia: Joining dots between accused in killing of Suvendu aide in Bengal

Manish Sahu
Ballia, June 7

A BUSINESS installing water pipelines for agricultural fields brought together four men from Ballia. Two years later, they would find themselves at the centre of a high-profile criminal investigation.

The four are among seven people arrested by the Central



Raj Kumar Singh and Gyanendra Singh, two of the four accused from Ballia, UP. A total of seven people have been arrested in the case



Bureau of Investigation in connection with the killing of Chandranath Rath, a close associate of West Bengal BJP leader and now CM Suvendu Adhikari, in the state's Madhyamgram city on May 6, shortly after BJP's thumping win in the Assembly polls.

The men, whose villages are scattered across a radius of roughly 50 kilometres, first

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Revanth says he took 'inspiration from Hitler' for HYDRAA; BJP calls it 'Emergency mindset'

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, June 7

TELANGANA CHIEF Minister A Revanth Reddy has triggered a controversy with his statement that the Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency (HYDRAA) drew its name and concept from German dictator Adolf Hitler's "fondness for the word Hydra".

"Hydra, the word is Hitler's favourite word. His core team was called Hydra, which could assassinate anyone. So, I have taken inspiration from Hitler and named it HYDRAA," he said at a conclave in Bengaluru



Telangana CM Revanth Reddy

on Saturday.

The BJP and the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) were quick to criticise the Congress leader's comment, suggesting that this was an indication of his "dictatorial" mindset.

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Happening today

● A HIGH-LEVEL EU delegation will be in Assam to advance collaboration opportunities between Europe and India's North eastern states in line with the priorities set out in the India-EU Joint Comprehensive Strategic Agenda.

● CHINA'S XI JINPING will meet North Korea's Kim Jong Un in Pyongyang. This will be his first visit to North Korea in nearly seven years as Beijing looks to reassert ties with its ally.

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THE WORLD PAGE 12

ISRAEL HITS BEIRUT AREAS DESPITE TRUCE; WILL RETALIATE: IRAN

● SHOWS RARE CONTINUITY OF HUMAN ACTIVITY LINKING EARLY TOOL-MAKING TRADITIONS WITH LATER RITUAL, SYMBOLIC AND SOCIAL LIFE

Rock marks, game boards: Wildlife trail leads to prehistoric past in Aravalli

Sophiya Mathew & Abhimanyu Hazarika
New Delhi, June 7

FOUR MONTHS ago, a wildlife trail through the rocky outcrops of the Bhondsi stretch of the Aravalli forests in Gurgaon led wildlife enthusiasts to a stone surface marked with dozens of carefully carved cup-shaped depressions, geometric grids, and a large foot-shaped engraving.

That spot has since been identified as a cluster of ancient petroglyphs (images or designs

carved or engraved on rock), possible stone game boards, and stone tools — part of a wider archaeological pattern emerging from the Aravalli belt where, researchers say, evidence from multiple prehistoric phases appears to survive within the same landscape.

"A chronological continuity is being found here," said Akash Gupta, a PhD scholar and faculty member at Delhi University's Satyawati College who has examined the Bhondsi material. "The discovery is significant because it

shows a rare continuity of human activity linking early tool-making traditions with later ritual, symbolic, and social life across this region."

Gupta said scholars such as French archaeologist André Leroi-Gourhan viewed hand engravings on rock as evidence of a cognitive shift. Placing the latest discovery in context, he said the region has yielded signs ranging from the Lower Palaeolithic to the Mesolithic period.

"Handaxes and cleavers point to early stone-tool traditions, while the tools indicate later Middle Palaeolithic activ-



(Left) Foot engraving on quartzite rock; an Acheulean bifacial hand axe found close to rock art cliff. COURTESY: TEJVEER MAVI, SHAILESH BAISLA AND YATIN VERMA

ity (300,000 to 50,000 years ago). The cupules (cup-shaped depressions) and rock-art-like markings are more likely to belong to later symbolic or ritual phases, especially the Mesolithic, when prehistoric communities are known to have left behind paintings, burial practices and other markers of social life," he said.

Officials said excavation teams from the Chandigarh Circle of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) and the Haryana Archaeology Department have been documenting the site, including the petro-

glyphs and other remains, and have submitted a report.

Kamei Athoilu Kabui, Superintending Archaeologist with ASI's Chandigarh Circle, said, "The site needs to be protected from the land mafia and further steps in this regard need to be taken by the state government department."

She said the ASI's local exploration team, working with local villagers, had found in situ petroglyphs and stone tools.

Anil Tiwari, Deputy Superintending Archaeologist, ASI Chandigarh, said: "A brief report was prepared but there is

still a lot of scope for further work and research."

According to Shalish Baisla, a PhD scholar and researcher at the School of Heritage Research and Management, Dr B R Ambekar University Delhi, the Bhondsi documentation began after wildlife photographers Yatin Verma and Ramkumar shared images of the cup-marked rocks they had come across in the forest in February.

Verma said, "During a bird-watching trip with my team, we heard a leopard calling from a cliff above us. The cliff is a

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Khan Sir’s institute in fresh trouble: Fire safety ‘shortcomings’

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 7

EDUCATOR AND YouTuber Faizal Khan, better known as Khan Sir, who has been at the centre of a storm over violence that took place outside his institution in Patna earlier this month, is facing additional regulatory scrutiny following a fire safety audit.

Bihar Fire Services on Sunday conducted a fire safety audit at Khan Global Studies in Patna and purportedly identified multiple deficiencies, issuing a notice to the institution and directing it to rectify the shortcomings within a week, officials said.

Assistant District Fire Officer Ajay Kumar Sharma said the audit was carried out as part of an ongoing statewide drive to verify compliance with fire safety norms. “Whatever deficiencies have been found during the fire audit, a notice will be issued. They will have to remove all shortcomings within one week,” Sharma said.

According to the fire department, the coaching institute lacked several key fire safety measures. The Assistant DFO said there was “no fire alarm system installed at the premises, no fire pump had been provided, and the capacity of

the overhead water tank was inadequate”.

Sharma said the audit was also linked to an application submitted by Khan Global Studies seeking a fire safety certificate for a new building. “We came here for inspection and found several shortcomings, following which a notice has been issued,” he said.

Bihar Fire Services DIG Manoj Kumar Nut said the audit had revealed shortcomings in fixed firefighting mechanism and certain issues related to occupancy management. “If they rectify them, there is no problem. If they do not comply, the fire officers concerned are monitoring the matter. Our objective is not to trouble anyone. Our objective is to ensure compliance,” he said.

“If compliance is not ensured, the coaching institute will face sealing action under the prescribed legal process.”

He said the department had adopted a stricter approach following recent tragedies. “Last week, around 20 people died in a major incident in Delhi. A day later, the incident occurred at Prasad Hospital in Muzaffarpur. Although around 20 people were rescued due to the prompt action of Bihar Fire Services, some people still died either because of injuries or suffocation.”

Jaipur: Net suspended for 24 hrs, prohibitory orders for two weeks

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, June 7

PROHIBITORY ORDERS were issued and mobile internet services were to remain suspended in Jaipur ahead of a major anti encroachment drive in Jaipur on Monday, officials said.

Citing a letter by Police Commissioner, Jaipur Divisional Commissioner Commissioner V Saravan Kumar said that it has been proposed to remove “mass encroachment” by the Jaipur Development Authority on Monday, June 8.

“For this reason, due to the possibility of communal harmony being disturbed and law and order being affected due to protests by various organisations, damage to public property and circulation of comments, videos and photos etc. on social media like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram and WhatsApp etc., a request has been made to ban the internet from 12:00 am on 08.06.2026 to 12:00

am on 09.06.2026,” Kumar said. In exercise of his powers, Kumar issued the orders for the same period in all of Jaipur, except some areas around Rajasthan International Centre, Jhalana Dungi.

Similarly, as per an order from the office of the Jaipur Police Commissioner, prohibitory orders were issued. As per the order, a request was received to prohibit rallies, processions and meetings etc. on roads and in public places under the Jaipur police commissionerate limits. The order said that in view of JDA's drive, there may be “attempts by various organisations to protest, damage public property and disturb communal harmony on social media like Facebook, Twitter, Instagram, WhatsApp etc.”

As per the order, there will be a complete ban on holding all types of rallies and meetings on public roads and places “without prior permission from the competent authority”.

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Domestic LPG price up

holds from spiralling international prices amid the West Asia crisis.

The latest LPG price hike follows increases in the price of other fuels like petrol, diesel, and compressed natural gas (CNG) in recent weeks. The OMCs – Indian Oil, Bharat Petroleum, and Hindustan Petroleum – are grappling with financial strain as they have been selling consumer fuels below market price. Like in the case of domestic LPG, the companies continue to incur losses on the sales of petrol and diesel, despite the recent price hikes.

“The prices of petroleum products in India are linked to the corresponding prices in the international market. The Government, however, continues to modulate the effective price to the consumer for domestic LPG. Any household can buy as many cylinders as it needs at Rs 942. A PMUY (Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana) beneficiary will additionally receive the direct benefit transfer of Rs 300 a cylinder on the first four refills each year (down from nine a year)... and so pays an effective Rs 642 on those refills; this support is unchanged. Even a non-PMUY household would pay about Rs 700 below the market-linked cost of the cylinder,” the Petroleum Ministry said.

There are over 33 crore households with domestic LPG connections, including 10.6 crore households that avail under the PMUY, which provides an additional subsidy of Rs 300 per cylinder. The international LPG price benchmark, Saudi Contract Price (CP), has risen sharply through the West Asia crisis. It has gone up to \$790 per tonne in June from \$542.50 in February, marking an increase of about 46%.

India depends on imports to meet about 60% of its LPG consumption, and 90% of those imports came via the Strait of Hormuz, where maritime traffic has been effectively halted since early March. The strait's closure

has led to a surge in international oil and fuel prices as the waterway accounted for a fifth of global crude oil and liquefied natural gas (LNG) flows.

“The commercial cylinder used by hotels and businesses is revised automatically every month, because its price is a direct pass-through of the international benchmark. The domestic cooking cylinder is not. India used to import 60 per cent of its LPG requirements, and the landed cost of that import tracks the Saudi Contract Price (CP) that Saudi Aramco sets at the start of each month. This is an external price over which the Indian consumer has no control,” the Petroleum Ministry said.

Under-recovery is the gap between the international price of LPG and the regulated retail price in the country. It is absorbed by the OMCs and compensated partly by the government. The cumulative under-recovery on LPG in 2025-26 (FY26) was Rs 60,000 crore, up from Rs 41,338 crore in FY25. In August of last year, the government approved Rs 30,000 crore in budgetary support to the OMCs to partly offset their

“This caused a stir at the headquarters because bank transfers do not establish that genuine workers received the money. Some beneficiaries under the scheme meant for unskilled labourers apparently run local businesses,” said a senior Rajasthan forest officer aware of the developments.

Subsequently, sources said, the Additional Chief Secretary of the forest department sought a formal proposal for an ACB investigation at a meeting in Jaipur on April 16. The next day, records show, Upadhyay constituted another committee to examine differences between the two enquiry reports within 15 days.

Asked about the delay and the infirmities in the 2025 report that necessitated a second enquiry, Arijit Banerjee, who resumed charge as HoFF on May 18, said: “The matter requires further clarification. Due process is being followed.”

While PCCF (Administration) Upadhyay declined to comment, one of his colleagues said: “Since the alleged irregularities have been going on for over a decade, a complete list of accused persons was sought before approving an ACB investigation.

losses on domestic LPG sales. “The under-recovery now absorbed on each domestic cylinder is about Rs 700. The scale of this is visible in the fully market-priced commercial cylinder: the 19 kg cylinder used in Delhi at Rs 3,113.50, about Rs 164 a kg, after five increases during the West Asia crisis. The domestic household, by contrast, pays about Rs 66 a kg after the revision. Commercial gas carries a higher rate of tax and larger margins, so it sits above the household's cost-reflective level; even so, the import-linked cost of a domestic cylinder works out to over Rs 1,600,” it said.

According to the Ministry, domestic LPG prices in India are lower when compared to neighbouring countries like Pakistan (Rs 1,046 per cylinder), Nepal (Rs 1,207), Bangladesh (around Rs 1,225), and Sri Lanka (Rs 1,241). In the developed world, LPG prices have shot up even further – for instance, about Rs 1,755 in the US, around Rs 1,765 in Australia, and about Rs 2,411 in Canada – as per the government.

So a second enquiry was ordered. Since its findings differed from those of the first enquiry, a third committee became necessary. Its report is expected soon.”

This is not an isolated instance of plantation works coming under scrutiny in Rajasthan. In recent months, the National Green Tribunal has recorded possible misuse of afforestation funds and large-scale plantation failures near Kota, while opposition leaders have alleged inflated plantation claims under Mission Harialo Rajasthan. Since 2024, similar allegations of irregularities in plantation works have surfaced in Udaipur, Jaisalmer and Dholpur districts.

Under schemes including CAMPA, NABARD-assisted forestry programmes, environmental forestry, grassland development, reforestation and climate-change mitigation initiatives, Rajasthan has pursued ambitious plantation targets involving annual expenditure of several hundred crore rupees.

Some programmes are backed by external funding agencies such as the French Development Agency (AFD) and the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA).

Aravalli

popular spot for yoga and recreational activities among local residents. After the calls ceased, we hiked to the top to inspect the area. There, I noticed several engravings that resembled the petroglyphs I had seen in reports and news articles.”

Baisla later visited the site with Tejveer Mavi, “a local expert from Kot village whose field knowledge of the Aravalli landscape has helped researchers identify several prehistoric markers across the ridge”.

The Bhondsi cluster, located near the Bhuvneshwari Mata Mandir temple complex in the belt running from Delhi's ridge through Gurgaon and Faridabad, is unusual because of the concentration and variety of markings on the exposed rock surfaces.

The team has documented cupules, geometric engravings, possible two-player game-board patterns and a large foot-shaped engraving, said Baisla, adding that this may have had ritualistic or ceremonial significance.

The team has been using LIDAR (Light Detection and Ranging) scanning – a laser-based remote-sensing technique that captures the shape and depth of surfaces in high detail – to create detailed digital records of the petroglyphs.

15 months & counting

(VFPMCs) in Alwar's Rajgarh range, Rajasthan's Head of Forest Force (HoFF) ordered an enquiry by the then Chief Conservator of Forests (CCF), Jaipur, in December 2024.

Village committees are set up to involve local communities directly in the protection, regeneration and management of forests in partnership with the state forest department.

Submitted in February 2025, the enquiry report stated that forest officials and VFPMC of office-bearers were involved in unnecessary expenditure exceeding Rs 2 crore and illegal withdrawal of more than Rs 15 crore in public funds from committee bank accounts through allegedly forged bills, fabricated labour-day records, fake signatures and manipulated measurement books.

The report recommended referring the matter to the ACB.

Between April and July 2025, the enquiry officer sent three reminders, additional evidence of alleged forgery, and proposals for show-cause notices against senior forest officers to HoFF

Arijit Banerjee, who forwarded the communications to PK Upadhyay, Principal Conservator of Forests (Administration), for action.

On July 21, Banerjee went on medical leave and Upadhyay assumed charge as HoFF. In August – six months after the enquiry report was submitted – Upadhyay forwarded the proposal for an ACB probe to the state government.

Citing involvement of state service officers, Deputy Secretary (forests) in December sought a proposal under Section 17A of the Prevention of Corruption Act for prior approval from the Additional Chief Secretary (Forest Department).

Instead, on February 19, 2026, HoFF-in-charge Upadhyay directed the current CCF (Jaipur) to re-examine the matter and, on March 16, appointed him the new enquiry officer.

Submitted on March 30, the fresh enquiry report concluded that the case was not fit for referral to the ACB because most payments had been made through bank transfers rather than cash.

Goyal

being created, given their (the US) constraints that the Congress is not going to support any of their actions (on reciprocal tariffs)... They are trying to create a competitive edge for India. So I don't think (we need to) worry about Section 301, we'll tackle it, it's our responsibility,” he said.

“The (Section 301) investigation is directed at a particular country,” Goyal said, without naming China.

He said India was keenly awaiting what kind of tariffs would ultimately be imposed under Section 301. “We will protect India's interests and I am very confident that the (India-US trade) deal will come through. It will be a good deal,” he said.

He, however, reiterated that “India stands for fair and equitable trade” and any deal being signed would be “balanced,” and that the country won't negotiate with deadlines set.

Goyal noted that in a world where geopolitics is in a flux, “realignment of friends and friendships” would be inevitable.

Replying to a question on whether investments from China could be facilitated further given India's growing trade deficit with that country and the critical inputs required for new-age manufacturing, he

said the government “has no problem with investments from China so long as they are in the desirable sectors and not meant for opportunistic takeover of Indian assets.”

He, however, ruled out any revisiting of India's decision to stay out of the China-led Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), saying it was incomprehensible in the first place why the then UPA government joined the talks for the 15-country trade bloc, while the country already had preferential trade pacts with most of these countries, except China.

He said the bulging merchandise trade deficit with China – \$112.4 billion in 2025-26 – could be progressively reduced by a multi-pronged strategy, including creating competitive domestic capacities wherever feasible, and cracking down on unfair trade practices like dumping and predatory pricing.

He hinted that the UK's insistence on proceeding with steel import tariff measures after all processes for implementing the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA) were almost concluded would lead to India clawing back some concessions it had given in the pact. “On steel, we will have to rebalance with some products which will possibly even hurt the UK businesses. But that's the nature of trade,” Goyal said. He

spoke of “two other issues” that had cropped up closer to the implementation of the bilateral CETA, and one of these was settled in India's favour in recent Delhi talks.

On March 19, the UK government announced that it will limit tariff-free steel imports from July 1, 2026, reducing overall quota volumes by 60% compared to the steel safeguard measure. Any imports above these levels will subsequently face a 50% tariff.

Goyal ruled out putting any curbs on investors repatriating their investments from India or outbound capital, citing the country's comfortable foreign exchange reserves and Current Account Deficit (CAD) remaining well under 2%. “Our financial services are largely about India's best banks and financial services. We've been too inward-looking. We have been content with a large Indian market. We have to shake our conscience, shake ourselves to start exploring world markets,” he said.

Goyal called upon Corporate India “to get out of its comfort zone” and look for investment and business opportunities both in India and abroad. “We have to get out of our comfort zone in every area. I mean, for that matter, whether it's banking, financial services, taking UPI internationally, publishing, jewellery, construction, education, culture, even sports,” he said.

Ballia

became acquainted about two years ago through their work and remained in occasional contact thereafter. For their families, what remains unanswered is how they came to be linked to an investigation that has captured national attention.

Besides the four from Ballia, the CBI has also arrested Mayank Raj Mishra and Vicky Maurya from Bihar's Buxar district and Vinay Rai alias Pumpum from Uttar Pradesh's Ghazipur district.

A visit to their residences revealed all four are from relatively well-off farming households, where their families live in sizeable homes and depend pri-

marily on agriculture for their livelihoods. Some had also ventured into small businesses, forging the professional relationships that eventually connected them. The families claim they are not aware if the men had been to West Bengal even once.

Sources in the CBI said the arrests are taking them closer to the prime accused, who is believed to have masterminded the killing. “We are trying to connect the dots and are questioning the accused to find out the exact chain – who hired whom and the exact motive behind the murder,” a source said.

With the exception of one accused, all four from Ballia have had a prior brush with the law, though only one has a substantial criminal record. The most prominent among them is Shee-

tal Davani village resident Gyanendra Singh alias Mannu, 48, a listed history-sheeter with 12 cases registered against him across Jharkhand, Bihar, Varanasi and Ballia. The cases range from murder and attempted murder to offences under the Arms Act. The other two accused, Naveen Singh, 34, of Thamanpura village, and Raj Kumar Singh, 21, of Ratopur village, have been named in cases involving physical assault, their families say. The fourth accused, Golu Singh of Basudevpur village, has no known criminal record, as per local police.

Naveen, a graduate and the most educated of the four, runs a business installing and maintaining irrigation pipelines for farmers across Ballia district.

At his two-storey home, his

father, Anil Singh, a government employee, said the others arrested came to know Naveen through this work. “Otherwise there was no particular reason for them to be in regular contact with him,” he said.

Over time, Naveen became the common link connecting the others, according to their families. “Raj Kumar worked alongside Naveen in the irrigation pipeline business for a few days, while Gyanendra came to our house two or three times after Naveen carried out work on his farm. They were acquaintances through business, not close friends,” Anil Singh said.

Raj Kumar lives about 30 kilometres from Naveen's village. Gyanendra's home is located nearly 25 kilometres away. Gyanendra had been prepar-

Opp

in the last four months and questioned the government's fuel diversification efforts.

“The flames from domestic LPG prices are intent on destroying the kitchens of common households!! The Modi government has allowed an increase of Rs 89 in LPG prices in the last four months. In Parliament, PM Modi had made huge claims about fuel diversification with 41 countries due to the West Asia war. What happened to them? Why is there paucity of LPG in rural areas till this day?” Kharage wrote on X.

The Congress leader asked if BJP leaders would hit the streets with cylinders in protest against the Rs 530 increase in LPG prices in the 12 years of the Modi government. “Modi ji and BJP leaders used to raise a hue and cry about inflation during the UPA era. Is it not true that the Modi government has increased domestic LPG prices by Rs 530 over the last 12 years? Why aren't BJP leaders taking to the streets with LPG cylinders in protest now?” he said.

Hitting out at the government, Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav wrote a couplet in Hindi that translates to, “Unhappy with the high price of rotis, the plate has sulked away; every hope that the BJP gave has been broken.”

Accusing the BJP-led government of passing on the burden to ordinary families, the Trinamool Congress (TMC) al-

leged that the situation was in line with “BJP model” when it came to global crises. “When global crises emerge, the poor keep worrying while the rich keep thriving. A government that boasts of being a ‘Vishwaguru’ cannot shield its own citizens from repeated price shocks. Instead of planning ahead and protecting households, @narendramodi's government keeps passing the burden onto ordinary families. For the rich, it's a minor inconvenience. For millions of families, it's ANOTHER BLOW to already stretched household budgets,” the page said in a statement posted on X.

Defending the hike, given the global scenario, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis said no nation was insulated from a rise in energy prices.

“The whole world knows that given the conditions around the (West Asia) war, no nation is immune. Petrol, diesel and gas prices have increased across the world. But the Prime Minister has worked towards containing this to a large extent in India,” he said.

“I feel that till the war situation persists, situations like this will arise, but as we have seen before, prices have also gone down; when the conditions change, the prices will also be lowered,” Fadnis said.

BJP Bihar president Sanjay Saraogi said the increase in prices was a global phenomenon and not restricted to India. “This is a global situation. However, the rate of increase in India is much lower compared to other countries,” he said.

Mamata

TMC's Rajya Sabha MP Sukhendu Sekhar Ray told *The Indian Express*. He said the process had not started in the Upper House yet. “The process was completed in the Assembly and has begun in the Lok Sabha. So, naturally, the phenomenon will follow in the Rajya Sabha as well. But it has not started yet,” he said.

Banerjee, who arrived in Delhi, met with AAP convener Arvind Kejriwal along with her nephew and second-in-command Abhishek Banerjee, who is under fire from the rebel MLAs who have elected their own legislature party leadership. Mamata and Kejriwal are known to share a warm relationship. The TMC said Mamata and Abhishek, the TMC's parliamentary party leader, “held an extensive discussion on the road ahead” with Kejriwal. “When the people of India unite, no force on earth can stop their march towards justice, dignity and a better future in 2029,” the TMC said.

It is not yet clear whether two-thirds of the TMC's 28 Lok Sabha MPs have decided to chart a separate course. “A handful of our MPs are up to something, but I don't know whether they have the support of 19 MPs,” a party leader said. At present, the

TMC has 28 MPs in the Lok Sabha and 13 in the Rajya Sabha.

The TMC leadership's apprehension is that some of the MPs are planning to do “something” on Monday to coincide with the INDIA bloc meeting, which is scheduled to begin at 12 pm. Mamata and Abhishek are in Delhi to attend the meeting.

Sources said a section of MPs might approach Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday, with the rebel camp confident that 20 MPs are with them. An MP close to Mamata Banerjee is learnt to be in constant touch with the party's MPs, while the dissidents too are following suit. Sources close to the former West Bengal CM acknowledged chances of the Lok Sabha group breaking, but are confident that at least 16 MPs will stay with her. This will deprive the rebels of the two-third majority which is needed to escape provisions of the anti-defection law. The party is also weighing options of going to court on the state Assembly issue.

TMC sources said Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, along with some other MPs, were already in touch with Birla. Sources also indicated that a section of Rajya Sabha MPs too are not happy with the party. Like the MLAs who broke away, a section of both TMC Lok Sabha and Rajya MPs are unhappy with Abhishek Banerjee, it is learnt.

Revanth

In the years since it was set up by the Revanth Reddy government in July 2024, HY-DRAA has been undertaking a major push to demolish commercial and residential buildings that were allegedly illegally constructed on government land. The nature of the demolition drive has been criticised by Opposition parties and also by the High Court. Reddy defended its record at the conclave, saying it was protecting lakes and safeguarding government lands, and suggested that the model should be replicated in other cities.

Picking up on the CM's reference to Hitler, BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla asked

if senior Congress leader and Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, would take action against Reddy. In a post on X, Poonawalla wrote, “Revanth Reddy is now openly boasting that Hitler inspired him to create HYDRAA. This is Congress's tanashahi (dictatorial) mindset. From Indira (Gandhi)'s Emergency to Revanth's crackdown on journalists and students.”

Union minister and Secunderabad BJP MP G Kishan Reddy, in a post on X, also referenced the Emergency and alleged the Congress has “always muzzled people of the country.” “Congress's dangerous Hitler, Emergency mindset is out in the open yet again,” he wrote. He demanded an apology from the Congress and Revanth Reddy.

Golu's village, Basudevpur, lies about 15 kilometres away. Having studied up to the intermediate level, he chose to enter business after marrying last year.

His 65-year-old mother, Vidyarthi Devi, said this was a sign that he was beginning to stand on his own feet. “I only learnt about Golu's arrest from people who came to the house,” she said.

Raj Kumar's father, Tribhuvan Narain Singh, an electrician, recalled that two of the men arrested in the case, Naveen and Gyanendra, had previously visited the family's home and even attended Raj Kumar's birthday celebration last year.

“He worked with Naveen for some time to learn the trade. People visit each other's homes while learning a profession,” he said.

ALLEGED MURDERERS HELD IN BENGAL, POLICE SAY PROPERTY DISPUTE MOTIVE BEHIND CRIME

18 mins, change of clothes, Bengal IDs: How cops swooped on masked ‘killers’ of DU prof

Alok Singh
New Delhi, June 7

A 42-YEAR-OLD man and his wife allegedly travelled nearly 1,400 km from West Bengal to Delhi along with their 13-year-old son, stayed in a hotel using fake Aadhaar cards, and murdered a Delhi University professor living alone in her apartment in East Delhi.

The trio wore surgical masks while entering the apartment complex and, after allegedly committing the murder, fled to the railway station to board a train to West Bengal in the same cab they used to come to the apartment from their hotel.

Delhi Police eventually tracked them through CCTV footage, identifying them after their images matched recordings from both the New Delhi and Bardhaman (Burdwan) railway stations.

According to investigators, the couple had meticulously planned the crime to avoid identification. However, a crucial mistake — changing their clothes before and after the murder — raised suspicion and helped police to crack the case.

Debosmita Paul, who lived alone in her flat at Satyam Apartment in Vasundhara Enclave, was found dead on Thursday afternoon. She had been attacked with a blunt ob-

ject, and there were cuts on her wrists. Nothing was missing from the flat, which led investigators to suspect that someone known to the victim may have been involved.

The police initially did not pay attention to the masked couple and the child, who appeared to be a family, captured on CCTV cameras. Looking at the footage repeatedly, however, they noticed something curious.

The clothes that the man and woman had on while entering the complex at 3.53 pm were different from the ones they were wearing as they exited at 4.15 pm on Wednesday. The child, however, was wearing the same clothes.

The post mortem examination had established the probable time of death, which corresponded with the 18-minute window during which the couple were inside the apartment.

As investigators tracked the movements of the couple through a network of CCTV cameras, they identified the cab that had brought them to the apartment complex, and had subsequently taken them to Anand Vihar railway station.

However, instead of boarding a train from Anand Vihar, the couple hired an autorickshaw and travelled to New Delhi railway station, appar-



Debosmita Paul

● THE TRAIL

● Accused arrived in Delhi along with son from West Bengal.

● They stayed in a hotel using fake documents.

● Trio wore surgical masks while entering victim's apartment.

● Couple changed clothes before exiting the apartment complex.

● Booked a cab to travel from the hotel to victim's house. Used the same cab to flee to New Delhi station after committing the murder.

● They boarded a train to West Bengal.

● Police tracked them through CCTV camera

ently in an attempt to mislead investigators.

There, they boarded the New Delhi-Howrah Poorva Express, which left at 5.40 pm. They had taken off their masks, and police were able to see their faces clearly in CCTV footage from the station.

Meanwhile, police had discovered that the suspects had been staying at a guest house in Dallupura since June 2. The guest house records showed Aadhaar cards with a Bardhaman address.

When police reached Bardhaman, they found that the residents at the address were not the same as the ones identified in the railway station footage.

But upon examining CCTV footage from Bardhaman railway station around the time of arrival of the Poorva Express, the train's last stop before reaching Howrah, they found the suspects, along with their son. However, police still did not know their address.

With assistance from the West Bengal Police, investigators scrutinised additional CCTV footage and discovered that the couple had parked a scooter near the railway station before travelling to Delhi. Using the vehicle's registration number, police traced their actual address, and arrested them from their residence.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly revealed that a property dispute with the professor had led them to murder her.

According to police, Debosmita's family owns property worth crores in Bardhaman, one of which was occupied by the accused as tenants. They have claimed that they paid her a monthly rent of Rs 11,500, and had spent around Rs 1.5 lakh on repairs at the property. The accused also operated a profitable sanitary goods shop from the premises, police said.

The couple had allegedly repeatedly urged Debosmita to sell the property to them, especially because they had invested money in it. However, she refused, and instead asked them to vacate the premises in June.

The couple were arrested on Sunday morning and produced before a court in Bardhaman, which granted transit remand for their transfer to Delhi.

Police sources said several key pieces of evidence had been recovered, including a Samsung mobile phone belonging to the deceased, a razor that was allegedly used in the crime, a backpack used by the accused, clothes and a cap allegedly worn during the commission of the offence, train tickets, and other travel-related documents.

Negligence alleged after man dies as plaster falls from Gr Noida high-rise

Drishti Jain
Noida, June 7



A video grab of one of the buildings of the society. EXPRESS

A DAY after a 46-year-old resident of a multi-storey society in Greater Noida West was killed after a portion of cement plaster fell on him from a 19th-floor balcony, it has been alleged that the builder, despite being repeatedly informed about the need for maintenance since 2022, refused to carry out any repair work.

The victim, identified as Vikas Chawla, was a resident of Arihant Ambar society and was riding his motorcycle at the time of the incident, police said, adding that a maintenance manager has been arrested in connection with the case. The sole earning member of his family, Chawla is survived by his parents, wife, and two children.

Amrisha Kumar (40), secretary of Apartment Owners' Association (AOA), Arihant Ambar society, told *The Indian Express* that the incident occurred around 4 pm on Satur-

day, when Chawla was exiting the society on his motorcycle to purchase things for his house. "Soon, a piece of plaster fell on him from the 19th floor balcony, causing his motorcycle to lose balance. Subsequently, his head struck the exhaust area of a nearby wall. He was rushed to a hospital where he was declared dead," Kumar said.

Raising concern over the structural integrity of the buildings, Kumar said, "Since Noida Extension was developed in 2013, apartments were built in the area at a rapid pace. A 3BHK flat in this society now costs around 1.4 crores. By October 2022 plaster had started falling from parts of the buildings in

the society," he said. As per Kumar, possession of the flats took place in 2019, and currently 625 out of 628 flats are occupied. "The flats were handed over to the owners on time, and the builder eventually started repair work. However, the work was later stopped," he said.

He claimed that in April 2023, the builder had given a written assurance that repair work would be carried out.

"Later, the builder left and the society was transferred to the AOA.... But when he failed to carry out the repair work, we approached the UP Real Estate Regulatory Authority (RERA) and the case went through several hearings," he said. Kumar said that seven months ago, repair work was undertaken, but it was also halted soon. He added that a complaint about the builder was also sent to the SDM on May 2.

With no action being taken, residents at a society meeting on May 24 decided to form a tender committee and invite bids for painting and repair work.

3 unauthorised properties razed, 12 sealed

New Delhi: As part of a citywide drive against illegal and unauthorised structures in the Capital, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Sunday demolished three properties while sealing another twelve,

officials said.

Meanwhile, in another drive targeted at non-compliant structures, the District Level Committee constituted by the Delhi government also visited around 130 properties

on Sunday, officials said.

The committee was formed in the fire at Flourish Stay bed-and-breakfast (B&B) facility in Hauz Rani, Malviya Nagar, claimed 22 lives, including 13 foreign nationals. ENS

B&B fire: One more foreign national dies; search intensified for accountant, manager

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 7

ANIGERIAN national injured in the fire that broke out at Flourish Stays B&B facility in Hauz Rani succumbed to injuries during treatment at a hospital on Saturday, taking the death toll in the blaze to 22, police said on Sunday. Meanwhile, Delhi Police have intensified their search for the B&B's accountant and manager following the arrest of its chef and owner.

With the death of a Nigerian national, the number of foreign nationals killed in the blaze has risen to 13, police said.

"The Nigerian national, a middle-aged man, had been staying at the hotel for the past few days. After the incident, he was taken to a nearby hospital and later referred to Safdarjung Hospital, where he died during treatment. He suffered burn injuries," an officer said, adding that the Nigerian Embassy has been informed.

Police said that efforts are underway to trace the hotel's accountant, Jay Mishra, and manager, Rakesh, who was present in the building when the fire broke out.

As per sources in the police, three hotel employees were



At the site of the blaze on Sunday. VIVEK PRAKASH KRISHNA

present at the time of the blaze — chef Keshav Negi, manager Rakesh, and a helper.

"Rakesh was sitting at the reception when the fire broke out in the kitchen on the ground floor. Keshav was in the kitchen when he noticed sparks in an air fryer, which led to a heat blast in the machine. However, instead of alerting others, he fled the hotel without informing anyone," an officer said. The officer added that Negi could have assisted in the rescue efforts or alerted the fire brigade,

"Negi's arrest was made based on his alleged culpability and evidence collected during the investigation," the officer said. On Sunday, Negi was also taken to the hotel to help police reconstruct the sequence of events, officers added

Fire at New Friends Colony house: eight rescued, two pet dogs killed

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 7

EIGHT PEOPLE, including four children, were rescued after a fire broke out at a residential building in South Delhi's New Friends Colony on Sunday afternoon, officials said. Two pet dogs, who got trapped inside the building, died in the blaze, they said

As per a Delhi Fire Services (DFS) official, the fire started on the first floor of the building at Mathura Road and people were trapped on the third floor. The two dogs were later rescued and taken to a veterinary hospital, where one was declared dead, while another died during treatment.

A call regarding the fire was received around 3.39 pm, officials said, adding that five fire tenders were pressed into service. By the time help arrived, thick smoke had engulfed the



A fire engine stationed at the site of the blaze in South Delhi on Sunday. ANI

building.

"The fire started on the first floor due to a malfunction in a split air-conditioner's indoor unit. The unit caught fire and fell onto a bed, causing the flames to spread rapidly," said DFS official Raj Kumar who supervised the rescue operation.

Upon arrival, firefighters heard children shouting for

help from the upper floors. They were later evacuated.

"The two dogs had fallen unconscious due to heavy smoke inhalation. Emergency CPR and first aid were administered at the scene, but one died. Another was rushed to a nearby veterinary hospital where it died during the treatment," the officer said.

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CORRIGENDUM

Reference: CTS Courses Admission Notice of NSTI(W), Noida published on 07-06-2026. "Drone Technician" course duration may be read as "Six Months" in place of "Six Year".

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		Manager (E3)	1
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		Manager (E3)	1
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// विज्ञप्ति //

महोदय शासन चिकित्सा शिक्षा विभाग मंत्रालय भोपाल के ज्ञाप क्रमांक एक 2-53/2017/1/55 दिनांक 12/01/2018 मध्यप्रदेश स्वशासी चिकित्सा सैद्धांतिक आदेश सेवा नियम 2018 एवं मध्यप्रदेश शासन लोक स्वास्थ्य एवं चिकित्सा शिक्षा विभाग मंत्रालय भोपाल द्वारा जारी अधिसूचना क्रमांक 1105 एफ 2-45/2010/1/55 भोपाल दिनांक 24.07.2024 एवं कार्यालय आयुक्त चिकित्सा शिक्षा के पत्र क्रमांक 112/स्वा/राज / सचिपति/2024 भोपाल दिनांक 18.01.2024 के अन्तर्गत स्वशासी संस्था गांधी चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय भोपाल के अधीन निर्मलक्षित विभागों में सहायक प्राध्यापक के रिक्त पदों की पूर्ति की जाना है आवेदन करने की प्रक्रिया अन्ती उम्मीदवार को वेबो की शासन / एलससी द्वारा निर्धारित अद्यतन दीई क्यू विभागकी अग्रसार अधिसूचि पूरी करे की है। अतः निर्मलक्षित रिक्त पदो हेतु निर्धारित प्रपत्र में गांधी चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय भोपाल (स्वशासी समिति) द्वारा दिनांक 25.06.2026 सायं 5:30 बजे तक आवेदन पत्र अप्रतिष्ठ किजे जावे है।

विज्ञान की संपूर्ण जानकारी एवं आवेदन पत्र का निर्धारित प्रारूप स्वशासी चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय भोपाल मध्यप्रदेश की वेबसाइट www.gmcchhopal.net पर उपलब्ध होगी।

सहायक प्राध्यापक (सीधी भर्ती) वेतन मेट्रिक्स लेवल 11-68900-139900

क्रमांक	विभाग	UR	OBC	ST	SC	Remark
1	कम्प्यूटरी मेडिसिन (स्टैटिस्टिक्स)	01	-	-	-	-
2	न्यूरोसर्जरी ट्रामाबुनित (सर्जरी विभाग)	-	01	-	-	-
3	स्पेर्टस मेडिसिन	01	-	-	-	-
4	जनरल मेडिसिन	-	-	-	01	-
5	इण्डोक्रिनोलॉजी	-	01	-	-	-
6	पीडियाट्रिक कार्डियोलॉजी	01	-	-	-	-
7	पीडियाट्रिक न्यूरीलॉजी	01	-	-	-	-
8	पीडियाट्रिक न्यूनेटोलॉजी	01	-	-	-	-
कुल-08		05	02	00	01	-

(बैकलॉग के पद) सहायक प्राध्यापक (सीधी भर्ती) वेतन मेट्रिक्स लेवल 11-68900-139900

क्रमांक	विभाग	UR	OBC	ST	SC	EWS	Remark
1	प्रसूति एवं स्त्री रोग	-	01	03	-	-	-
2	फार्माकोलॉजी	-	-	01	-	-	-
3	नेस्ट्रोडोन्टोलॉजी	-	01	01	-	-	-
4	रेडियरेटरी मेडिसिन	-	-	01	-	-	-
5	रेडियोलॉजी	-	-	02	-	-	-
6	नेफ्रोलॉजी	-	01	01	-	-	-
7	मेडिकल ऑफिसोलॉजी	-	01	-	-	-	-
8	फॉरेंसिक मेडिसिन	-	01	-	-	-	-
कुल-14		00	05	09	00	00	-

रिक्तियों की संख्या परीक्षित्य भर्ती के किसी भी चरण में पदों की संख्या घटाई / बढ़ाई जा सकती है

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गांधी चिकित्सा महाविद्यालय, स्वशासी समिति, भोपाल

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TWISHA DEATH CASE

Records show delays in key recoveries – from 10 hrs to 10 days

Anand Mohan J Bhopal, June 7

INVESTIGATORS IN the Twisha Sharma case have claimed that evidence was seized from retired judge Giribala Singh's home within hours of the news of the model's death being communicated to the Bhopal Police at midnight on May 13.

However, a scrutiny of the seizure records reveals that crucial evidence, including the ligature material — a gymnastics rope allegedly used by Twisha to hang herself — was recovered nearly 10 hours after the phone call to the police, along with other evidence such as her mobile phone and laptop. A head- phone set worn by Twisha seen in CCTV footage capturing her last moments was recovered only 10 days later.

The CBI is expected to question Madhya Pradesh Police officers on their handling of crucial evidence in the case. The CBI took over the investigation after officers from Katara Hills police station were accused of conducting a shoddy probe by Twisha's family, particularly after the ligature material was not produced at the time of the post-mortem examination.

Twisha's lawyer, Ankur Pandey, had alleged that the "police did not secure the crime scene, which was left with the accused who could have tampered with crucial evidence".

Lawyers for the accused have rejected these allegations.

Bhopal Police were informed of the death at 12.05 am on May 13 – two hours after she allegedly hanged herself on the terrace of her matrimonial home – by AIIMS Bhopal. Police have claimed they carried out a spot inspection, prepared a site map, and that an FSL team inspected the site. The



Twisha Sharma

first seizure was recorded at 9.42 am on May 13. According to the seizure memo, three items were seized from beneath a shed on the roof of the house.

The first piece of evidence, the ligature material, was described as a black strap or belt approximately 1 inch wide and about 99 inches long, along with a tyre strap measuring approximately 51 inches, wound around a circular wheel. The item was allegedly used in the hanging, the seizure memo records.

Investigators also seized a silver HP laptop and a red iPhone. Both the devices were locked at the time of seizure.

The seizure memo says these items were "seized from spot". The seizure was witnessed by police personnel and an independent witness who is a resident of Katara Hills.

Over the following hours, investigators returned repeatedly to the residence of the retired judge.

At 3.30 pm on May 13, according to records, a second mobile phone — a Samsung Galaxy handset — was seized after it was produced by Twisha's husband, Samarth Singh, in the presence of two independent witnesses.

At 4.40 pm, police collected a second set of materials from Samarth Singh.

According to seizure records, investigators also seized a collection of medical docu-

ments connected to Twisha.

At 6.40 pm, police seized the digital video recorder (DVR) connected to the CCTV camera system in the house. The DVR was produced by Giribala Singh, Twisha's mother-in-law. CCTV footage from the house later emerged in public, and there were competing allegations about the handling and circulation of the video clips.

Giribala's legal team denied leaking portions of the CCTV footage, which showed Twisha's body being brought down a staircase after attempts to administer CPR allegedly failed.

The Bhopal Police were accused of not securing the crime scene, resulting in the leak of the footage.

On May 15, police registered an FIR against Giribala and Samarth.

At 8.41 pm on May 23, investigators carried out more seizures at the Katara Hills residence. The first item seized was a Samsung mobile phone with two numbers but no SIM. The second was a pair of black Sony headphones which, according to the seizure memo, the "deceased had taken with her and climbed atop the terrace".

Katara Hills SHO Sunil Dubey, who was part of the SIT and among the first officers to investigate the case, said he was yet to be questioned by the CBI.

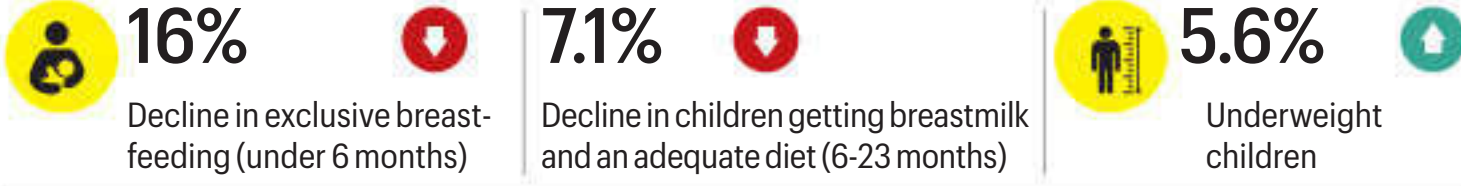
Asked why police did not mention who had helped identify the ligature material, Dubey said, "The FSL team conducted the inspection and found the ligature material at the site, which was secured immediately after AIIMS Bhopal informed us."

Asked about the delay in the recovery of the headphones, Dubey said, "They were not recovered during the videography. This doesn't compromise the case."

Delhi's infant feeding practices see sharp dip across nutrition indicators: NFHS

Feeding practices, nutrition received by children in Delhi

	Urban (%)	Rural (%)	Total as per NFHS-6 (%)	NFHS-5 (2019-21) (%)
Children under 3 yrs breastfed within 1 hr of birth	45.1	46.6	45.1	51.2
Children under 6 months exclusively breastfed	47.5	*	48.3	64.3
Children under 6 months currently breastfed	88	*	88	96
Children under 6 months exclusively or predominantly breastfed	71.9	*	72.2	83.9
Children aged 6-8 months receiving breastmilk and complementary food	52.2	*	52.5	62.9
Children aged 6-23 months receiving breastmilk and adequate diet	11	10.4	10.9	18
Children aged 6-23 months receiving adequate diet, but not breastmilk	12	*	11.9	8.6
Children aged 6-23 months receiving adequate diet	11.3	8.9	11.2	16
Stunted (height-for-age)	26.4	28.5	26.4	30.9
Wasted (weight-for-height)	15.1	10.3	15.0	11.2
Severely wasted (weight-for-height)	4.2	0.0	4.1	4.9
Underweight (weight-for-age)	27.4	26.6	27.4	21.8
Overweight (weight-for-height)	1.8	0.3	1.7	4.0



dominantly breastfed fell from 83.9% to 72.2%.

Among older infants, feeding practices also deteriorated. The proportion of children aged 6-8 months receiving complementary food alongside breastmilk declined from 62.9% to 52.5%. Only 11.2% children aged 6-23 months were receiving a minimum adequate diet, down from 16% – suggesting that nearly nine in ten children in this age group are not receiving basic standards of dietary diversity and meal frequency.

Doctors and public health experts say the trend points to a broader breakdown in early childhood nutrition practices. Dr Uma Vaidyanathan, director of obstetrics and gynaecology at Fortis Hospital Shalimar Bagh, termed the decline "a matter of concern", noting that despite

routine counselling, many mothers are unable to continue exclusive breastfeeding for the recommended duration.

She said returning to work early after childbirth is a major factor, with many women introducing formula or other feeds within a few months to accommodate care-giving arrangements. The issue, she added, is not limited to working mothers. "Even among homemakers, we have observed a growing tendency to discontinue breastfeeding early, often due to lack of sustained encouragement," Vaidyanathan said.

"There is generally no such thing as a biological failure of lactation," she said, adding that most women are physically capable of breastfeeding for one to two years, but increasingly choose not to continue.

Dr Neelam Benara, Consultant, Obstetrics and Gynaecology at Kailash Hospital, Noida, said the NFHS-6 findings point to a worrying decline across multiple indicators. The reductions in early initiation, exclusive breastfeeding, timely complementary feeding and dietary adequacy, she said, suggest that many children are not receiving optimal nutrition during a critical window of growth and development. While the survey does not identify specific causes, she said possible barriers include gaps in breastfeeding support, caregiver awareness and nutrition counselling.

Dr Vaidyanathan cautioned against a growing reliance on formula feeding, saying it may be associated with higher rates of digestive issues and allergy-like symptoms.

'They were inseparable': Tale of two promising athletes that ended in tragedy

Drishti Jain Ghaziabad, June 7

BOTH FAMILIES had struggled to support their sons' dreams. Every time a medal or trophy was added to the collection, celebrations would follow at their homes in Muradnagar, Ghaziabad. The houses belonged to young para-athletes Chirag Tyagi, 24, and Yash Khatik, 22, who had shared a common dream for the past seven years: to win medals for India and put their district on the global map.

On May 31, those dreams and hopes came crashing. Chirag was killed in Ghaziabad's Sai Kunj area; police said he had died from a gunshot wound.

The person who pulled the trigger? It was Yash, claimed police. The same night, he was apprehended based on CCTV footage and formally arrested, along with another accused, on

Monday. The news left the village in shock. Residents said Chirag and Yash were "inseparable", often seen riding bikes together and training side by side.

According to DCP (City) and Trans-Hindon Dhawal Jaiswal, Yash claimed he harboured resentment towards Chirag after his disqualification in an event last year. "He claimed Chirag had submitted a complaint to the sports association regarding his qualification, following which his nomination was cancelled and he was disqualified. To take revenge, he killed Chirag," Jaiswal said.

At Chirag's home, trophies stood neatly arranged and medals hung in his room. Just days earlier, his family had been preparing to celebrate his qualification for the 2026 Asian Para Games, scheduled to be held in Japan in October.

He had won gold and silver



Chirag Tyagi; (right) his mother outside their home in Ghaziabad. SHREYA SINGHA

medals in the 400 m and 1,500 m races in the Men's T12 (Visually impaired athletes) category in the 8th Indian Open Para Athletics International Championship held at Sri Kanterava Stadium in Bengaluru between May 26 and May 28.

"He was always came first," said his cousin, Himani Tyagi (40). She recalled how Chirag convinced his parents he



wanted to pursue a career in sports even while they insisted he study engineering. "He would wake up at 3 am in the biting cold to practise. Villagers lovingly called him 'Chirag Toofan'," she said.

"He competed at the state level and twice at the national level," Himani said. She said all his parents wanted was to see him soar high. "They never

compromised on his food... they invested everything in his career..." His father was in a private job but had been unwell for the past four years.

Around two years ago, Chirag shifted to Delhi to practice at JLN Stadium. Whenever he visited home, children would gather around. "He gave hope to all the children in the village," said his neighbour, Payal.

DELHI BIRD ATLAS CITES PRESENCE OF ARAVALLIS, FLOODPLAINS, AND A MIGRATORY FLYWAY AMONG REASONS

'Among global capitals, Delhi ranks second in bird diversity'

Sophiya Mathew New Delhi, June 7

THE DELHI Bird Atlas, released on June 5, which claims to have mapped the distribution and abundance of bird species across the city for the first time, has placed it "second only to Nairobi among the world's national capitals in bird diversity".

The atlas cites the rare mix of the city's geography, including the northern edge of the Aravallis, proximity to the western Himalayas, the Yamuna and Sahibi floodplains, and its location near the Central Asian Flyway (CAF) — a key bird migration route stretching from the Arctic down to the Indian Ocean — as the primary reason behind the bird diversity.

The atlas was developed by the Delhi Forest Department, Bird Count India, World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF)-India and other partner organisations, with the participation of birdwatchers, students, researchers, forest staff and

citizen volunteers.

According to the atlas, "The Delhi Bird List now stands at 471 species", excluding another 22 species that have not been re-recorded since 1975.

The atlas covers 11% of Delhi's area in its sampling design. The survey started in January 2025, takes place twice a year, in winter and summer, and will run for at least two years. Winter surveys document resident species and winter migrants, while summer surveys record breeding activity, resident birds, summer migrants and early-returning migrants.

In the first year, 221 species were recorded across the city, including 200 in winter and 152 in summer. Of these, 126 were resident species, 81 winter migrants and 14 summer migrants. Nearly half the recorded bird assemblage comprised invertebrate feeders, that is, 108 species or 48.87%. Plant and seed feeders accounted for 37 species, omnivores for 34, vertebrate and carrion feeders for 33, and fruit and



The Ultramarine Flycatcher and (right) the River Lapwing were among birds surveyed. SURVEYOR MOHIT MEHTA

nectar feeders for nine.

The atlas also records 18 endemic bird species, that is, species found exclusively in one specific geographic region. It also lists several vulnerable bird species, including the Endangered Egyptian Vulture and Black-bellied Tern, the Vulnerable River Tern and Common Pochard, and Near Threatened species such as the Black-tailed Godwit, Ferruginous Duck,



Painted Stork, Black-headed Ibis and Oriental Darter.

Unlike other bird lists, the atlas used a grid-based method. Delhi was divided into grids of 6.6 km by 6.6 km, subdivided into smaller quadrants and subcells. A total of 145 subcells were randomly selected for sampling to reduce bias and ensure representation across habitats. Each subcell required four 15-minute checklists, with birds recorded

on foot and uploaded to eBird. The atlas says this "systematic approach" of collecting "equal-effort lists from randomly placed grids across the city" helps reduce sampling bias and ensures that results reflect the "true distribution and abundance of species".

Experts associated with the atlas attribute Delhi's bird diversity to the city's position at an ecological intersection: the Ridge brings the Aravalli landscape into the Capital, while the Yamuna floodplains and associated wetlands provide refuge for waterbirds and migrants. The city's proximity to the western Himalayas, meanwhile, facilitates seasonal movement. The atlas notes that Delhi "lies almost at the heart of the Central Asian Flyway", making it "a seasonal haven for species arriving from as far as Central Asia and the Arctic".

The exercise, according to the atlas, provides "a robust scientific baseline" against which future atlases, to be con-

ducted five years from now and beyond, can measure ecological change. Repeated surveys will help track shifts in bird populations, habitat preferences and environmental stress over time, officials said.

Meanwhile, the atlas also describes Delhi as "a meeting point of history, geography, and biodiversity", noting that such diversity persists despite the pressures of one of the world's most populous urban regions. It underlines the importance of protecting "green and blue spaces that sustain it", pointing to forests, wetlands, riverine systems, grasslands, urban greens and floodplains as habitats that continue to support birdlife. The Yamuna floodplains, in particular, are identified as a key ecosystem for conservation and habitat restoration.

The Delhi Bird Atlas was prepared by Dr Lynette Gomes, nodal officer, Delhi Forest Department; Pankaj Gupta, state coordinator, Bird Count India; and Arnab Gupta.

Struggling to find buyers, DDA extends deadline for booking Karkardooma flats

Devansh Mittal New Delhi, June 7

STRUGGLING TO find buyers for flats in its flagship Karkardooma project in East Delhi, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) has extended the booking period for flats in the project for yet another month.

The booking period for flats under DDA Towering Heights at East Delhi Hub, Karkardooma Housing Scheme 2026, has been extended till June 30, according to a circular issued by the agency. This is the second such extension: the scheme, launched in January was only valid till March 31 initially, and was then extended till May 31. The latest order, thus, gives buyers yet another month to book the flats.

Officials and industry watchers have attributed the lack of response to high prices of units, unattractive location and uncertainty due to the on-

Skywatch



Forecast: June 8, 2026

Partly cloudy sky, possibility of thunder.

MAX: 41-43

3°C above normal

MIN: 24-26

3.6°C below normal

AQI Tracker



- Good (0-50)
- Satisfactory (51-100)
- Moderate (101-200)
- Poor (201-300)
- Very Poor (301-400)
- Severe (401-500)

Govt to induct 2,800 e-buses under Centre's PM E-DRIVE

Devansh Mittal New Delhi, June 7

THE DELHI government is set to induct 2,800 air-conditioned low-floor electric buses under the Centre's PM Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement (PM E-DRIVE) scheme, including 1,400 nine-metre buses and 1,400 twelve-metre buses, as part of its plan to expand the city's public transport fleet, Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said on Sunday.

The proposed fleet is expected to improve connectivity across the city, particularly in areas with limited public transport access. The mix of nine-metre and twelve-metre buses is intended to serve both neighbourhood routes and high-demand corridors, said officials.

The government said that currently, nearly 4,300 electric buses operate in Delhi and it aims to increase the number to around 7,500 by the end of this year. The proposed bus induction forms part of the government's longer-term target of increasing the Capital's overall public bus fleet to nearly 14,000 by 2028-29. The city already has the largest electric bus fleet in the country.

Singh said the government is also pursuing the induction of 3,330 additional electric buses under the next phase of the PM E-DRIVE scheme. These will include 500 seven-metre electric buses, which are proposed to be deployed on feeder routes and for last-mile connectivity. Another 2,330 buses will be nine-metre long and 500 will be seven metre long.

"The planned induction of 2,800 new electric buses will significantly strengthen connectivity, improve commuter convenience and accelerate our transition towards sustainable mobility," Singh said.

going West Asia conflict.

The second phase of the scheme, under a first-come-first-service basis, was launched this year after an e-auction held in December 2025 under the first phase saw subdued response. The DDA was only able to sell 178 units out of 1,026 put for auction.

In the project, DDA is offering 848 two-bedroom on 140-195 sq m at a cost of around Rs 1.8-2.4 crore. While 741 are on offer for individual buyers, the remaining 107 are for bulk allotments to government institutions.

The DDA did not respond to requests for comments by The Indian Express.

Previously, the agency had even waived parking charges to make the scheme more attractive, bringing down prices by Rs 5-12 lakh.

The East Delhi Hub, the city's first Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) project, is spread over 30 hectares.



सत्यमेव जयते
दिल्ली सरकार

12 साल विश्वास के, विकास के, जनकल्याण के



आदरणीय प्रधानमंत्री श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी जी को
समस्त दिल्लीवासियों की ओर से
हार्दिक बधाई एवं शुभकामनाएं



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली



Pep Talk

ACTING ON Prime Minister Narendra Modi's words during the National Conference of Chief Secretaries in December 2025, the Union government has asked all states to nominate a group of senior as well as young IAS officers for "motivational and knowledge-sharing interactions" at the Statue of Unity on October 31. The senior officers are meant to spend the day with the younger officers in order to mentor them. The DoPT has asked all state governments to make arrangements for the proposed visit that coincides with the birth anniversary of Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel.

Packed Week

ENTRUSTED WITH the responsibility of leading his party's annual outreach to national media on the occasion of the completion of the NDA government's 12 years in power, BJP president Nitin Nabin will camp in the Capital for the entirety of the coming week, according to party insiders. Nabin, who has been travelling across the country to familiarise himself with the party's organisational chain of command, will hit the pause button on the exercise to be the face of back-to-back events related to the outreach between June 8 and 13.

Ram Temple Trust denies Akhilesh charge of missing donation funds

Express News Service
Lucknow, June 7

SP PRESIDENT Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday demanded judicial intervention into reports alleging that crores of rupees from donations made to the Ram Temple in Ayodhya have gone missing, while the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust rejected the allegations saying routine audits found no significant irregularities.

In a post in Hindi on X, Akhilesh described the reports as a matter of grave concern for the devotees, terming the situation as "extremely shameful" for the temple trust and sought suo motu cognisance by judiciary.

Questioning the government's reported silence on the issues so far, he wrote: "*Sarkar ki chuppi sandigh hai*" (The government's silence is suspicious).

Responding to the allegations, general secretary of the temple trust, Champat Rai, said in a statement that the trust "undergoes internal audits from time to time, undertaken by the trust and the SBI. The audit process continues for several days. The same exercise is currently underway. So far, nothing noteworthy has come to light."

DMK absent, allies restive, INDIA bloc meets today

Battling internal rebellions, TMC is expected to play a more active role

Asad Rehman
New Delhi, June 7

WHEN THE Opposition INDIA bloc meets in Delhi on Monday, it will be under entirely different circumstances compared to the alliance's last meeting on April 15, when it devised its Parliament floor strategy on Bills related to delimitation and women's reservation.

The Opposition stands weakened after the recent Assembly polls and the equations have also seen a shift. This time there will be no DMK, which is angry with Congress over its decision to snap ties following the Tamil Nadu elections, while the once-distant TMC is looking to play a more proactive role, having lost power in West Bengal and facing the threat of an organisational collapse.

Leaders in the bloc said Monday's meeting was likely to see some fireworks as discontent among some of the members has been simmering. CPI(M) and JMM have conveyed their displeasure to Congress leadership about its style of functioning. While JMM is upset with Congress for "unilaterally" announcing a candidate for one of

the two Rajya Sabha seats from Jharkhand, the CPI(M) has conveyed its strong displeasure over attacks on former Kerala CM Pinarayi Vijayan by Congress leaders, including LoP Rahul Gandhi, during the recent Kerala election campaign.

"There is palpable anger against this government on the ground, but the Opposition is not being able to channel it for elections. That has to be discussed and a roadmap drawn out by the bloc at tomorrow's meeting. If the Congress wants to lead the alliance, it has to take everyone along. Its leaders can't go around town saying only Congress can defeat BJP. Then, why do we have this alliance? Where is Congress in UP, Bihar, Tamil Nadu, and West Bengal? DMK being snubbed to get a couple of ministers was a bad move for the alliance and all parties will be naturally wary of Congress," said a senior SP leader.

A Left leader said the country faces so many issues and the Opposition parties need to have better coordination. "If the Congress is leading the alliance, then it has to play the role of the leader of the bloc and not do petty politics," said the leader.



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge and LoP Rahul Gandhi. INDIA bloc meet is likely to see some fireworks as CPI(M) & JMM have conveyed their displeasure to Congress leadership over its style of functioning.

Other issues likely to be taken up at meeting will be the SIR, the delimitation Bill, the One Nation, One Election Bill, and exam paper leaks and issues concerning the education system, said sources.

For the Opposition alliance, DMK's absence will be a major one. With Congress joining the Joseph Vijay-led TVK in government, the DMK is unwilling to share space with its former ally. This has led to questions about the role of the MK Stalin-led party in the alliance going forward. Some non-Congress INDIA bloc leaders, including Mamata Banerjee, are learnt to have reached out to DMK leaders, but to no avail. The TVK will not join the meeting as the meeting is for only those parties that have representation in Par-

liament, said a Congress leader.

The meeting will also likely see both Mamata Banerjee and her second-in-command Abhishek Banerjee play the role of pacifiers. The Banerjees themselves are facing a rebellion from a large section of MLAs and possibly MPs who are unhappy with Abhishek. They have landed in Delhi to ostensibly attend the alliance meeting but are learnt to be trying to stave off attempts to break TMC parliamentary party.

"Meeting with a common purpose and clear intent. INDIA united. Many parties look forward to meeting in the spirit of camaraderie," TMC RS MP Derek O'Brien said on X in response to Congress communications chief Jairam Ramesh's post announcing that 23 parties would be in attendance.

JAISHANKAR, SUGIONO HOLD TALKS

India, Indonesia deepen cooperation in defence, maritime security, infra

PM Modi's visit to Jakarta also discussed

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 7

EXTERNAL AFFAIRS Minister S Jaishankar and his Indonesian counterpart Sugiono held bilateral talks on Sunday as the two nations agreed to advance co-operation in defence, maritime security, digital connectivity and infrastructure. The two leaders also discussed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's likely visit to Jakarta next month.

Jaishankar co-chaired the 8th India-Indonesia Joint Commission Meeting with Sugiono in New Delhi.

After the bilateral meeting, Jaishankar posted on X, "... Our Comprehensive Strategic Part-



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar holds talks with his Indonesian counterpart Sugiono in New Delhi, Sunday. PTI

nership has witnessed a strong growth in recent years. Held substantive discussions on our political, defence & security, maritime & shipping, trade, fintech, health, pharmaceuticals, fertiliser, critical mineral as well as tourism, education and cultural cooperation."

He also said he "exchanged perspectives on regional developments, advancing our multi-

lateral coordination and deepening India — ASEAN ties".

Sugiono said, "... We discussed key priorities under the Indonesia-India Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, from trade and maritime security to digital connectivity, infrastructure, health and people-to-people ties."

"Looking forward to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's upcoming visit to Jakarta," said

E. EXPLAINED

Historical links

From struggle against colonial powers, democratic traditions and pluralist culture, India & Indonesia share deep linkages. Independent India and Indonesia became chief votaries of independence of Asian and African countries, the spirit of which led to Bandung Conference of 1955 and later formation of NAM in 1961. Indonesia is a key pillar of India's Act East Policy. The PM's likely visit will give a fillip to new sectors like defence & semiconductors.

Sugiono, adding that it will be an important opportunity to deepen cooperation between both nations.

Will expand protests if Pradhan doesn't quit: CJP founder

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, June 7

A DAY after online satirical platform Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) staged its first major ground demonstration in Delhi, the youth pressure group's founder Abhijeet Dipke on Sunday announced that it would mobilise support across the country before returning to the Capital for its "next big protest".

Dipke, who reiterated a seven-day "ultimatum" for the removal of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged irregularities in na-

tional examinations earlier in the day, said the CJP would "expand" the movement through protests across India if the minister did not resign by next Saturday.

"I just want to say that yesterday was a trailer; over the coming days, we will expand this through protests across different locations in the country... Dharmendra Pradhan ji, there is still time, resign; you have spoilt the future, lives of more than 1 crore students," Dipke, who left Delhi for his residence in Maharashtra's Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar after Saturday's protest, said on



CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke with activist Sonam Wangchuk at Jantar Mantar. EXPRESS FILE

Instagram live Sunday evening. "We expect you to resign by Saturday; if you don't resign, we will be forced to take this movement to different locations in the country and its streets," he said.

Speaking to reporters in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Dipke said, "PM Narendra Modi should seek the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan... If PM Modi can stop the Russia-Ukraine war, then why can't he stop paper leaks?"

Dipke also announced that he would remain in India. "I will now stay in India and will

'No deliverables, no work output': Probe on Pinarayi daughter ties with PSU

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, June 7

A SOFTWARE firm, whose flagship product was a school and college management application, hired as an IT consultant for a mineral sands company; monthly remuneration of Rs 8 lakh for consultancy work that, investigators say, left no trace; and, fresh loans disbursed despite defaults on earlier borrowings.

These are the key allegations to emerge from a Ministry of Corporate Affairs investigation into the financial dealings between Exalogic Solutions Pvt Ltd, owned by Veena T, daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, and Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd (CMRL). CMRL is a publicly listed company in which state-PSU KSIDC (Kerala State Industrial Development Corporation) holds a 13% stake.

The allegations, detailed in a Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SPIO) report filed before a court in Ernakulam last year as part of prosecution proceedings under the Companies Act, are central to the Enforcement Directorate's money laundering probe against Veena and CMRL.

On Friday, ED Director Rahul Naveen was in Kerala to take stock of the probe. Days earlier, the ED had searched premises linked to Vijayan and Veena in Kerala as part of the probe.

Veena has denied all allegations through a counter affidavit in court, claiming her transactions with CMRL were lawful and transparent. Following the ED searches, CPM general secretary M A Baby had said, "The CPI(M) denounces the ED raid on Comrade Pinarayi Vijayan's residence. This is a targeted attack on a top Opposition leader by the BJP government. Such actions will not intimidate Pinarayi Vijayan or the CPI(M)."

According to the SPIO report, Exalogic Solutions was incorporated in 2014-15 with a paid-up capital of Rs 1 lakh, with Veena as its director. Its principal software product, Inmegg, was a school and college management solution, it said. Despite the company's modest scale and a negative net worth of Rs 66 lakh in 2021-22, the report said, a substantial portion of its revenues came from contracts awarded by CMRL, particularly during 2017-18 and 2018-19.

According to the SPIO, Veena allegedly played a "pivotal role" in facilitating payments



Ministry of Corporate Affairs investigated financial dealings between Veena T's firm and Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd

amounting to Rs 2.78 crore from CMRL under the guise of IT consultancy services. "Veena was appointed by CMRL as an IT and marketing consultant, receiving a monthly retainer of Rs 5 lakh in addition to Exalogic's monthly payments of Rs 3 lakh. This dual arrangement positioned her as a significant financial beneficiary, heavily reliant on CMRL," the report states.

However, the report says, investigators found no evidence that either Veena or Exalogic carried out any consultancy work for the company. "Investigations uncovered that Exalogic provided no actual services to CMRL, as confirmed by statements from Exalogic employees, CMRL's IT head, and Veena T herself. This absence of any development or consultancy work confirms that payments to Exalogic and Veena T were fraudulent, with no deliverables or work outputs provided."

The report contrasts Exalogic's engagement with that of another technology firm hired subsequently by CMRL. "In contrast, ATNA Technologies, later hired for a similar IT study, delivered structured outcomes at a significantly lower cost, underscoring the lack of justification for the payments made to Exalogic and Veena," it states.

'Rs 50-lakh loan trail'

The SPIO further alleges collusion between Veena and then CMRL Managing Director Sasidharan Kartha. According to the report, a non-banking finance company promoted by Kartha and his wife Jaya Kartha, Empower India Capital Investments Pvt Ltd (EICPL), extended a Rs 25-lakh loan to Exalogic in August 2015, carrying an interest rate of 12% and requiring repayment through 24 monthly instalments beginning August 1, 2016. Despite Exalogic making no repayment until August 28, 2016, EICPL sanctioned and disbursed another Rs 25-lakh loan the following day. Exalogic repaid Rs 4

If Sachin Pilot made a mistake, he should admit it: Gehlot on 2020 'rebellion' bid

Hamza Khan
Jaipur, June 7

AMID SPECULATION that Congress leader Sachin Pilot may be made the party's Rajasthan unit chief, former CM and fellow Congress leader Ashok Gehlot on Sunday made references to the Pilot-led rebellion in the party in 2020, and suggested that he "admit" his mistakes and "accept the truth".

Terminating the September 2022 boycott of the CLP meet a conspiracy to defame him, Gehlot said that the move was not against the party high command but against Sachin Pilot by party MLAs opposed to Pilot.

Gehlot told reporters in Jaipur, "... I want to tell Pilot *sahab* he should accept the truth. If he made a mistake, he should admit it. As soon as I left the hotel in Jaisalmer (in 2020), when it was decided they (the Pilot-led rebels) were returning, I spoke to you (journalists) and said, 'forget and forgive.' If Sachin Pilot had understood my feelings that day, he too would have forgotten and forgiven. I didn't say it wasn't my fault and it was his. I said, 'Forget and forgive,' meaning forget and forgive the mistakes we made between us. If he didn't understand that, what's my fault?"

lakh only after receiving the seed loan, the report states.

According to the SPIO, funds paid by CMRL to Exalogic were allegedly used to subsequently service these liabilities. "Bank records indicate that funds paid by CMRL to Exalogic were mostly redirected to cover Exalogic's debts with Empower India Capital Investments Pvt Ltd (EICPL). This diversion effectively transferred a Rs 50 lakh liability from the private EICPL to the publicly held CMRL, causing financial harm to CMRL," the report says.

CMRL is a listed manufacturing company specialising in the production of synthetic rutile and related chemical products. The Kartha family is its largest shareholder at 35.57%, followed by KSIDC at 13%.

Investigators said email exchanges examined during the probe allegedly centred mainly on invoicing and release of payments rather than delivery of services. "The investigation also uncovered collusion between Veena and Sasidharan Kartha... Emails predominantly focused on invoice generation and payment processing rather than actual service provision, suggesting a deliberate misuse of consultancy agreements for financial gain," the report states.

The allegations concerning Exalogic emerged during a wider SPIO investigation into CMRL's finances, which uncovered what investigators described as a long-running scheme of siphoning company funds. According to the report, CMRL recorded Rs 139 crore in "fictitious cash expenses" under sludge handling and transportation, and another Rs 43 crore through alleged over-invoicing involving unidentified vendors — an alleged cash misappropriation totalling Rs 182 crore over 15 years.

The SPIO submitted in court that the probe relied in part on loose sheets recovered by the Income Tax Department during a search of CMRL in 2019, which investigators said recorded actual cash disbursements. "The loose sheets reveal that, in addition to payments categorized under various heads, there are also cash payments recorded in the name of the Managing Director (MD) and his relatives. Therefore, there appears to be no connection between the cash payments made and the operations of CMRL," the report says.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

● U.N. MILITARY GENDER ADVOCATE OF THE YEAR AWARD FOR MAJOR BARAK; PM SAYS HER ACHIEVEMENT INSPIRATION TO YOUNG INDIANS, ESPECIALLY OUR DAUGHTERS

PM congratulates Major Abhilasha Barak for UN honour

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 7

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Sunday congratulated Major Abhilasha Barak on being awarded the UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award. He said the honour was a recognition of her outstanding service and India's long-standing contribution to United Nations peacekeeping operations.

Major Barak, who is also the Indian Army's first woman combat helicopter pilot, is serving with the UN mission in Lebanon at present. She received the award for her outreach efforts and community engagement

activities for women and adolescent girls and gender sensitisation training for peacekeepers.

Major Barak trained at the Officers Training Academy, Chennai, and was commissioned in September 2018. She hails from an Army family.

"Congratulations to Major Abhilasha Barak on being conferred the UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award," the PM said on X, adding that Major Barak is serving as an Engagement Team Commander and Gender Focal Point within the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL).

"This honour is a recognition of her exemplary service and also of India's longstanding



Major Abhilasha Barak is currently with the UN mission in Lebanon. PTI

contribution to United Nations peacekeeping efforts. Her achievement is also an inspiration to countless young In-

dians, especially our daughters, who aspire to serve the nation and humanity," he said.

The announcement had

come last month, when the Permanent Mission of India to the UN posted on X: "Proud to announce that Major Abhilasha Barak has been awarded the 2025 UN Military Gender Advocate of the Year Award."

According to an official UN statement, Major Barak has been serving with UNIFIL since June 2025 as Engagement Team Commander and Gender Focal Point with the Indian Battalion in Sector East, southern Lebanon. The award was presented by UN Secretary-General António Guterres at the UN Headquarters in New York on June 5.

UN Under-Secretary-General for Peace Operations Jean-Pierre Lacroix said that Major

Barak's work demonstrates how advancing gender equality strengthens peacekeeping operations and supports more durable peace.

The statement noted that she has led extensive outreach efforts reaching more than 5,000 women and girls through education, healthcare and vocational training programmes aimed at supporting empowerment and post-conflict recovery. "Within six months, she conducted 539 gender-focused field activities, the highest number recorded within the mission, while also leading all-women patrols during periods of heightened tensions," it said.

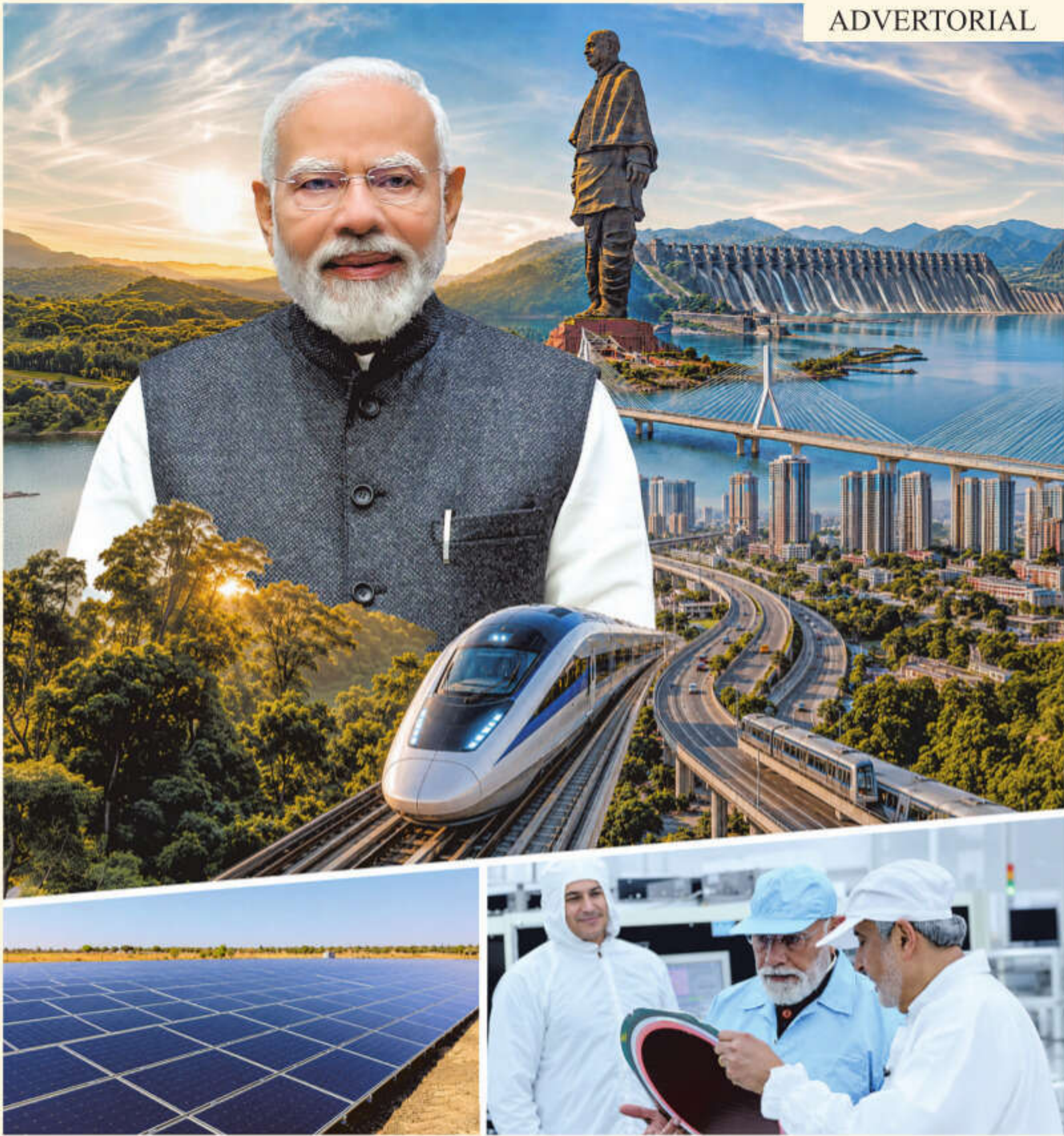
12 YEARS OF PM NARENDRA MODI: TRANSFORMING BHARAT, EMPOWERING GUJARAT

A JOURNEY OF DEVELOPMENT, WELFARE AND NATION BUILDING

Twelve years ago, India entered a new phase of governance when Shri Narendra Modi assumed office as Prime Minister following a historic mandate in 2014. Guided by the vision of a Viksit Bharat, his leadership has continued through three consecutive terms, with May 26, 2026, marking the completion of 12 years in office.

During this period, several landmark decisions and reforms have driven the country's developmental landscape. Initiatives such as GST, UPI and RuPay digital payments ecosystem, Swachh Bharat Mission, Ayushman Bharat, Make in India and the Semiconductor Mission have strengthened economic activity and improved governance. Major developments, including the abrogation of Article 370, Operation Sindoor, Surgical strikes and consecration of Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, have also marked significant moments in the country's journey.

For Gujarat, these years have translated into tangible progress through infrastructure projects, institutional development and investment-led growth aligned with the vision of 'Viksit Gujarat for a Viksit Bharat'.





12 YEARS
OF TRANSFORMATIVE
GOVERNANCE



3 TERMS
OF TRUST AND
CONTINUITY



**VIKSIT BHARAT
VISION**
HOLISTIC GROWTH FOR
NEW INDIA



**VIKSIT GUJARAT
GROWTH STORY**
PROGRESS, PROSPERITY
AND PEOPLE FIRST

WATER SECURITY:
Turning a Long-Awaited Vision into Reality



One of the most significant developments for Gujarat was the completion of the long-pending process to raise the Sardar Sarovar Dam to its full height. Within 17 days of assuming office as PM, Shri Narendra Modi approved the installation of gates on the dam, enabling it to achieve full capacity and strengthening water security across the state. In March 2015, Gujarat also received ₹ 763 crore in pending crude royalty dues, resolving a long-standing issue.

REIMAGINING GUJARAT'S CITIES FOR THE FUTURE



The launch of Smart City Mission in 2015 paved the way for urban transformation in Ahmedabad, Surat, Vadodara, Rajkot, Gandhinagar and Dahod. Ahmedabad strengthened its urban infrastructure through projects such as BRTS, Metro Rail, the Sabarmati Riverfront and the Atal Foot Overbridge. Surat advanced through Dream City, the Diamond Bourse and Metro Rail. Rajkot, Vadodara and Gandhinagar witnessed growth through projects including AIIMS Rajkot, the National Rail and Transportation Institute, GIFT City and improved transport infrastructure.

CONNECTING PEOPLE, PILGRIMAGE AND POSSIBILITIES



Connectivity has emerged as a major focus area during the past 12 years. The Mumbai-Ahmedabad Bullet Train project will redefine high-speed mobility. Gujarat received its first Vande Bharat Express in September 2022 and is now served by multiple Vande Bharat services. The Namo Bharat Rapid Rail between Bhuj and Ahmedabad has further strengthened connectivity. The 116-km Taranga Hill-Ambaji-Abu Road railway line, estimated at ₹ 2,798 crore, is expected to improve access to major pilgrimage centres and benefit around 100 villages. The inauguration of Sudarshan Setu, India's longest cable-stayed bridge, in 2024 improved connectivity between Dwarka and Bet Dwarka.

FROM GLOBAL RECOGNITION TO INDUSTRIAL LEADERSHIP



Gujarat hosted 18 meetings during India's G20 Presidency, showcasing its infrastructure, investment potential and governance achievements to the world. Industrial growth has received a major boost through projects such as PM MITRA Park at Navsari, the Tata Aircraft Complex at Vadodara, where C-295 aircraft are being manufactured, and the Dahod locomotive manufacturing facility, from which the first 9,000 HP locomotive rolled out in May 2025. The inauguration of Micron Technology's ATMP facility and the Keynes Semiconductor OSAT facility at Sanand this year have strengthened Gujarat's position in semiconductor manufacturing.

EXPANDING ACCESS TO HOUSING, HEALTHCARE AND RESEARCH



Under PM Awas Yojana, Rajkot's Lighthouse Project delivered 1,144 affordable and disaster-resilient homes using advanced French monolithic construction technology.

The establishment of the WHO Global Centre for Traditional Medicine in Jamnagar has positioned Gujarat as a hub for research in traditional medicine systems. The approval of the Bulk Drug Park at Jambusar in Bharuch, planned at a cost exceeding ₹ 2,500 crore, will strengthen domestic pharma manufacturing.

BUILDING INSTITUTIONS FOR TOMORROW'S BHARAT



Gujarat's emergence as a centre for specialised education and skill development has gained pace through institutions such as the National Forensic Science University and Rashtriya Raksha University. In 2018, the National Rail and Transportation Institute, the country's first university dedicated to railway and transportation studies, was inaugurated in Vadodara.

LEADING INDIA'S GREEN ENERGY TRANSITION



The Khavda Renewable Energy Park, the world's largest hybrid renewable energy park, in Kutch, is expected to play a significant role in India's clean energy transition. Gujarat's leadership in renewable energy was further highlighted when Gandhinagar hosted the RE-Invest Global Renewable Energy Meet and Expo in 2024.

PRESERVING HERITAGE, CELEBRATING IDENTITY



The Statue of Unity, the world's tallest statue, has emerged as a global landmark and a major tourism destination since its inauguration in 2018. Other notable projects include the National Maritime Heritage Complex at Lothal and India's first Archaeological Experiential Museum at Vadnagar. Ahmedabad's selection to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games and recent progress towards the Kalpasar project further underline Gujarat's growing prominence. The celebration of Somnath Swabhiman Parv further reaffirmed Gujarat's enduring cultural and civilisational significance.

GUJARAT'S ACHIEVEMENTS IN MAJOR CENTRAL SCHEMES



9.20 LAKH+ HOUSES
Built in urban Gujarat under PM Awas Yojana



44.80 LAKH+ TOILETS
Constructed in rural Gujarat under Swachh Bharat Mission



₹ 23,044.83 CR TRANSFERS
To 69.25 lakh farmers under PM-Kisan Samman Nidhi



43.84 LAKH+ LPG CONNECTIONS
Provided under Ujjwala Yojana



2.78 CRORE AYUSHMAN CARDS
Beneficiaries under Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY



6.70 LAKH ROOFTOP SOLAR SYSTEMS
Installed under PM Surya Ghat Yojana



1.98 CRORE JAN DHAN ACCOUNTS
Opened



3,410 KM NATIONAL HIGHWAYS
Constructed

ISSUED BY GOVERNMENT OF GUJARAT

RULES OUT THIRD-PARTY MEDIATION

Want to resolve border issues with India via diplomacy, says Nepal Foreign Minister

Divya A
New Delhi, June 7

NEPAL WANTS to resolve the border row with India through diplomacy as no problem is too large if both sides sit across with an “open heart”, Nepal Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal said in New Delhi on Sunday, talking to reporters just before concluding his two-day official visit to India.

Khanal said the new government in Kathmandu refuses to look at India through the “distorted, hyper-sensitive lens of 21st century geopolitics” and instead, wants to build a mutually beneficial relationship for overall prosperity of both nations. This came a day after Khanal held wide-ranging talks with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, which included discussions over the boundary issue.

Khanal’s remarks comes a week after Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah’s remarks on the India-Nepal boundary row. Speaking in the Nepal Parliament on May 31, Shah had stated that the border dispute with India is “not one-sided”. He claimed that after taking office, he discovered Nepal had also encroached on Indian territory in several places, just as India had done to Nepal.

Later that day, Nepal’s Foreign Ministry clarified that the cross-border encroachments were primarily technical issues related to the vaguely defined “no-man’s land” along already demarcated sections of the open border.

Playing down those remarks,



Nepal Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal addresses the media in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

Khanal said on Sunday that the priority of the new Nepal government is fast economic growth and it is with that lens that they want to upgrade ties with India, acknowledging at the same time that there are “outstanding issues, including border and boundary”.

“There are active mechanisms that exist between Nepal and India. Field survey team is actually on the border, working together. We agreed during discussions with Jaishankar to activate all these mechanisms to solve border issues,” he said.

No problem is too large and no boundary too complex when we sit down with an open heart, Khanal said, adding, “We look at India with an open heart, clear eyes, and with a single, transparent agenda: the economic transformation of Nepal.”

“Rather than engaging in hyper-nationalistic grandstanding, we are pursuing a calm, data-driven approach to resolve issues,” he said.

FULL REPORT ON

WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Man dies after falling ill at Mumbai concert; woman hospitalised

Manish Kumar Pathak & Purnima Sah
Mumbai, June 7

A 28-YEAR-OLD law student died and a 25-year-old woman was hospitalised after they fell ill during a techno music concert at Mumbai’s NSCI Dome in Worli Saturday night, prompting police to register a case against two senior executives of the event management firm that organised the show.

Police lodged the case against Karan Singh (40), CEO, and Parag Narendra Uke (42), senior manager, at Space Bound, the event company.

The deceased, Rushil Gangurde, developed severe health complications around 9pm, police said. He was rushed to hospital, where he died during treatment. The woman was admitted to another hospital where her condition has since stabilised. She had travelled from Odisha to attend the event, police said. Po-

lice sources said they were investigating whether at least one of the incidents was linked to alcohol consumption at the venue.

“We have recorded the statements of around 15 persons, including Singh and Uke, as well as officials associated with the NSCI Dome. Our investigation has found no evidence of drug consumption. Alcohol was served at the event, and the woman who was admitted to hospital has stated that she had consumed it,” an officer said.

On Gangurde’s death, the officer said: “The preliminary post-mortem report has not indicated the presence of any intoxicating substance...”

Singh and Uke have been charged under BNS sections pertaining to death by negligence, among others.

The concert, Outworld Mumbai, is part of a concept created by German DJ and producer Klangkuenstler (Michael Korb).

Telangana man shot in US, kin blame ‘fake pizza delivery trap’

Sreenivas Janyala
Hyderabad, June 7

A 28-YEAR-OLD man from Telangana was shot dead in the US in the early hours of Friday while he was delivering pizza to a house in Philadelphia. Local authorities have said the pizza was ordered to a house that was supposed to be vacant, and the victim’s family has alleged he was lured into a trap.

Anshul Kuncha, whose family lives in Gundlapochampally in Medchal-Malkajgiri district on the outskirts of Hyderabad city, went to the US four years ago after getting an employment opportunity there, his sister, Tanvi, said. Kuncha was employed at a multinational corporation, but also worked as a pizza delivery person on the weekends to earn some extra money, according to the family.

“He worked during the weekends delivering pizza to earn some extra cash. He did not even want to go to the US. He went only due to the family’s expectations...,” Tanvi said.

“This is a message to all families trying to send their children to the US... Look at what happened to my brother. He ended up dead on a dark street, shot in the head,” she said, adding that he had been



28-year-old Anshul Kuncha was employed at an MNC in US and delivered pizzas on weekends for extra money, says his family

robbed earlier, too, losing his gold chain, phone, and wallet. Anshul’s parents are K Srinivas and Nilima, who live in Gundlapochampally.

US media reported that investigators learned someone had called in a pizza delivery order to a vacant unit in a housing complex in Philadelphia in the early hours of Friday. As per a CBS News report, Philadelphia Housing Authority cameras showed Kuncha walking with the pizza order and being followed by two people wearing dark clothing and carrying a backpack.

Tanvi said, “As per US media reports, at least two persons wearing masks and backpacks ambushed him. One person shot him several times in

USD 20,000 reward for leads on suspects

New York: Police are offering a USD 20,000 reward for information leading to arrest in the killing of Anshul Kuncha.

The Consulate General of India in New York expressed condolences at the incident and said it is extending all possible assistance to Kuncha’s family. “We are deeply saddened by the untimely demise of Mr Anshul Kuncha, an Indian national in Philadelphia, PA... The Consulate is in touch with Anshul’s family and is extending all possible assistance,” it said in a post on X Saturday.

A media report said that police are offering a USD 20,000 reward for any information that leads to an arrest and conviction in the case. **PTI**

the head. It was a setup as he was lured to a deserted and abandoned area to deliver the pizza. It was a fake order, and he walked into their trap. They did not rob him, but just shot him in the head and left him on the street to die. We do not know of any reason or what they gained by killing him.”

IIT panel gives nod to CBSE examiner portal, paves way for re-evaluation

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, June 7

THE CBSE has received a final security clearance for its examiner-facing re-evaluation portal after an IIT-led cybersecurity review completed its last round of testing Friday night, clearing the way for reassessment of Class 12 answer scripts, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The IIT teams will remain on standby in case fresh issues emerge during the re-evaluation exercise, said sources.

The development comes days after *The Indian Express* reported on June 5 that CBSE was forced to delay the launch of its Post-Result Activities (PRA) portal after expert teams from two IITs uncovered multiple high-severity vulnerabilities in the Board’s digital systems. It has been learnt that CBSE decided not to use the Coempt EduTack platform, which powered this year’s controversial On-Screen Marking (OSM) system, for the re-evaluation process. Instead, student and examination data were migrated to infrastructure directly controlled by CBSE, with the re-evaluation workflow redesigned to run through the Board’s own systems.

The IIT-led teams are now preparing a set of recommendations for the Education Ministry and the CBSE, which are ex-

IIT teams will remain on standby in case fresh issues emerge



A recent protest against CBSE’s OSM policy in New Delhi. FILE

pected to call for all future examination software to be designed with cybersecurity safeguards.

According to an official in the know of the developments, the recommendations will focus on ensuring that cybersecurity considerations are incorporated from the earliest stages of software development. The report is also expected to recommend that, once developed, the software should undergo a thorough “red-teaming” exercise by a competent independent group before being deployed.

The CBSE did not respond to requests for a comment.

She remembered her brother as a “loving and joyful” person. “Just for the sake of killing, they shot him dead. It was a premeditated act using a fake pizza order. The assailants did not rob the cash that Anshul was carrying at the time of the attack, making it clear that this was not a robbery gone wrong, but a deliberate plot to take his life,” Tanvi said.

The incident took place shortly after 12.30 am. After he was shot, passersby informed police.

Chief Inspector Scott Small said that Kuncha was “lying on the ground unresponsive, bleeding heavily with a gunshot wound to his head.” “All three spent shell casings were just a few inches away from where this victim was lying on the ground in the courtyard, which is an indication that the shooter or shooters were standing very, very close to the victim...” Small was quoted as saying by an NBC report.

Police found three untouched pizza boxes and a bag inside the vacant apartment, signalling that Kuncha “successfully delivered the items before being shot outside”. Kuncha’s family has appealed to the Indian consulate to help them repatriate the body as soon as possible.

-WITH PTI INPUTS

“From our side, we gave a green signal on Friday night. Whatever we found has been fixed and we could not find anything more. There may be some minor vulnerabilities, but nothing that would have any impact,” the official said.

The examiner-facing platform had remained unavailable even after the PRA portal was launched on June 2. While students were able to submit requests for verification and re-evaluation, answer scripts could not be assigned to examiners for want of security clearance.

Sources said the Board is in the process of informing the examiners that they can begin accessing the system and participate in addressing students’ requests for re-evaluation. Rather than reviewing entire answerbooks, examiners will be shown only the specific questions flagged by students for re-evaluation, they added. The exercise will be conducted digitally; examiners will access scanned answer scripts on tablets and award marks in accordance with CBSE’s original marking scheme. The marks awarded by the original evaluator will not be visible to the re-evaluating examiner, said the sources.

This is intended to allow an independent assessment and reduce the possibility of bias, the official quoted above said.

Pannun plot: Nikhil Gupta’s counsel to seek ‘lowest possible’ sentence

Divya A
New Delhi, June 7

THE SENTENCING of Nikhil Gupta, the Indian national who pleaded guilty in an American court earlier this year in the plot to assassinate Khalistani separatist Gurbatwant Singh Pannun, has been postponed to September 25, according to US court records. The sentencing was initially slated for May 29.

Gupta pleaded guilty in February, in a case that could fetch him a sentence of 19 to 23 years. His counsel said the postponement was sought to allow more time to review case records and argue for the “lowest possible” sentence.

Responding to an emailed query from *The Indian Express*, Gupta’s New York-based counsel Isabelle Kirshner said: “There is a great deal of material that was provided to the defence attorneys during the pendency of the case that needs to be reviewed and, given that we did not enter the matter until after Mr. Gupta entered his guilty plea, we need more time to review that material, meet with Mr. Gupta and be sure that we are presenting the strongest possible argument to the Court.”

Gupta was charged with three counts: murder-for-hire, conspiracy to commit murder-for-hire, and conspiracy to commit money laundering, in connection with his efforts to murder a US citizen in New York City,” the statement said.

Kirshner said: “There are certain factors that the judge must take into consideration, including the sentencing guidelines. The judge must calculate the sentencing guidelines independently, and also take many other factors into account, such as the nature of the offence, the health and age of the defendant, criminal history, etc. In this case, our intention is to argue for the lowest possible sentence, which is our approach in all cases.”

Gupta has been held in Brooklyn since his extradition to the US from the Czech Republic in June 2024, where he had been arrested a year earlier. He had in-



Nikhil Gupta pleaded guilty in an American court earlier this year

itially pleaded not guilty. However, his admission of guilt in February moved the case from the zone of unsubstantiated allegations to an admission by an Indian citizen of involvement in an assassination plot on foreign soil.

In February, the US Department of Justice (DoJ) said Gupta had pleaded guilty and that he worked at the direction of an Indian government employee to arrange the murder. “NIKHIL GUPTA, a/k/a ‘Nick,’ an Indian national, pled guilty to all three counts contained in the Second Superseding Indictment (by DoJ in 2024), charging him with murder-for-hire, conspiracy to commit murder-for-hire, and conspiracy to commit money laundering, in connection with his efforts to murder a US citizen in New York City,” the statement said.

The US Attorney’s Office for the Southern District of New York stated: “...Gupta is a citizen and was a resident of India, and has described himself as an international narcotics and weapons trafficker in electronic communications with Yadav and others. Yadav was employed by the Government of India’s Cabinet Secretariat, which houses India’s foreign intelligence service, the Research and Analysis Wing.”

New Delhi has, on several occasions, dissociated itself from any plot against Pannun, calling it contrary to Government policy.

Surat: 4 die while cleaning sludge tank at jewellery unit

Express News Service
Surat, June 7

FOUR PERSONS died possibly after inhaling toxic gas while cleaning a tank at a jewellery manufacturing unit in Surat on Sunday morning, police said.

One of the deceased was a supervisor whereas three others were labourers. The incident took place in Varachha-Khand Bazar area and a case of accidental death was registered at Ashwinikumar Police Station.

Deputy Commissioner of Police, Zone 1, Alok Kumar said that the incident occurred at the facility of Rati Gems when workers entered the tank, which collects sludge from the jewel-

lery cleaning process.

“They clean the tank almost every two months. On Sunday, a worker entered the tank and fell unconscious. Then another labourer entered (to save the first one) and he too fell unconscious. So, (in this manner) four persons went inside the tank and (possibly) died of asphyxia or poisoning,” Kumar said.

“The exact cause of death will be known once we get the post-mortem report,” he said.

“We are examining whose negligence led to the incident, as preliminary investigations indicate that safety protocols were not followed. We will conduct a detailed investigation into the matter,” he added.

Jahangir Aziz, Co-Head of Macroeconomic Research, JP Morgan is Explained.Live guest today



Express News Service
New Delhi, June 7

THE WAR in West Asia is in its fourth month, with a shaky ceasefire being interrupted repeatedly. But the conflict is only the latest episode in a series of shocks the world has had to contend with over the last decade.

These shocks have come in various forms, starting with the political upheaval in the US following the election of Donald Trump for the first time in 2016 and China coming in the crosshairs of his administration. Then came the coronavirus pandemic, Russia’s invasion of Ukraine, Trump’s second term and his aggressive tariff-led trade war, and finally, the attacks on Iran by the US and Israel, and the subsequent closure of the Strait of Hormuz, which has led to what



Jahangir Aziz, Co-Head of Macroeconomic Research at J.P. Morgan

experts say is the largest energy supply shock in history. These series of events have been instrumental in shaping global capital flows.

Then there is the advent of artificial intelligence (AI), which has led to an investment boom the likes of which has never been seen before. Chip companies have been at the forefront, with money being diverted to TSMC, Nvidia, Samsung, and SK Hynix, among

others. While this has propelled their share prices to eye-watering levels, it has also left countries high and dry.

For India, a net importing nation, the West Asia conflict has exacerbated an already delicate external situation. With foreign capital inflows in the form of direct and portfolio investment slowing down for some time now, the widening of the current account deficit due to tariffs and then the war has exerted tremendous pressure on the rupee—which has led to further outflows from domestic financial markets. Which has exerted even more pressure on the currency. And so on.

The government and the RBI responded emphatically last week, announcing a series of measures to boost foreign fund inflows into the debt market, with banks encouraged to take on foreign currency deposits and Public Sector Undertakings loans from abroad. All these steps are

widely seen attracting more than \$50 billion. But will this be enough?

To better understand recent global economic developments as well as those on the horizon, *The Indian Express* has invited Jahangir Aziz, Co-Head of Macroeconomic Research at JP Morgan, for an Explained.Live session on Monday. He will be in conversation with Siddharth Upasani, Deputy Associate Editor, *The Indian Express*.

Aziz has spent nearly two decades at JP Morgan. Currently based in New York, he was previously the investment bank’s Head of Emerging Markets Economic Research and Chief Economist for India. Before joining JP Morgan, he was the Principal Economic Advisor in the Union government’s Ministry of Finance. Prior to that, he spent more than a decade at the International Monetary Fund, including three years as the head of the IMF’s China division. He has a PhD in Economics from University of Minnesota.

{ SALIM KUMAR • 1969-2026 }

‘A person who brought happiness, laughter’: Malayalam actor dies of cardiac arrest at 56

Anandu Suresh
Kochi, June 7

UNLIKE ACTING maestros who were also comic geniuses, such as Kalpana, Innocent and Jagathy Sreekumar, Salim Kumar did not essentially introduce a new style of acting to Malayalam cinema. In fact, a close look at some characters that Salim immortalised might lead one to wonder if they are all long-lost cousins. Yet, his brilliance lay in his ability not to make the audience feel that. Or, even if they did, the hilarity he delivered was so impactful that the masses simply did not care.

The actor passed away following a cardiac arrest in Kochi on Saturday. He was 56.

Salim loved humour so much that he ensured no good joke passed by without the recognition it deserved. The actor had spoken about instances where, if he loved a joke that didn’t make it to the final cut of



Salim Kumar receiving the National Award from former President Pratibha Patil in 2011. PTI FILE

a film, he would later rework and use it in a completely different scenario in another movie, giving it a new lease of life.

Salim began his career as a mimicry artiste at Cochin Kalabhavan. Although he entered Tinseltown with a small role in

Ishtamanu Nooru Vattam (1996), it was his stint on the show *Comic Cola* that earned him fame.

While he delivered hilarious performances in movies such as *Mannadiar Penninu Chenkotta Cheekan*, *Mattupetti Machan*, *My Dear Karadi*, and *Melevariyathe Malakhakkutti*, it was *Sathyameva Jayathe* that helped him capture the attention of both the audience and industry insiders alike.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi condoled Salim’s death with a post on X. “...Over the course of a distinguished career, he made a mark with his versatility and memorable performances...” Kerala Chief Minister V D Sathesnan said, “For Malayalis, Salim Kumar was a familiar presence in their homes and family gatherings, a person who brought happiness and laughter...”

Besides earning the National Film Award for Best

Actor for *Adaminte Makan Abu*, Salim also received four Kerala State Film Awards, including Best Story for *Karutha Jothan*. He donned the director’s hat thrice.

A follower of social reformer Sahodaran Ayyappan, the actor’s father named him Salim Kumar as a response to the social evil of the caste system, so that one couldn’t recognise his caste from his name.

A staunch supporter of the Congress, Salim addressed the masses during the party’s electoral campaigns.

Although Salim never shied away from speaking his mind, the comments he made about the 2017 Kerala actor assault case received significant backlash. Salim later issued an apology for some of those comments.

He is survived by his wife Sunitha and their two sons, actor Chandu Salim Kumar and Aaromal Salim Kumar.



#ExpressExplained

If there are questions of current or contemporary relevance that you would like explained, please write to explained@indianexpress.com

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE

Is a text AI-aided? Science, limits of detection tools



ABHINAV CHAKRABORTY

AS ARTIFICIAL Intelligence (AI) writing aids become more popular, authors and writers are navigating a tricky territory — there is almost no way to conclusively prove that they did not use AI in any stage of the writing.

The controversy around AI authorship exploded recently when the British literary magazine *Granta* announced the regional winners of its annual Commonwealth Short Story Prize, and three of the five winners faced accusations of AI use.

What makes the debate murky is that the AI detection tools generally used are far from fool-proof. In case of *Granta* winner Jamir Nazir, AI detector tool Pangram was used to term his story *‘The Serpent in the Grove’* (winner for the Caribbean) “100% AI generated”.

What is machine learning?

To understand how these tools claiming to detect AI-generated text work, one must first know the science of machine learning (ML). In simple terms, ML refers to the use of data and statistics to build an AI system: this is done by feeding large data-sets into a computer so that it can recognise patterns.

“So you would take lots of examples of AI-written content and human-written content and feed it to a big model to do the classification for you. The model, through data, learns signals like, ‘Oh, AI models tend to use em dashes,’ or use words like ‘imperative’ or ‘delve’.

These are statistical patterns that large ML models can learn when they’re fed lots of examples of both human writing and AI writing,” Danish Pruthi, assistant professor at the Indian Institute of Science Bengaluru, told *The Indian Express*.

There are also some AI ‘tells’. Pruthi said that besides em dashes or certain words, other tells include text that is organised in bullet points, often with a heading. Also, AI-generated text tends to conclude things neatly, with Pruthi saying that “human conclusions sometimes introduce new content, but model conclusions rarely do”.

He also cited the instance of “negative parallelism”: a rhetorical writing style

TEACHING, LEARNING AI

MACHINE LEARNING AND AI DETECTION

- Machine learning involves use of data and statistics to build an AI system.
- Done by feeding large datasets into a computer system so that it can reason at human or even superhuman levels.
- Requires lots of examples of both AI-

and human-written content to be fed into the system.

- The system learns to identify statistical patterns in form of words, phrases, and punctuation, thus classifying content as AI-written or human-written.

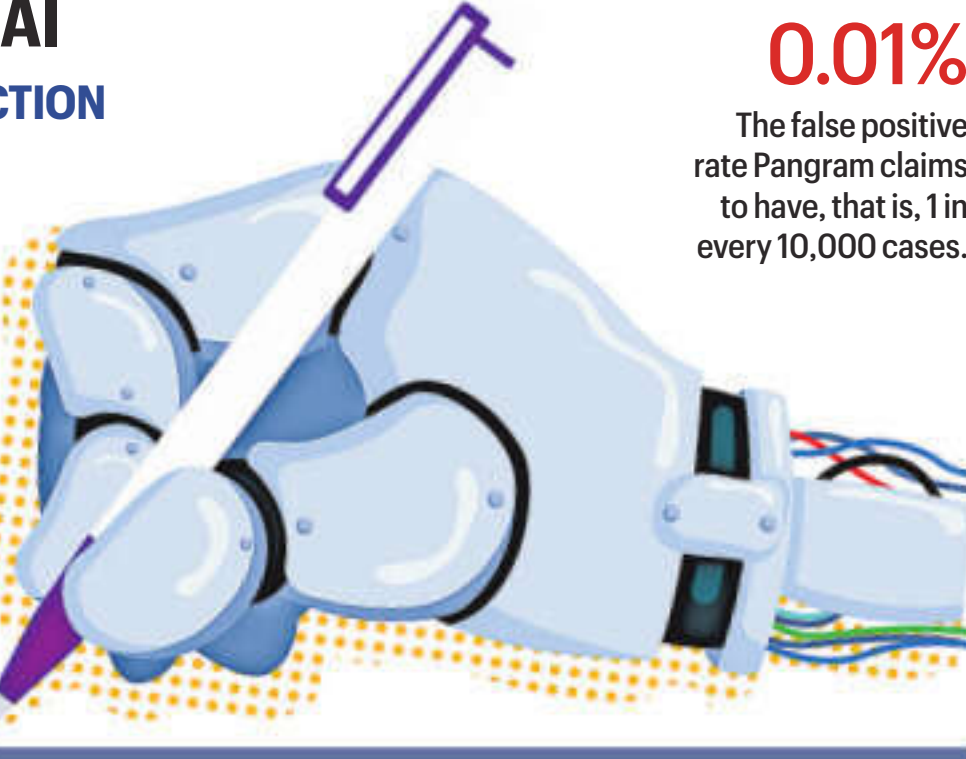
AI ‘TELLS’

- Refers to the signs that a piece of text is AI-generated.

- Excessive use of em dashes, or words not used generally in conversations.

- Text organised in bullet points, often with a heading of what the bullets are about.

- Negative parallelism, a rhetorical writing style marked by the formulaic “Not X, but Y” structure.



0.01%
The false positive rate Pangram claims to have, that is, 1 in every 10,000 cases.

marked by the formulaic “Not X, but Y” structure. “For instance, ‘These headphones are not just hearing devices, but sound-cancelling devices.’ Models are very commonly doing that now,” he said.

As to where these tells come from, Pruthi said research was ongoing but there were no clear answers yet.

“One common hypothesis is that after you pre-train a model, you post-train it to make it safe and useful and able to follow instructions. That’s typically done by contracting annotators and data vendors who create examples to answer questions of different types,” he said.

“A lot of those datasets, which are private and constructed by large frontier labs, have these cues. People who are writing those answers write in this way, and therefore models replicate that behaviour,” he added.

Can AI chatbots be good detectors?

Pruthi said people now want to move beyond this “binary framing” of what is AI versus human. “They are figuring out what the extent of collaboration is. Is it lightly assisted by an AI, moderately assisted by an AI, [or] heavily assisted by an AI?”

According to Pruthi, asking Claude, ChatGPT, or Gemini whether something is AI-written is a “very bad idea”. “The model is not specifically trained for this. So it might take an educated guess, but that isn’t going

Need for openness

Friedman said onus was on everyone in publishing or related fields to be on the same page, despite “very good reasons to be anti-AI”.

“I think just saying, ‘I don’t want to deal with it and you can’t make me’, seems childish or naive. At some point, you have to realise that this technology is here,” she said.

to be very accurate... This happens to be a task where you care about accuracy a great deal because of it being high stakes,” he said.

The other key difference, Pruthi said, is that a lot of detectors are tuned in such a way to ensure “false positives are low”. A false positive refers to an instance when a detector flags something human-written as AI-generated, as opposed to a false negative, wherein an AI-generated text might pass off as human.

AI detectors are also distinct from tools detecting plagiarism. Pruthi said since plagiarism largely concerns copying intellectual work without attribution, “plagiarism detectors tend to sophisticatedly score how well a given idea/work matches with existing work”. “On the contrary, AI detectors just try to estimate whether a piece of text could be AI-generated given lots of examples they’ve seen,” he said.

How reliable are these tools?

Pruthi said that Pangram — which claims a false positive rate of 1 in every 10,000 cases (0.01%) — is quite reliable, which was backed by some independent studies.

But he sounded a word of caution, saying that an ML model would “obviously not be 100% accurate all the time”. Using the analogy of spam classification in emails, he said: “We still develop ML models to detect what is spam and what is not. There too, the content, the words used, the way it is phrased — all that is helpful to figure out whether it is spam or not. We still get a few

examples wrong.”

This is because these tools have limitations. According to Pruthi, ML models are more likely to be wrong when there are fewer words, since there aren’t enough signs to tell confidently whether something’s AI-written or human-authored.

Another limitation is what Pruthi called “low-entropy text”, which refers to text that is generally precise and accurate in nature, and thus hard to classify.

“If I ask you, ‘Give me all the states of India in alphabetical order.’ This has one clear, definitive answer, whether from a model or a human,” he said.

Similarly, code — written instructions that tell a computer to execute a certain task — can also “be tricky to detect” at times. “There’s only a certain way it can be written,” Pruthi added.

Pruthi mentioned another limitation — one that he and his colleagues presented in a recent paper at an ML conference — in a scenario when one slightly polishes a piece of text using a language model. “Even though the base ideas and content were written by you, instead of saying that it is slightly edited or mixed text, models might flag it as fully AI-generated,” he said.

This can dissuade writers from even refining their writing using AI, out of fear that their work could be mistakenly flagged as AI-generated. “There’s a lot of AI slop on the internet right now. A lot of Kindle books that are published are fully AI-written,” he said. “So if a good detector is able to weed out most of that and at least label that this is AI-generated, then maybe a careful reader can choose not to consume that content. In some way, good AI detectors are helping channel attention to legitimately human-written content.”

How should writers, publishers navigate this?

Recently, Nobel Prize-winning Polish writer Olga Tokarczuk’s comments about using AI for research while writing her last novel had invited criticism. Tokarczuk later clarified she did not use AI in the writing process itself.

Jane Friedman, an American publishing professional with over two decades of industry experience, told *The Indian Express*, “Everyone needs to be on the same page about where these tools are touching the process and, to the best of everyone’s ability, track how they’re being used.”

“One of the problems here is that everyone is kind of doing their own thing behind the curtain. Part of that has to do with the taboo around it and everyone being uncertain about the technology and the different attitudes towards it,” she added.

SHIPPING

Why energy tankers are using risky dark fleet ploy to cross Hormuz

Sukalp Sharma

New Delhi, June 7

FOR YEARS now, ships involved in sanctioned and illicit trade have “gone dark” to avoid detection — that is, switched off their automatic identification system (AIS) transponders to make themselves virtually invisible to authorities and other vessels.

This dark shipping practice has largely been limited to the “shadow fleets” transporting sanctioned Iranian and Russian oil. But as the US-Iran war drags on, for energy tankers looking to sail through the blocked Strait of Hormuz, avoiding detection is increasingly becoming a necessity. This has brought this risky tactic out of the margins.

Surge in dark transits

According to International Maritime Organization (IMO) guidelines, AIS should always be in operation when a ship is sailing or at anchor, unless the master of the

ship decides that broadcasting the information is a threat to its safety or security.

Switching the transponder off makes the vessel untrackable and invisible to other ships’ systems, which can significantly increase the risk of collisions at sea. This risk becomes even greater in crowded waterways such as the Strait of Hormuz.

According to energy and freight markets analytics firm Vortexa, dark transits through the Strait of Hormuz — between March 1 and late May — represent 57% of all transits recorded over the period.

This trend of ships going dark while transiting the strait has intensified in recent weeks. The share of outbound laden vessels transiting dark stood at 58.5% in March, slightly dipped to 54% in April when vessel movements through the waterway picked up slightly through corridors regulated by Iran, and then rose sharply to 65.2% in May, as per Vortexa.

“Commercial operators are simulta-

India-bound ships too

- India depends heavily on the Strait of Hormuz, with over 40% of its oil imports, 60% of its LNG imports, and 90% of its LPG imports coming through this narrow passage.

- Many of the energy cargoes that have reached India via the Strait of Hormuz over the past three months went dark as they crossed the strait.

neously adapting both operationally and physically to the environment through prolonged dark operations, altered routing, escort behaviour, and possible vessel hardening measures. Taken together, the Strait of Hormuz is increasingly functioning as a contested low-visibility operating environment where commercial transit continues, but under growing military pressure, degraded transparency, and sustained enforcement risk,” maritime intelligence provider Windward said in a note last month.

Of the energy cargoes being transported by tankers that are going dark to cross the Strait of Hormuz, crude oil and condensates account for around 40%, ‘clean products’ (like petrol, diesel, jet fuel, and naphtha) account for about 25%, ‘dirty products’ (like bunker oil and bitumen) have a share of about 18%, and LPG accounts for about 14%, shows Vortexa data. LNG tankers, hitherto absent from dark shipping activity in the region, appear in

the data from April into May.

Accepted protocol

Ship tracking data shows that tankers belonging to or chartered by the national energy companies of countries such as the UAE, Qatar and Saudi Arabia are also going dark to cross the strait. In March, non-Iranian operators accounted for 37% of dark outbound laden transits through the chokepoint, which rose to 56% in April and 67% in May.

Vortexa analysis shows that UAE-linked vessels account for the largest share of dark transits at around 27%, followed by Iraq at about 11%, and Qatar at around 10%. Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and Bahrain together account for another 9%.

Experts point out that with global energy flows disrupted due to the crisis, there is increasing pressure on major energy producers from the Gulf to keep exports going to the extent possible.

LEGAL

For survivors of trafficking, SC plan focuses on consent, dignity

Amaal Sheikh

New Delhi, June 7

THE SUPREME Court last month said that considering that the “existing vacuum seriously impairs the fundamental rights” of the victims of trafficking for commercial and sexual exploitation (CSE), it was “left with no option but to pass detailed directions” by framing a Victim Protection Plan. This will operate until Parliament enacts a law on the protection and rehabilitation of victims of CSE.

Background

The litigation traces to a 2004 petition filed by Prajwala, a Hyderabad-based anti-trafficking organisation, which argued that victims of CSE were treated as “criminals” rather than “victims or survivors” and that the absence of a comprehensive “Victim Protection Plan” made rescue and rehabilitation efforts ineffective.

In December 2015, the SC disposed of the petition after noting that the government was committed to establishing an Organised Crime Investigation Agency (OCIA) and constituting an Inter-Ministerial Committee to prepare a comprehensive anti-trafficking law. But the OCIA proposal was dropped, with the Centre instead empowering the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to investigate trafficking offences in 2019. Prajwala returned to the SC in 2022, alleging non-compliance with the commitments on which the 2015 order rested.

Rehabilitation, no criminalisation

On dignity, the SC said that every person possesses dignity “simply because they are human”. Trafficking violates this directly as “the entire transaction proceeds as though their humanity is irrelevant and they are nothing more than mere objects”.

On rehabilitation, it held that victims of trafficking for CSE have a constitutional right to rehabilitation.

The bench examined Section 17 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act (ITPA), 1956, which governs what happens after a person is removed from a brothel during a raid. It noted that the provision treats women

trafficked into prostitution, a woman who was trafficked but later continued in sex work voluntarily, and a woman who entered sex work voluntarily, alike. A “one-size-fits-all approach” risks becoming “counterproductive” and “may violate their rights and dignity”.

The court held that magistrates must first conduct an inquiry to identify voluntary adult sex workers, for whom the question of “rescue” does not arise. Victims’ consent must be “the primary and governing consideration” in decisions on detention in a protective home or reintegration with family.

Debangana Chatterjee, assistant professor of social science at the National Law School of India University, told *The Indian Express* that the distinction the court draws between voluntary and involuntary sex work does not hold on ground. Consent, in practice, operates under what she described as “dire structural conditions” that make a clean determination of voluntariness difficult. “Unless you have a sense of what exactly ‘voluntary’ entails, this becomes really difficult to decipher.”

Victim Protection Plan

The plan states that victims should not be treated like criminals, and rehabilitation cannot be imposed without “free and informed consent”. The bench directed that anti-human trafficking units be headed by officers of Deputy Superintendent of Police-rank and be notified as police stations for registering and probing trafficking cases.

During rescue operations, victims are not to be arrested, subjected to verbal or physical abuse, or photographed and filmed in a manner that reveals their identity.

Post rescue, victims cannot be kept in lock-ups or detained overnight in police stations, must be provided legal aid, medical care and counselling, and must be produced before the appropriate authority without delay. Before ordering long-term custody or rehabilitation, magistrates are required to hear the victim and, where necessary, conduct an inquiry into whether an adult woman is engaging in sex work voluntarily.

GLOBAL

100 days of Iran war: Behind Tehran linking ceasefire more to Lebanon than Gaza



EXPERT EXPLAINS

BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH

AS THE US-Iran war touches 100 days, the two countries have entered into a new equation that rests on neither side breaking off talks substantially, while continuing to trade limited strikes at strategic targets. The Strait of Hormuz remains blocked.

Even as this equation represents Iran’s strengthened bargaining position, Tehran faces an urgent need to translate this leverage into tangible gains, not least due to its continuing economic crisis, with year-on-year inflation touching 80%.

Iran’s need for decisive outcomes

For Iran, Washington’s overall preference for relying on its own blockade of the Hormuz without a full-scale war (for which its munitions still run low) is a concern. As several analysts have noted, the more days pass before a decisive outcome for Iran (unfreezing Iranian funds, sanctions removal, an end to the US blockade), the longer the break in Iran’s strategy of maintaining multi-pronged pressure.

Ultimately, Hormuz restrictions are an indirect leverage — they are sufficient to deter full-scale American/Israeli attacks but evidently insufficient to force the US towards decisive concessions.

Hence, on June 5, Advisor to the Supreme Leader, Mohsen Rezaee, declared to *CNN* that the US failing to unfreeze \$24 billion in blocked Iranian assets and lifting the blockade would prompt Iran to expand its punitive actions to the Mediterranean, the Red Sea, and the Bab-el-Mandeb strait. Among Iran’s allies, while the Yemeni Houthis’ ability to threaten the latter two has been decisively proven, Lebanon’s Hezbollah maintains an underutilised ability to threaten military and commercial activity in the Mediterranean through its anti-ship cruise missiles.

However, while Iran maintains its reliance on UNGA Resolution 3314 to deem US bases in Arab countries as legitimate targets in response to limited US strikes on Iran, it is Israel’s war in Lebanon which potentially allows Tehran to generate new *casus belli*.

Despite a US-brokered ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon (Hezbollah) in April, Israel’s campaign in South Lebanon continued largely unabated, until Iran once again threatened to call off talks over it. By June 3, tripartite negotiations led to a joint statement by Israel, Lebanon, and the US, recommitting all parties to the April ceasefire. US President Donald Trump even said the US was “speaking to Hezbollah” and that he “would like to meet” Iran’s new Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei.

Linkage of US war with Israel’s in Lebanon

Lebanon is not important to Iran solely



An Israeli flag hangs on a destroyed building in southern Lebanon. AP

due to the formidable value that Hezbollah brings to Tehran’s strategic power projection. Presently, the Israel-Lebanon ceasefire has a new characteristic — a fragile agreement that Iran knows Israel will inevitably violate.

This provides Tehran a unique strategic option: to determine that Israel’s attacks in Lebanon warrant a tighter chokehold on Hormuz or a resumption of its missile attacks, at any point when Tehran perceives Washington to be slow-peddalling a deal.

Already by June 4, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi reaffirmed that “this war will end only when it ends in Lebanon as well”. Combined with Rezaee’s statements, it is clear that while protecting Hezbollah is a clear Iranian objective, Lebanon principally serves as a pressure point to force Washington towards concessions vis-à-vis Iran itself.

For perspective, Iran has refrained from officially linking the ceasefire with Israel’s war on Palestine, or at least making it an immediate imperative. Apart from reports from the semi-official *Tasnim News* that Tehran also requires Israel to cease hostilities in Gaza, Iran’s negotiating posture since April has prioritised Lebanon. This is despite Israel’s Gaza campaign pre-dating the current war on Lebanon, causing significantly greater casualty figures, and prompting in-

ternational investigations into Israeli conduct. Iran’s regional posture has also been articulated historically as integrally tied with Palestine (Jerusalem or Al Quds).

Among other things, this reinforces Iran’s awareness that Washington is more likely to pressure Israel on Lebanon than on Palestine; a compromise Iran is willing to make for its immediate strategic needs. The alternative would be a bogged-down Iran with reduced bargaining space in the face of the marginal likelihood of Israel withdrawing from Gaza, even if Tehran threatens military action.

Ultimately, these developments still retain both Iranian and American preference for a deal. However, it is now increasingly evident that just as Washington sought favourable terms through military action in March, Tehran is inching closer to adopting a similar posture. Functionally, this implies that organic pressures are building within the US-Iran equation that will either decisively break the ceasefire, or force Washington and Tehran into at least an interim arrangement, pending a larger deal.

Facing stress, economy will need a leg up

THE INDIAN economy grew at a healthy pace in the fourth quarter (January-March) of the last financial year (2025-26), despite the conflict in West Asia that had begun to cause widespread disruptions to global energy markets and trade towards the end of the quarter. GDP growth has been pegged at 7.8 per cent for the quarter by the National Statistics Office, driven by a buoyant services sector. This takes growth for the full year to 7.7 per cent — the highest in the last three years. However, at 8.9 per cent, nominal growth was the lowest. It was also significantly lower than the 10.1 per cent assumed in the Union budget.

The disaggregated data shows that the services sector grew at almost 10 per cent in the fourth quarter, with both segments — trade, hotels, transport, and communication and financial, real estate, IT and professional services — growing at a fairly healthy clip. Agriculture continued to hold up, while manufacturing growth slowed down. On the other hand, both private consumption and investment stayed steady. Growth over the full year — a period marked by tremendous uncertainty on the external front owing to Donald Trump’s tariff policies — is likely to have been supported by both fiscal and monetary policy. Measures such as the rationalisation of GST rates and low interest rates would have provided support to economic activities.

The outlook for the ongoing financial year (2026-27) is, however, less buoyant. In the June Monetary Policy Committee meeting, the RBI has projected the economy to slow down to 6.6 per cent this year, down from its earlier assessment of 6.9 per cent. This implies that growth this year is likely to be around 1.1 percentage points lower than last year. Some estimates are more pessimistic. Higher energy and commodity prices and continued supply chain disruptions, along with the possibility of a weak monsoon season, are heavily weighing down expectations. Economic momentum is expected to be particularly hit during the first half of the year. Growth is expected to slow down, while inflation is likely to edge upwards. Much will depend on how long the conflict in West Asia drags on. Then there is the stress on the balance of payments and the currency to contend with. On their part, the Union government and the RBI have taken several steps to shield the economy during this period of stress. Last week, measures were announced to attract foreign capital and ease the pressure on the rupee. But, considering the severity of the situation, more steps may be needed.

Rain & fertiliser shortfall can be an opportunity

INDIA’S FARM sector grew by 4.2 per cent in 2024-25 and 3.2 per cent in 2025-26 on the back of two good monsoon years. Rainfall for the country as a whole was 104 per cent of its long period average (LPA) in 2024 and 110 per cent in 2025, with the southwest monsoon season (June-September) alone registering nearly 8 per cent surplus precipitation in both years. This year, the prognosis isn’t great due to an El Niño, expected to return after a strong event from around June 2023 to April 2024. Global models indicate a weak-to-moderate El Niño developing in the current monsoon season. The India Meteorological Department has already forecast a below-normal monsoon, with overall rainfall at 90 per cent of LPA for the four-month season.

But the hit to agriculture may not come in the kharif crop season, whose plantings have just about commenced and will pick up as the monsoon advances. The real impact might be during the rabi (winter-spring) season, with strong-to-very strong El Niño conditions projected to emerge through November-January. El Niño is known to not only suppress the monsoon rainfall but also lead to warmer and shorter winters in India. If its intensity is relatively mild during the monsoon months and peaks after November, the rabi crops are the ones that will bear the brunt. The same goes for fertilisers, where the stocks seem reasonably comfortable to meet the requirements of the kharif season. The effects of the supply shock from the ongoing West Asia conflict and blockade of the Strait of Hormuz may be felt only in rabi. This applies even to food inflation, which has not spiralled so far (unlike energy, metals or industrial raw materials), thanks to record 2025-26 crop production levels both in India and globally.

India should turn the potential double whammy of rain and fertiliser shortfalls into an opportunity. The country imported an all-time-high 16.9 million tonnes (mt) of vegetable oils in 2025-26 and 7.3 mt of pulses the previous fiscal. The Narendra Modi government must work towards making 2026 India’s year of millets, pulses and oilseeds, which also consume less water and fertilisers — especially urea (nitrogen) — than rice, wheat or sugarcane. Indian farmers respond well to price signals. They will grow these crops once assured of minimum support prices (MSP), either through direct government procurement or payment of difference over open market rates. Such MSP assurance should, however, be conditional upon cost/market-driven pricing of water and fertilisers, which will promote efficient use of these scarce resources.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



The Editorial Page

MONDAY, JUNE 8, 2026

Amid global shocks, activate growth drivers within domestic control

THE GROWTH-inflation mix is set to worsen for India this fiscal year, largely due to the West Asia conflict and expectations of a sub-par monsoon — factors not in our control. The longer the conflict persists, the greater the risk to growth and upside to inflation.

To be sure, GDP growth was unscathed in 2025-2026, according to the latest estimates of the National Statistical Office (NSO), despite the tariff turbulence of 2025 and the conflict, which began towards the end of February this year.

The NSO now sees GDP growth for the year at 7.7 per cent, slightly higher than the second advance estimate of 7.6 per cent released in February. The print is above the potential growth rate of 7 per cent noted in the recent Economic Survey and much stronger than projected by policymakers and analysts at the beginning of the year.

The revision is not unusual, considering the February estimate was based on incomplete information for the fourth quarter. High-frequency indicators such as auto sales and retail credit growth indicate domestic demand held up during the quarter. But what really makes the performance stand out is a combination of sustained high growth — measured through rebased GDP — and benign inflation, at a lower-than-expected 2.1 per cent.

Several factors helped sustain growth despite adverse external conditions. The impact of high tariffs imposed by the US was lower than initially feared as exporters front-loaded shipments. Services exports remained robust, while exemptions for fast-growing sectors such as electronics helped limit the damage. Low crude oil prices and a normal monsoon — the “good luck” factor for India — supported growth and kept inflation under control.

Policy interventions contributed, too. Rate cuts by the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee supported financial conditions and demand. Fiscal measures, including rationalisation of GST rates, income tax relief and an increase in direct benefit transfers at the state level, provided additional support. These measures helped strengthen household purchasing power and business sentiment. Private consumption and investments emerged as the primary drivers last year, growing at 7.7 per cent and 8.2 per cent respectively.

Cut to this fiscal year. The ride is becoming more labourled. Growth expectations are being lowered as downside risks to the economy begin to materialise.

Crisil expects GDP growth to slow to 6.6 per cent from 7.7 per cent last year. The RBI, in its June monetary policy, also pared its growth outlook to 6.6 per cent, while keeping rates and stance unchanged. A slew of measures announced by authorities was aimed at encouraging foreign capital inflows, which, along with a depreciating rupee, have been a wrinkle in an otherwise healthy macroeconomic story.

Though the government is likely to maintain its investment momentum, a pick-up in private corporate investment will be delayed due to a highly uncertain environment.

Inflation, on the other hand, will move up to 5.1 per cent, with risks tilted to the upside. Despite the slowdown in real GDP, the nominal GDP growth is set to be higher due to higher inflation based on both the Wholesale Price Index (WPI) and Consumer Price Index (CPI).

The main reason for the worsening growth-inflation mix is the West Asia conflict that has brought



DHARMAKIRTI JOSHI

The expected slowdown in major export destinations, could reduce opportunities for goods exports. Also, the two ‘good luck’ factors that supported growth and kept inflation benign last year have turned adverse

a major energy shock and a wider trade disruption. It has led to a sharp rise in freight and insurance costs, intensified uncertainty and, coming on top of the unresolved tariff shock of 2025, rendered the external environment more challenging.

The expected slowdown in major export destinations, including the US, Europe and West Asia, will likely reduce opportunities for India’s goods exports. Also, the two favourable “good luck” factors that supported growth and kept inflation benign last year have turned adverse.

Crude oil is expected to average \$90-95 per barrel this fiscal, compared with \$70 last fiscal. India’s high dependence on imported energy increases its vulnerability to both price increases and supply disruptions. Higher costs reduce availability of energy at affordable prices and weigh on growth, particularly in manufacturing, construction and services such as travel, transport and restaurants.

The forecast of El Niño reducing rainfall to 90 per cent of the long-period average could become another headwind to both growth and inflation. Although the development of the Indian Ocean Dipole can provide some offset, it is a bit early to predict how this will play out. The risks from monsoons remain tilted to the downside.

Crisil’s Financial Conditions Index shows the conflict significantly tightened India’s financial conditions in March and April through capital outflows, sharp depreciation of the rupee and rising bond yields. Tighter financial conditions can affect borrowing costs, investment decisions and overall confidence.

The upside risks to inflation have started materialising, with the pressure currently more visible in wholesale inflation than retail in-

● **WORDLY WISE**
Sowing is not as difficult as reaping.
— Johann Wolfgang von Goethe

flation. WPI inflation, which is directly affected by global commodity shocks, came in at 8.3 per cent in April, while CPI inflation remained benign at 3.5 per cent.

We expect CPI inflation to rise to 5.1 per cent as manufacturers pass on higher input costs to consumers. The government has also begun passing through higher crude prices to petrol and diesel, which will have both direct and indirect effects on inflation. A weaker rupee further raises the risk of imported inflation.

Food inflation may also come under pressure due to disrupted agricultural production from heatwaves and expected below-normal rainfall. The household survey of inflation expectations released alongside the June monetary policy report suggests rising inflationary expectations.

On the positive side, Crisil Ratings notes that strong balance sheets, with the median debt-to-equity ratio currently at a low of 0.45, provide a cushion to a majority of medium and large corporates.

However, the policy space to support growth through easy monetary policy has evaporated because of rising inflation risks. Fiscal policy will need to balance several priorities: Supporting MSMEs, managing a higher fertiliser subsidy bill and accelerating efforts to improve energy security and affordability.

With the rising frequency of global shocks and geopolitical reset towards protectionism, this is the moment to activate medium-term growth drivers that are within domestic control. Removing the bottlenecks in the economy, fast-tracking ease of doing business and pushing ahead with remaining reforms will be crucial to revive private capex and realise the export potential of recently signed foreign trade agreements.

The writer is chief economist, Crisil

Let’s resist easy indictments of Indian Knowledge Systems



SWATI RAMANATHAN AND RAMESH RAMANATHAN

YOGENDRA YADAV is among modern India’s serious public intellectuals. He brings depth and domain knowledge to most subjects he writes about. But Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS), to our understanding, is not one of them. This is only reasonable, given the scale and complexity of the topic.

Yadav begins a recent article (‘State push for Indian knowledge systems is a farce. But dismissing them is a mistake’, *IE*, May 19) with a disparaging critique of state patronage for IKS as “a state-sponsored farce”. But can it happen without state leadership? Globally, every major intellectual and cultural shift has required not just social energy but political leadership as well. Many of us disagree with the BJP on many counts. But its centrality in creating the context for the recent flowering of IKS activity is hard to dispute. The larger issue, though, is not political. It is intellectual.

Yadav makes several critiques of the current IKS effort — that it is backward-looking, overly text-based, dismissive of oral traditions, excessively Brahmanical (read Sanskrit), and seeks validation through Western categories. Essentially, IKS is little more than a selective glorification of ancient Sanskrit texts, dismissive of, in his words, “farming and artisanal communities that we call uneducated and backward”.

But who is making this argument? There is no prescribed pedagogy for IKS. No scholar or practitioner suggests Indian knowledge systems begin and end with Sanskrit. We ourselves support an open-source IKS initiative focussed precisely on the oral and folk traditions Yadav describes as ignored. That work is independent of the state, but exists because of the opening the state created.

Yadav’s indictment of Sanskrit reflects an old intellectual habit. Part of this is Dravidian politics. But part of it comes from the long shadow of the Macaulay project. Even while critiquing the “pathetic political project” of seeking validation from the West, Yadav wants IKS to be “future-oriented” and “connected to modern science” — categories emerging from a Western framework.

Can we really imagine a serious, vibrant IKS without the richness, diversity and depth of Sanskrit material? Tamil, Bhakti, Buddhist, Jain and countless vernacular traditions all carried deep philosophical and spiritual insight. But Sanskrit functioned as a connective layer — a space where India debated consciousness, selfhood, ethics, reality and liberation in a systematic way.

Acharya Tripathi’s book, which Yadav praises, is about India as a knowledge culture in which Sanskrit is connective tissue across regional streams of meaning-making; his larger concern is the rupture colonial education inflicted on that inheritance. Similarly, Allama Prabhu and Basavanna, in the 12th century, were not seeking to dismantle Sanskrit civilisation. Their Kannada *vachana* movement was a spiritually grounded social reform emerging from Indic traditions.

This is not to deny the historical exclusions of Sanskrit and Brahmanical learning. But Vivekananda, Sri Aurobindo and scholars like Kapil Kapoor pointed to a balanced approach. Vivekananda’s answer was not to reject Sanskrit but to take knowledge beyond enclosures and make it available to all. Aurobindo warned that “it will not be a good day for India when the ancient tongue ceases entirely to be written or spoken”.

The contrast with the West is striking. Through the Renaissance, Enlightenment, Romanticism, modernity and postmodernity, it kept engaging its classical inheritance. Greek and Latin were critiqued and reinterpreted, but never treated as foreign to the civilisation that grew from them. India, unusually, developed a habit of separating Sanskrit from the living traditions around it.

The IKS movement marks the beginning of something important — not a triumphalist declaration of past glory, but a serious effort to rediscover, study, debate, and revive India’s own knowledge traditions. The process will be messy. There will be exaggerations, oversimplifications and political appropriations. But the answer cannot be to retreat into strawman arguments.

The writers are co-founders of JANA Group. Views are personal.

What the Pope talks about when he talks about dignity



PIUS V THOMAS

THE CONCEPT of human dignity mediates and negotiates all rights. It encourages a closely and widely woven network of recognition and democratic inclusion. It is in this context that the encyclical of Pope Leo XIV, titled *Magnifica Humanitas*, becomes significant and worthy of debate. The crucial message of the encyclical is that governments should “regulate AI companies, protect workers who are displaced by AI, and ensure humans retain oversight of autonomous weapons”. “The primary choice is not between a ‘yes’ or ‘no’ to technology,” the Pope writes, “but rather between constructing Babel or rebuilding Jerusalem”.

As Anna Rowlands, theologian at Durham University, says, the encyclical challenges society to reflect on questions such as, ‘What do we think human life is?... What vision and goal are we aiming for in our humanity and in our lives together?’ The Pope’s answer is “a rather beautiful vision of a civilisation of love”. The encyclical “urges humanity to recover a shared moral imagination, especially a way of seeing one another and the world that recognises the inherent value of the human person”.

It is interesting to read how such a stance can make Pope Leo a moral voice that can speak to the search for social justice and a harmonious coexistence. He reminds us that every civilisation and culture appears to present a story of growth from “disvalue” to “value”, from chaos to order. This is a spectrum. The disvalue-value structure ranges from self-aggrandisement to a sense of mystery and a genuine/creative idea of human ignorance when it comes to the claims of ultimate knowledge (as with Socrates) on the one side, and the rules and rituals of social formation and structural efforts to control and govern in accordance with enlightened ideas on the other. Our concept of god will tell who we are (even atheists fall into this litmus test, as most of the time atheistic “no-god” statements end up in some other god(s)). The biggest problem of technological civilisation and the currently dominant system of liberal-advanced capitalism is that it dehumanises people (Gandhi was a staunch critic of this system).

Democracy, therefore, should go beyond being a mere political system and become an effort to create new humanising values to reinforce peace and non-violence.

A deep sense of the dignity of all life will also act as a caution against slavery of all kinds. Uncontrolled manipulation of AI, driven by greed, may result in a form of human slavery. The dignity approach foresees this, acknowledges the irresponsible behaviours of the past, and recognises the threats of the future. Leo XIV issued an apology for the Holy See’s role in legitimising slavery. It is as Dostoyevsky says: “I did not bow down to you; I bowed down to all the suffering humanity.” Human dignity can enable the ability to apologise and propose pacifism and non-violence as the new pillars for a democratic and just coexistence.

The writer is professor, Department of Philosophy, Assam University, Silchar

40 YEARS AGO

June 8, 1986



Ten shot dead in Punjab

TEN PERSONS were killed by suspected terrorists in the past 24 hours in different places in Punjab. Suspected terrorists opened Sten gun fire on people who had come to buy ice from a factory at Duburji village near Amritsar, killing five and injuring several others. Rahim, an Iranian student who had come on a motorcycle to Punjab University, Patiala to seek admission for a PhD, was killed by the terrorists.

\$4 billion aid for India

INDIA WILL receive about \$4 billion from the Aid India consortium in 1986-87. The consortium of Western aid donors will meet

in Paris on June 16 and probably agree on a figure close to the \$3.9 billion India received last year. And the consortium will probably warn India to improve its export performance, increase the efficiency of its high-cost public-sector industries and so reduce its existing trade gap.

Queen urges sanctions

QUEEN ELIZABETH II has urged the British Prime Minister, Margaret Thatcher, to agree to economic sanctions against South Africa, the newspaper Today reported. A signed front-page article that did not quote sources said the Queen gave Thatcher a “discreet warning” during a private audience recently at Buckingham Palace. It was

only the third time in her 34-year reign that the Queen had made known her dissatisfaction with government policy, the paper said.

More AIDS cases in TN

NINE MORE sex workers in Tamil Nadu are confirmed to have been infected with AIDS, said Dr Eric Simoes of CMC, Vellore. Six cases were reported earlier. Dr Simoes said 19 others whose blood samples indicated infection were awaiting confirmation. Their blood samples had been sent to the National Institute of Health in the US. The samples were obtained from various parts of Tamil Nadu where AIDS infection was fairly widespread.



Policy is undoing what science built. That's a challenge for Cotton Productivity Mission



FROM PLATE TO PLOUGH
BY ASHOK GULATI, AYUSHI GUPTA AND RITIKA JUNEJA

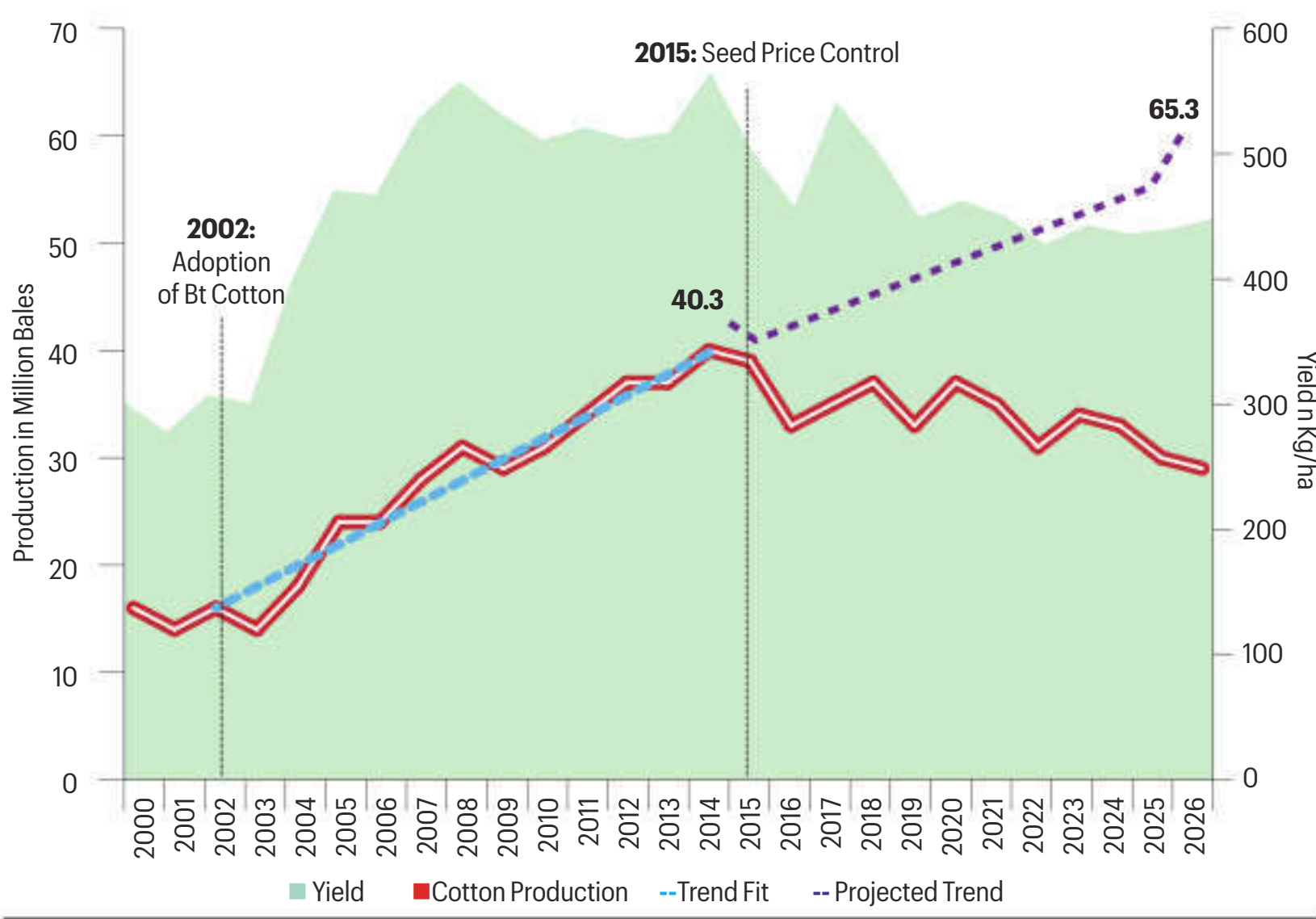
IN APRIL 2026, the Union Cabinet approved the Mission for Cotton Productivity with an outlay of Rs 5,659 crore, to run from 2026-27 to 2030-31. The intent is to raise lint productivity from 441 kg per hectare (in triennium ending (TE) 2025-26) to 755 kg/ha by 2031. But to understand whether this mission can succeed, it is worth recalling where India once stood and how deep the crisis in cotton fields runs.

In 2002, Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee approved the commercial cultivation of Bt cotton as cleared by the Genetic Engineering Appraisal Committee (GEAC). At the time, he said: "The next big revolution that is unfolding in the world is the biotechnology revolution. This is going to touch the lives of ordinary people in ways that we cannot even fully imagine today. We must not lag behind others in this revolution. India should aspire to be one of the leaders of this revolution. We must plant its healthy saplings in different parts of the country so that we can reap their fruits soon."

India did not lag behind. For a decade, it led. The first Bt hybrids incorporating the cryIAc gene were approved to resist the bollworm complex. By 2006, GEAC had approved Bollgard II, a second-generation hybrid with two stacked genes. The results were unambiguous. Cotton production rose from 13.6 million bales in 2002-03 to 39.8 million bales in 2013-14, a 193 per cent increase. Annual output grew at 10 per cent, and area expanded by 56 per cent, from 7.6 million hectares (mha) to 11.9 mha. Yields improved by 88 per cent, from 302 kg/ha to 566 kg/ha. India became the largest producer and second-largest exporter of cotton. A technology decision taken by Vajpayee triggered an agricultural revolution. But thereafter, the policies by successive governments, both at the state and central levels, undid what science had built.

After Bollgard II, Mahyco-Monsanto

● PRODUCTION AND YIELD OF COTTON IN INDIA



Biotech (MMB) India developed the next generation: Bollgard II with Roundup Ready Flex, and Bollgard III, incorporating three stacked genes with herbicide-tolerant traits designed to address evolving pest resistance and rising weed-management costs. But they were not released.

What killed them was a sequence of price-control decisions that made seed innovation commercially unviable. In 2006, Andhra Pradesh imposed a Maximum Retail Price of Rs 750 per packet, less than half the prevailing price of Rs 1,600, of which Rs 1,250 had been charged by MMB as trait fee. Maharashtra and Gujarat swiftly matched the cap. In 2015, the Centre formalised this through the Cotton Seed Price Control Order, slashing the trait fee by 74 per cent from Rs 186.95 to Rs 49 per packet. In 2018, the national retail price was cut further to Rs 740. By 2020, the trait fee had been abolished entirely.

The consequence was direct. Faced with unfriendly regulation,

Had India continued on the production trajectory between 2002 and 2014, cotton output in 2026 would have reached 65.3 million bales. The actual figure in 2025-26 is 29 million bales. The gap is the accumulated cost of a decade of policy failure

Monsanto withdrew Bollgard II-RRF from GEAC consideration. Meanwhile, advanced agricultural economies routinely plant Bollgard 3 ThryvOn with XtendFlex, a platform combining three-gene caterpillar protection, built-in biological defence against sucking pests, and tolerance to three separate herbicide groups simultaneously. Brazil, where 92 per cent of cotton is rainfed, has deployed technology and seed innovation to the point where 60 per cent of cotton-planted area supports a second crop within the same agricultural year.

Today, India is not a leader of the biotechnology revolution in agriculture. It's not even a serious participant.

Look at the productivity of cotton: Australia: 2,340 kg/ha; China: 2,311 kg/ha; Brazil: 1,943 kg/ha, and the United States: 976 kg/ha. These are lint yields for the TE 2025-26, reported by the International Cotton Advisory Committee. And India, which has the largest cotton-growing area in the world (11 million hectares), has a yield of just 441 kg/ha.

The gap between India and its competitors is a precise measure of the gap in technology adoption, research investment, and regulatory ambition.

What is painful to see is that since 2014-15, production has declined at an average annual rate of 2 per cent. Had India merely continued on the production trajectory established between 2002 and 2014, cotton output in 2026 would have reached 65.3 million bales. The actual figure in 2025-26 is 29 million bales. The gap, 36.3 million bales, is the accumulated cost of a decade of policy failure. India went from a net cotton exporter to importing 4 million bales in 2025-26. It won't take long for India to become a large importer of cotton if business as usual continues.

It is against this backdrop that one needs to evaluate the Cotton Productivity Mission. The Mission's intent is welcome, but does it have the technology that global giants provide? The simple answer is "no". How it will achieve the productivity target of 755 kg/ha by 2031 remains to be seen. And even if it does, it would still leave India at less than half of what Brazil, China, and Australia have achieved today. How will it compete with them?

Developing new seed varieties requires years of investment in plant breeding, biotechnology, and trait research, followed by a lengthy biosafety regulatory process with no guarantee of commercial approval. Without a policy framework that ensures adequate returns on that investment, private companies have no rational basis for undertaking it. Price controls that compress trait fees to zero do not merely limit profits; they eliminate the incentive to innovate at all.

The government, therefore, faces a clear choice. Either it restores the intellectual property framework that allows private innovators to recover their costs, which means revisiting the Cotton Seed Price Control Order, or it commits to funding public sector R&D at a scale sufficient to fill the gap the private sector has vacated. What is not sustainable is the current arrangement, where price controls suppress private innovation, public R&D is chronically underfunded, and farmers are left with dated technology. Can the Cotton Productivity Mission undo this policy damage? Only time will tell.

Gulati is distinguished professor, Gupta a research associate, and Juneja a senior fellow at ICRIER. Views are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Gen Z's frustration

THE FIRST street protest staged by the nascent Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) in Delhi captured the imagination of the people ('At first protest, CJP calls for Pradhan's resignation, IE, June 7). The "cockroaches" moved from screens to streets. The BJP's electoral victories cannot obscure the fact of growing frustration and anger among the youth for a host of reasons, with limited job opportunities being a major concern. The protest has given some visibility to Gen Z's disillusionment with traditional politics.

G David Milton, Maruthancode

Restoring public trust

WHEN YEARS of effort and investment are undone by negligence, public trust in national examinations is eroded ('Impunity for exam leaks undermines trust', IE, June 6). Education cannot thrive on an ad hoc system. Restoring confidence in India's examination system will require not only strengthening institutional guardrails and technological platforms but also political accountability.

SS Paul, Nadia

Paper incentives

THE CENTRAL bank's decision to maintain a wait-and-watch stance while slashing GDP growth projections to 6.6 per cent exposes a structural trap. ('Rates on hold, focus on bringing foreign capital', IE, June 6). While the co-ordinated tax waivers on government bonds and concessionary forex swap facilities are administratively sound mechanisms to entice foreign portfolio investors, financial engineering alone cannot reverse a \$28.6-billion capital flight. Global capital chases robust ground-level economic vitality, not just subsidised hedging costs. Until domestic inflation settles permanently below the pump, fiscal concessions remain paper incentives against volatile global headwinds.

Krishan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi



PRIYANKA CHATURVEDI

ET TU, BRUTE? This iconic line from the play *Julius Caesar*, written in 1599 by William Shakespeare, is a reminder for anyone in politics that the ultimate betrayal does not come from one's enemies, but from one's closest allies. This is the everyday political reality in India, in this time of breaking news content. It is the age of "Shah Neeti".

A mere 24-hour window may see twists and turns, political parties losing, and engineered splits. In 2022, we saw how the Shiv Sena split. Of course, this wasn't a first in India's history — even Congress split in 1969. That, however, was an outcome of organisational revolt. In the Shiv Sena's case, it was an engineered revolt that then became a model to use against other regional parties. We are seeing it play out now in West Bengal with the All India Trinamool Congress.

In Shakespeare's play, the deepest wound to Caesar was not inflicted by steel blades, but by a single face among the crowd of assassins: Marcus Brutus, his protégé and trusted friend. With that final, heartbreaking realisation, the Roman dictator stopped fighting and succumbed to the daggers. The scene is a haunting reminder that in the theatre of power, the sharpest betrayal is always the one you never saw coming.

As a member of the united Shiv Sena, I watched every day as party

I watched everyday as party members chose sides during the unfolding saga. Some were pushed, others lured, some had pending cases, some just wanted to align with the powers-that-be

members chose sides during the unfolding saga. Some were pushed, others lured, some had pending cases, some just wanted to align with the powers-that-be. The people I had come to lean on, who I thought would stay on our side, would, within the next hour, move to the other side. After the split, there was a meeting of party office bearers at Shiv Sena Bhavan when we were briefed about the next steps of the party; someone who was a minister in the MVA cabinet and who was most engaged during the meeting was on a flight to Guwahati within a few hours. We could only watch the visuals and be surprised at the audacity. With every new exit, though, the shock turned to numbness.

Having seen this in my party, I can relate to the AITC's current problem as many of those who were once fiercely loyal have started to express anguish with the party's functioning. It always begins the same way. Of course, some grievances could be genuine. But when it becomes a template before every party split, it shows that "Shah Neeti" is at work. The party led by Mamata Banerjee has the stomach to fight on, and she will certainly rebuild and resurrect. I recall my party president, Uddhav Thackeray, once saying that old leaves need to fall in order for new ones to

As TMC weakens within, I remember Shiv Sena split

grow. This is how we live to fight another day.

The current way of doing politics doesn't shock people anymore. It has become a spectator sport, with real-time betting regarding the movement of individuals, amid source-based media speculation. Politicians who have long been part of the system see immediate rewards being handed out — corruption cases closed, tickets handed out, a ministerial berth or standing committee chairmanship offered as a quid pro quo — and then switching becomes lucrative. Many justify this as political survival. In real terms, however, it is about opportunities, because having an ideology now means hanging on to perks rather than fighting a battle of ideas.

The new politics also has a curated "party split option", which can be chamber-specific, like how the AAP was split up only for the Rajya Sabha. The formula involves getting two-thirds of either the political party itself or its representatives in the Assembly or Parliament. It is a game of numbers that can even end with the party name and symbol being handed over to the rebels.

The dynamics of the AITC and Shiv Sena are different. But what remains the same is how an exodus is manoeuvred and a split is engineered using the Brutuses within.

The writer, a former Rajya Sabha MP, is with Shiv Sena (UBT)

Who gets rupee right: Economists, market wallahs or moralists?



ISHAN BAKSHI

IN TIMES of crisis, advice, often unsolicited, tends to pour in from all quarters. This time is no different. Economists, market *wallahs* and moralists — all have given their two cents on how the ongoing crisis ought to be tackled. What they have proposed, though, has been largely at odds. That should not be surprising. After all, the advice that is given, as is often the case, depends on where you sit.

Economists have, by and large, stuck to orthodoxy — that the central bank should not defend the rupee. It should neither draw down its forex reserves nor should it raise interest rates to defend the currency. An inflation-targeting central bank should focus on inflation, not the exchange rate. The rupee should, instead, be left to find its own level. A weaker currency would, at the very least, help maintain the competitiveness of the country's exports. It would also make Indian assets such as stocks and bonds cheaper in dollar terms, increasing their attractiveness for foreign investors.

Efforts to defend the currency are, in any case, likely to be futile as the rupee's problems run deep. The energy shock that has exposed India's vulnerability, the absence of a domestic AI play alongside the rapid global adoption of AI models that threatens India's growth engine, the possibility of the China+1 dream fading away and the risk-return calculus on domestic investments souring even for Indian firms — all raise deeper questions about the country's growth prospects. It is these concerns that have prompted a flight of capital and put pressure on the currency that need to be addressed, not the rupee's decline.

Market *wallahs*, including some from India Inc, however, have a different view, with many in favour of supporting the currency. Some have even called for raising interest rates to defend the currency. Never mind that the economy isn't overheating — core inflation (excluding precious metals) is around just 2.2 per cent. But, for them, "100" is not just another number. Worries of a vicious cycle — the decline in the rupee triggering more capital outflows, which in turn compounds



balance of payments pressures and further weakens the currency — have gained traction. The Indian markets, which find little mention among global investors at the moment, are fearful of a further loss of investor confidence. The defence of the currency is, in some sense, also a defence of the markets.

The Indian central bank has often tended to side with this line of thinking despite its pronouncements to the opposite.

There have been numerous episodes when, in the face of sustained depreciation pressures, it has intervened through various tools in order to defend the rupee — an approach it has pursued across governments of varying ideological dispositions.

But, if there is one thing that both economists and the market *wallahs* agree on, it is the need to facilitate foreign capital flows through various channels. While their preferences may differ, the proposals have ranged from eliminating taxes on investments of foreign institutional investors in markets to encouraging flows through FCNR deposits and/or ECBs, and facilitating greater FDI flows, among others. Some of these suggestions have been acted upon. On Friday, the government and the central bank announced a slew of measures to attract foreign capital. But the question is: In an environment where the India-US yield differential isn't that large, how much can be realistically mopped up? And would it be enough to ease the pressure? If not, will the RBI follow this up with an interest rate defence as the market *wallahs* have argued for?

The moralists, on the other hand, have a different take. In times of distress, personal sacrifices must be made, and those profiting, the speculators, must be punished. So, there is a need for market interventions and restrictions on economic activities, demands for austerity and exhortations to curb the use of foreign exchange.

Of course, the distinction between these categories isn't neat. Overlaps do exist. But all these groups are currently jostling to influence the direction of policy at this critical juncture for the Indian economy. At the moment, it does appear that the market *wallahs* and the moralists have the upper hand. They may well believe that their measures will help tide over this crisis. But any relief is likely to be short-lived. The focus should instead be on addressing the core issues facing the economy.

The writer is associate editor, The Indian Express

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NFHS-6 data on child nutrition has sobering warnings



URVASHI PRASAD

THE HEADLINE from NFHS-6 on child health is heartening. Stunting — children who are too short for their age — has declined nationally from 35.5 per cent to 29.3 per cent. That is a substantial improvement and deserves recognition. However, read in full, NFHS-6's child nutrition story presents a more complicated picture: National gains are uneven, several large states have deteriorated, and key drivers of child nutrition remain deeply concerning.

Severe wasting, the most dangerous form of acute malnutrition, declined from 7.7 per cent to 5.2 per cent. This is a meaningful gain that should translate into fewer child deaths.

Yet overall wasting fell only marginally, from 19.3 per cent to 19 per cent, meaning nearly one in five Indian children under five remains acutely malnourished. The proportion of underweight children moved from 32.1 per cent to 31.8 per cent. Nearly one in three Indian children is still underweight.

The state-level data is even more troubling. In Jharkhand, underweight prevalence increased from 39.4 per cent to 41.1 per cent. In UP, wasting rose from 17.3 per cent to 19.2 per cent and underweight from 32.1 per cent to 34.5 per cent. Rajasthan recorded similar deterioration, with wasting rising from 16.8 per cent to 19.8 per cent and underweight from 27.6 per cent to 33.3 per cent. These setbacks in some of India's largest states are obscured by the national headline.

The stunting figure itself conceals wide disparities. Kerala's stunting rate is 20.1 per

cent, compared with 35.6 per cent in Bihar and 35 per cent in Jharkhand. The gap reflects two very different childhood realities under the same national programmes. Jharkhand's wasting rate stands at 22.3 per cent, more than double Kerala's 10.9 per cent, and virtually unchanged from NFHS-5's 22.4 per cent despite four years of programme implementation.

Only 15.3 per cent of children aged 6-23

Breastfeeding remains one of the most evidence-backed, low-cost public-health interventions available. Its decline in states with high malnutrition burdens is a serious policy failure

months receive an adequate diet, up from 11 per cent. This is progress, but it still means more than eight in 10 children during the most critical developmental period are not receiving what nutrition science recommends. Dietary adequacy is only 8.7 per cent in Rajasthan and 11.9 per cent in Bihar. The decline in stunting has occurred despite this gap, not because it has been resolved.

Perhaps the most worrying finding is breastfeeding. Exclusive breastfeeding among infants under six months has fallen nationally from 63.7 per cent to 55.8 per cent. In UP, it has dropped from 59.7 per cent to 46.6 per cent. Jharkhand and Rajasthan have also seen sharp declines. Kerala, in contrast, improved from 55.5 per cent to 72.7 per cent. This suggests the problem is not institutional delivery but postnatal support after discharge. Breastfeeding remains one of the

most evidence-backed, low-cost public-health interventions available, benefiting both child survival and maternal health. Its decline in states with high malnutrition burdens is a serious policy failure.

There are clear successes. Full vaccination coverage increased from 83.8 per cent to 87.1 per cent, while rotavirus vaccine coverage surged from 36.4 per cent to 85.4 per cent, reflecting effective national rollout.

NFHS-6 confirms India can reduce stunting. But wasting, dietary inadequacy and declining breastfeeding remain major risks. Whether the next NFHS shows continued progress on stunting will depend on whether these warning signs are addressed now.

The writer is senior fellow, Pahle India Foundation and former director, office of vice chairperson, NITI Aayog



The site of a Russian strike, in Zaporizhzhia, Ukraine on Sunday. REUTERS

Starmer hosts Merz, Zelenskyy & Macron as Russian strikes kill three in Ukraine

Associated Press
London, June 7

A RUSSIAN drone strike killed three people waiting at a bus stop in southeastern Ukraine on Sunday, an official said, as British Prime Minister Keir Starmer hosts the leaders of Ukraine, France and Germany for talks on ongoing support for Kyiv.

Another person was wounded in the drone attack in Balabnye in Ukraine's southern Zaporizhzhia region, the head of the regional military administration, Ivan Fedorov, wrote on his Telegram channel.

A separate drone strike damaged a storage center for spent nuclear fuel in the Kyiv region, just 15 kilometers from the Chernobyl nuclear power plant, Ukraine's General Staff said. The attack sparked a fire that was extinguished within an hour. Radiation remains within safe levels, officials said.

The International Atomic Energy Agency chief Rafael Grossi said the incident was "deeply concerning" due to the large amounts of nuclear material held at the facility.

He said in a statement that the agency would visit the site of the attack soon.

The meeting on Sunday followed Starmer, French President Emmanuel Macron and German Chancellor Frie-

drich Merz comes in the wake of a large-scale Ukrainian drone attack that targeted Saint Petersburg, Russia's second-largest city, underscoring Kyiv's growing ability to hit deep inside Russia.

Governor Alexander Beglov said three people sustained minor injuries in Saturday's attack, during which residents were advised to stay indoors.

The UK, France and Germany, the so-called E3 group of European nations, have been prominent backers of Ukraine following Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022. The UK and France lead the "coalition of the willing" initiative to provide security guarantees for Ukraine as part of a peace process.

With the front line barely moving as swarms of drones hinder advances, both sides have sought an edge by launching long-range strikes. The war that followed Russia's invasion of its neighbor is more than four years old, with no end in sight.

The St Petersburg attack, which came less than 24 hours after the end of the city's flagship economic forum, was an embarrassing blow to Russian President Vladimir Putin's efforts to cast conflict as a distant event that doesn't affect daily life.

Putin on Friday rejected Zelenskyy's offer for a meeting, saying he sees "no point" in it.

US SAYS IT SHOT DOWN TWO MORE IRANIAN ATTACK DRONES

Israel strikes Beirut despite truce; Iran vows retaliation

Pak minister in Tehran to meet supreme leader

Reuters
Cairo, June 7

ISRAELI STRUCK the outskirts of Beirut on Sunday for the first time since the US announced a truce plan for Lebanon last week, and an Iranian lawmaker threatened to retaliate, putting talks to end the wider war into new jeopardy.

Iran has long said any peace deal with the United States would depend on a ceasefire also holding in Lebanon, which Israel invaded in March in pursuit of Iran-backed Hezbollah fighters who fired across the border in solidarity with Tehran.

There was no immediate formal response from Tehran to Sunday's Israeli strikes on the southern outskirts of Beirut, but influential headline Iranian lawmaker Ebrahim Rezaei posted on X that Iran would deliver a "decisive and painful response".

"Look at the sky of the occupied territories tonight," wrote Rezaei, who serves as the spokesperson for parliament's national security committee.

Washington and Tehran have shown little progress in reaching a deal to end the war that President Donald Trump launched in February with a campaign of air strikes alongside Israel against Iran. Trump has repeatedly threatened to restart the strikes unless there is an agreement soon.

"We're very close to a deal, or I'm going to blow the hell out of them," Trump told *NBC News* in an interview, broadcast to mark 100 days of the conflict. The comments were recorded on Friday and broadcast on Sunday as



People walk beneath a banner bearing portraits of Ayatollah Khomeini and the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Tehran. FILE

tional security committee.

Trump visited his New Jersey golf course.

Trump has leaned on Israel to scale back its campaign in Lebanon to allow room for a peace deal with Iran, including rebuking Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu with obscenities in a phone call last week.

After the call, Netanyahu called off air strikes on Beirut and agreed the latest truce plan with the Lebanese government.

But Israel has never fully halted its campaign in Lebanon, which has killed thousands of people and driven hundreds of thousands from their homes.

Hezbollah, which was not party to the truce and would be dismantled under its terms, has also continued attacks and says it will not give up its weapons unless Israel halts fighting and withdraws.

Netanyahu said Sunday's strike on Beirut's southern outskirts, a district known as Dahiyeh that has long been a Hezbollah stronghold, was ordered in response to Hezbollah firing.

The Israeli military had earlier said it had intercepted two projectiles fired over the border. It issued an evacuation order for the southern Lebanese city of Tyre and surrounding areas ahead of possible strikes there.

The wider war has been stalemated since the United States and Israel paused their attacks on Iran in early April, with Tehran blocking most shipping through the Strait of Hormuz.

Though the sides have both said they are close to a preliminary agreement that would reopen the strait, they have repeatedly traded strikes, with escalations in recent days that have included attacks on nearby Arab states hosting US bases.

US forces struck Iranian coastal radar sites in Goruk and Qeshm Island, both in Hormuz, early Saturday after shooting down drones launched by Iran

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Israel kills 9 in Gaza as Egypt holds truce talks

Hamas, Tel Aviv trade blame over ceasefire breach

Reuters
Cairo, June 7

ISRAELI STRIKES on a Hamas-run police station and a vehicle in the Gaza Strip killed at least nine people and wounded 20 others, health officials said, as mediators began new efforts to salvage a fragile US-brokered

ceasefire deal.

One strike hit a police post adjacent to a large tent encampment of displaced families in Khan Younis in the south of the enclave, killing five people and wounding 16 others, medics said. They did not say how many of the casualties were police.

Israel has stepped up attacks against police headquarters and personnel in the past several months, killing dozens of them, according to Hamas security officials.

Later on Sunday, another Israeli airstrike killed four people

and wounded four others when it hit a vehicle driving through the middle of Gaza City, medics said. The Israeli military did not comment on the incidents.

Egypt began hosting a new round of truce talks with leaders from Hamas and other Palestinian factions, sources from Hamas and other sources close to the negotiations said. The talks are expected to last for a few days.

Last year's deal established a Board of Peace led by Trump to oversee a phased ceasefire, opens new tab and was ratified

by the United Nations Security Council. However, many of the toughest areas of dispute, including the disarmament of Hamas, Israeli withdrawal and make-up of a Gaza government, were postponed to later in the process. The Board of Peace negotiators have been talking to both sides on the disarmament issue.

Hamas told envoys from the Board and mediators Egypt, Qatar and Turkey that ending Israeli attacks in Gaza was essential for any progress, sources close to the talks said.

With Xi in North Korea today, Kim to project confidence and defiance

Reuters
Seoul, June 7

NORTH KOREAN leader Kim Jong Un welcomes Chinese President Xi Jinping to Pyongyang on Monday, feeling in a position of strength with a firm ally in Russia, a nuclear arsenal and little apparent appetite to engage with Washington.

For Xi, leader of the world's second-biggest economy, the two-day visit to China's neighbour, his first in seven years, is part of an effort to draw Pyongyang back into its orbit.

Xi hosted Kim, among other leaders, at a massive military parade in Beijing last year, and the two countries have since resumed some passenger rail and air services.

This week's summit is likely to present a contrast to Xi's first visit to the isolated state in 2019 - months after a meeting between Kim and U.S. President Donald Trump fell apart over denuclearising North Korea and sanctions relief.

Since then, Kim has forged

E. EXPLAINED

Beijing renews push for Pyongyang

President Xi Jinping is visiting Pyongyang for a rare summit as Kim Jong Un leans on Russia, expands his nuclear arsenal and resists Washington. Beijing wants to pull North Korea back into its orbit, with talks expected to focus on economic cooperation, tourism and cautious regional diplomacy for now.

closer military and trade ties with Moscow, bolstered by his dispatch of troops to fight for Russia in the Ukraine war, continued to build up his nuclear capabilities in defiance of U.N. sanctions and locked down the North Korean border to stop the flow of escapees.

North Korea has sought to

flex its strength on the eve of Xi's arrival, announcing plans on Saturday for a 10,000-ton naval destroyer and reaffirming its status as a nuclear-armed state on Sunday.

"Having Xi visit Pyongyang is a big deal and the culmination of a good couple of 'comeback' years for Kim," said Andrew Gilholm, an analyst at consultancy Control Risks.

In 2019 Kim gave Xi a lavish reception that included thousands of people holding up placards that formed a picture of Xi's face and the Chinese flag, and a performance of the song "I Love Thee, China".

But relations between the two have been strained at times, particularly over North Korea's nuclear programme. Beijing has publicly opposed Pyongyang's nuclear tests and called for it to give up its nuclear weapons.

North Korea has been cautious about becoming over-reliant on China, with which it shares an 1,400-km (880-mile) border. Support from Russia is likely providing some balance.



Pope Leads Madrid Procession

Pope Leo XIV leads a Corpus Christi procession through Madrid's Plaza de Cibeles on Sunday, as an estimated 1.2 million people filled the square and surrounding streets for an outdoor Mass during the largest event of his weeklong visit to Spain. In his address, the Pope urged Catholics to live their faith by standing with the 'poor, the lonely and the forsaken'. REUTERS



Sam Smith editing audio tracks at his home in London. AP

guitarist: his hands. He released his debut album, "In the Springtime," in 2023, saying he wanted to give his two sons a

way to remember when he could perform and record music himself.

"I'd always written, I'd also

played, I always sung," he said. "And immediately it became clear to me that I was in trouble, that my music was going to be seriously compromised."

AI music generators use systems trained on large datasets of recorded music and audio. The platforms analyze patterns in melody, harmony, and rhythm before generating new audio based on prompts or uploaded recordings. Users don't need musical talent to end up with a serviceable song, or even a popular one.

Smith said producing convincing demos from the synthetic tracks the apps generated often required "50, 100, 150 attempts" and extensive editing

• BRIEFLY

SOUTH KOREA

Former Naver CEO named first female PM candidate in 20 years



Han Seongsok, South Korean Minister of SMEs and Startups. FILE

SOUTH KOREAN President Lee Jae Myung has chosen Han Seongsok, the country's minister for small and midsize businesses and startups, to be prime minister, the presidential office said on Sunday. If approved by parliament, Han would become South Korea's first female prime minister in 20 years. Han, who had also previously served as chief executive of South Korean internet giant Naver, is expected to lead the country's AI transformation, presidential chief of staff Kang Hoon-sik said at a press briefing. REUTERS

NIGERIA

Military rescues 360 hostages in Borno state

NIGERIA'S SECURITY forces have freed 360 men, women and children from a mountain hideout where they were held by kidnappers in Borno state in its northeast, after an intelligence-led operation, the military said on Sunday. The rescue operation was carried out by a joint task force that includes special forces, who forced the kidnappers to abandon their positions, the military said. REUTERS

UNITED STATES

12 injured after gunman opens fire at a festival

AT LEAST 12 people were wounded as gunfire erupted Saturday near a busy street festival in Ohio. Some people at the event in Toledo scrambled for cover while others rushed to help the victims. No suspects were in custody hours afterward, Toledo Deputy Police Chief Joe Heffernan said. He said it appeared that at least two people fired weapons and they were "probably shooting at each other." AP

• NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

PAKISTAN

Five killed in clash between rival groups

AT LEAST five people were killed and two injured in a deadly exchange of gunfire between rival groups over a land dispute in northwest Pakistan, police said Sunday. The incident occurred in Gul Kach area within the jurisdiction of Toi Khula police station in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. PTI

BHUTAN

Death sentence for couple in girl's rape, murder case

A COURT in Bangladesh on Sunday sentenced a couple to death for the rape and murder of an eight-year-old girl. The Dhaka Metropolitan Child Repression Prevention Tribunal handed down the sentence 19 days after the incident, which triggered nationwide outrage and protests. PTI

Bangladesh & Turkey agree to strengthen defence, political ties

Press Trust of India
Dhaka, June 7

BANGLADESH AND Turkey have reached an understanding to form a joint ministerial level committee on defence and foreign affairs to strengthen bilateral political cooperation.

The decision was announced Saturday after a meeting between Prime Minister Tarique Rahman and Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan, who arrived in Dhaka on a three-day visit.

"Bangladesh and Turkiye have decided to form a joint committee at the ministerial level on defence and foreign affairs to strengthen bilateral relations," the state-run BSS news agency reported quoting the prime minister's press wing.

The meeting decided to hold annual foreign office consultations between foreign and defence ministers of the two countries to further deepen the



Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan. FILE

"strategic relations," the press wing spokesman said.

Fidan said his visit constituted the first step towards elevating Bangladesh "Turkey relations to the 'strategic level'" as he simultaneously conveyed President Recep Tayyip Erdogan's greetings to Rahman.

The press wing said the prime minister's discussion with Fidan also focused on the Rohingya crisis, climate change, trade and investment, joint production and cooperation, and regional and international matters of mutual interest.

• AS PARKINSON'S PROGRESSIVELY ERODED HIS ABILITY TO PLAY GUITAR, MUSICIAN SAMUEL SMITH USED A.I.-GENERATED DEMOS TO HELP COMPLETE TRACKS ON HIS SECOND ALBUM, THE ART OF LETTING GO

He could no longer play guitar because of Parkinson's; AI helped him finish an album

Mustakim Hasnath
London, June 7

SAMUEL SMITH spent years writing songs with a guitar in his hands.

Now, the London-based singer-songwriter is using artificial intelligence tools to help him continue making Americana music after Parkinson's disease largely took away his ability to play guitar.

Smith, who was diagnosed with the progressive neurological disorder in 2020, recently released his second album, *The Art of Letting Go*. For one of the eight tracks, an instrumental piece titled *Horizon*, he relied on platforms that use AI to generate music to create demo arrangements that would convey his vision to the musicians who recorded the song.

The demos he created by humming rough melodies into his phone and uploading the recordings into song generators like Suno and Udio weren't for mixing into the final studio version of *Horizon*, Smith stressed. But tremors, stiffness and fatigue, which are common symptoms of Parkinson's, caused his guitar skills to deteriorate during the more than a year he worked on the album, he said.

"So then I'm faced with a question," Smith, 49, said. "Don't play, don't be creative, or find a way out, find a route."

And for me, this was the route."

Generative AI has divided the music industry, whose artists and record labels have complained of their copyrighted work being used to train the models behind AI-powered music tools. Sony Music Entertainment, Universal Music Group and Warner Records sued Suno and Udio in June 2024, although Universal later reached a settlement and partnership deal with Udio and Warner did the same with Suno.

Less discussed is what those platforms can do when employed by a serious musician like Smith, whose disease affects the tools central to his songwriting and identity as a



Sam Smith editing audio tracks at his home in London. AP

guitarist: his hands. He released his debut album, "In the Springtime," in 2023, saying he wanted to give his two sons a

way to remember when he could perform and record music himself.

"I'd always written, I'd also

played, I always sung," he said. "And immediately it became clear to me that I was in trouble, that my music was going to be seriously compromised."

AI music generators use systems trained on large datasets of recorded music and audio. The platforms analyze patterns in melody, harmony, and rhythm before generating new audio based on prompts or uploaded recordings. Users don't need musical talent to end up with a serviceable song, or even a popular one.

Smith said producing convincing demos from the synthetic tracks the apps generated often required "50, 100, 150 attempts" and extensive editing

"to get something that sounds close to my music." After humming a song into his phone and uploading the recording, he gives prompts describing instrumentation, mood and style.

"AI is not replacing anything for me," he said. "It's unlocking, it's enabling. It's allowing me to keep writing. I upload my lyrics; AI doesn't create my lyrics. I upload my music; AI does not create my music."

He added: "It then brings it to life in a way that I can play to session players and say, 'Here, that's what I'm thinking, that's what I'm hearing.'"

The album was produced by Grammy-winning pianist and producer Matt Rollings, who

assembled a group of established roots and bluegrass musicians for the project. They included dobro player and 16-time Grammy winner Jerry Douglas, Grammy-winning banjo player Alison Brown, fiddler Stuart Duncan, guitarist Bryan Sutton, bassist Viktor Krauss and singers Jonatha Brooke and Glen Phillips.

For Smith, the experience of singing in a Nashville studio alongside musicians he had admired for decades was "an extraordinary moment."

Smith said he thinks his experience demonstrated how AI could benefit society and expand creative access, if it's developed responsibly. AP

‘GOVT CAN ISSUE FOREIGN CURRENCY SOVEREIGN BONDS IF MORE STEPS NEEDED’

‘Forex measures, FII bond tax leeway could attract \$60-80 bn’

DEPENDING ON how they are executed and the final guidelines, India could see inflows to the tune of \$60 billion-\$80 billion from the various measures announced by the government and the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Friday to attract foreign capital — from the scrapping of capital gains and withholding tax on foreign institutional investors’ (FIIs) investment in government debt to concessional windows to boost foreign currency deposits and loans — according to Devang Shah, Head of Fixed Income at Axis Mutual Fund. And while these steps appear adequate, there remains space to take more action, if needed.

“Issuance of foreign currency sovereign bonds could serve as a supplementary step to finance the fiscal deficit, ease pressure on domestic yields, and support foreign inflows,” Devang Shah told Siddharth Upasani in an interview. Edited excerpts:

What is your estimate of the foreign inflows that we can see from the measures announced by the government and the RBI?

There were two sets of measures. The government removed capital gains and withholding taxes on government bonds. This itself is a positive measure which would attract flows and is expected to serve as a precursor to government bonds being included in Bloomberg’s indices. If that materialises, it could potentially result in additional inflows of

\$20 billion-\$25 billion.

Significant importance must also be attached to the second set of measures announced by the RBI such as the Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) deposits, for which the entire hedging cost will be provided. In addition, there is the concessional forex swap facility for External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) by Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs). While the final guidelines are awaited, it may be understood that the RBI would have received feedback from market participants for the same. If the concessional rates are sufficiently attractive, ECB borrowings by PSU lenders could become a significant avenue.

The combined impact of these two facilities could possibly bring in inflows of \$50 billion-\$55 billion, is our estimate.

Further, we believe that the removal of capital gains and withholding taxes is expected to deliver meaningful benefits over time. Yields in India have already increased notably, while the rupee has depreciated by over 15% in the past 18 months. At these levels, certain FIIs and hedge funds may find yields attractive. To summarise: \$30 billion-\$35 billion may come from FCNR(B) deposits, \$10 billion-\$20 billion from PSU ECBs, and \$20 billion-\$25 billion from the tax concessions and Bloomberg index inclusion.

In aggregate, this could translate into inflows of \$60 billion-\$70 billion over the next 12-18 months.



Are the withholding and capital gains taxes the only reason why FII holdings in Indian government debt have been so low? Or does more need to be done?

Several measures have been announced, and their effectiveness will depend on how they are executed before any additional steps are considered. However, if these measures do not prove as attractive as anticipated for any reason, and if the West Asia crisis remains unresolved, some pressure may emerge on the fiscal front.

At present, even after the recent increases in petrol and diesel prices, the Centre could face a shortfall of Rs 2.5 lakh crore-Rs 3 lakh crore. This gap may widen further if crude oil prices rise beyond \$100-\$110 per barrel. In such a scenario, the government could consider issuing foreign currency sovereign bonds.

While the measures announced so far appear adequate and could attract inflows in the range of \$60 billion-\$80 billion,

depending on execution and final guidelines, there remains room for additional action if required. Issuance of foreign currency sovereign bonds could serve as a supplementary step to finance the fiscal deficit, ease pressure on domestic yields, and support foreign inflows.

Could there be a negative impact if the numbers fall short of expectations?

Even if the eventual inflows are lower than current estimates, this would still represent a positive step. The measures announced were not expected to be introduced all at once, but rather over a period of time, which underscores the decisiveness of both the government and the RBI. We believe that the measures were announced to acknowledge the underlying risk of a potential Balance of Payments (BoP) deficit. Based on the market estimates, the BoP gap for the year could be in the range of \$50 billion-\$75 billion, and the measures collectively aim to address this.

There is also limited concern around execution. A relevant precedent exists from 2013, when banks successfully mobilised approximately \$26 billion through FCNR(B) deposits with effective efforts. In that context, achieving inflows of \$30 billion-\$40 billion under the current framework appears realistic.

Do you expect FIIs to pour money into Indian debt immediately or wait for more cues on the interest

rate front?

There are broadly two types of investors: those with a medium-term outlook and others with a more tactical approach to interest rates. From a macroeconomic standpoint, we believe that the RBI has attempted to prepare the market by highlighting elevated inflation risks and providing clear forward guidance. It has indicated that if inflation data deteriorates further, policy rate hikes remain a possibility.

Macroeconomic data will ultimately determine whether FIIs choose to take positions immediately or adopt a wait-and-watch approach. However, initial indications suggest healthy participation given that FII activity in the debt market on Friday was robust, with estimated inflows in the range of Rs 3,000 crore-Rs 4,000 crore based on changes in holdings. That being said, a segment of investors may prefer to wait for greater clarity on the interest rate cycle. It is important to note that rates in India have already moved up meaningfully. The 10-year term gov bond yield, which had bottomed at 6.15% in June 2025, had risen to around 7% prior to the latest announcements. Historically, in rate upcycles over the past decade, 10-year gov bond yields have not moved significantly beyond 7.5%. Long-term gov bond yields are already in the range of 7.6-7.65%, indicating that a substantial portion of the adjustment has already occurred.

FULL INTERVIEW ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

INSIDE ANDHRA’S AI AMBITIONS

Why Andhra Pradesh plans to let data centres buy & distribute own electricity

Pratyush Deep New Delhi, June 7

DATA CENTRES, the massive facilities that power artificial intelligence (AI), are among the largest consumers of electricity in an economy. As the AI boom drives up the demand for computing power, governments are increasingly being forced to rethink how these facilities access and procure electricity.

The Andhra Pradesh government, which has lofty AI ambitions for the state, has announced a first-of-its-kind policy move to address this issue — let data centres function under the tag of a power distributor by granting them a deemed distribution licence (DDL).

DDLs are not a new concept in India’s electricity framework. They have largely been issued to government entities, special economic zones, ports, airports and industrial enclaves. Even the Railways, until recently, was a deemed distribution licensee for around a decade. Extending such a licence to private data centre developers is a major departure from the norm.

But what exactly are these licences and how will it help data centres? Very simply put, it will allow them to procure electricity at a relatively lower cost and distribute it within their own campuses. But there’s more to this. Here’s a deeper dive into the mechanics of how this policy will work.

Data centres’ massive electricity needs

AI runs on algorithms, but those algorithms require vast computing power housed in data centres. Data centres, in turn, run on massive quantities of electricity. This is why data centres are identified not by the number of servers they house, but by the amount of power they require. As AI adoption accelerates, the demand for computing capacity is driving a surge in data centre construction — and with it, a sharp rise in electricity requirement. In the US, home to more than half of the world’s data centres by both numbers and power consumption, the rapid expansion of hyperscalers has emerged as a political and regulatory issue, with concerns that growing power demand from data centres is contributing to higher electricity prices in regions where data centres are lo-

POWERING GROWTH

ANDHRA PRADESH is leading the race to become a major data centre hub among Indian states

GOOGLE IS setting up a 1 GW data centre campus in Visakhapatnam in one of the largest such projects in the country

THE STATE is also planning to create 5 GW of data-centre capacity in Visakhapatnam alone

THE COUNTRY’S installed data-centre capacity currently stands at around 1.2 gigawatt



but is estimated to quadruple by 2030

cated. Such concerns could surface in India as well. The country’s installed data-centre capacity currently stands at around 1.2 GW but is estimated to quadruple by 2030. Among Indian states, Andhra Pradesh is leading the race to become a major data centre hub.

Google is setting up a 1 GW data centre campus in Visakhapatnam in one of the largest such projects in the country. And the state is planning to create 5 GW of data-centre capacity in Visakhapatnam alone.

How will DDLs help?

Unlike the US, electricity tariffs for industrial and commercial consumers in India are substantially higher than those for residential and agricultural users. This is largely because industrial and commercial consumers essentially subsidise agricultural and domestic consumers. To understand why DDL status matters for data centres, it is important to understand how electricity tariffs are structured.

Broadly, a consumer’s electricity bill has two components: fixed charges and energy charges. Fixed charges have to be paid irrespective of how much electricity is consumed, while energy charges vary with actual consumption. The fixed-cost component covers expenses such as capacity payments made to power generators, transmission infrastructure costs, salaries of utility employees, and maintenance of the electricity network. When a distribution company (discom) acquires a large new consumer, it must ensure adequate power

supply for that consumer by contracting additional generation capacity and, where necessary, expanding transmission and distribution infrastructure. These costs eventually find their way into consumer tariffs. This becomes particularly relevant in the case of data centres, whose electricity demand can run into hundreds of megawatts — comparable to that of a medium-sized city. Andhra Pradesh’s policy allows data centres with a minimum connected load of 300 MW to obtain DDL status, with investors permitted to aggregate loads from multiple facilities to meet the threshold.

By granting DDL status, the state effectively allows these large consumers to arrange their own power procurement and develop electricity distribution infrastructure within their project boundaries. As a result, the local discom is not required to make fresh generation capacity commitments or undertake network investments specifically to serve these energy-intensive facilities. For data centre operators, the benefits could be substantial. DDL holders can procure power from any lawful source, including through open-access arrangements, while being exempted from the cross-subsidy surcharge and additional surcharge that are typically levied on open-access consumers. This allows them to avoid the higher tariffs that commercial consumers usually pay to subsidise residential and agricultural users.

FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Nvidia, SK to detail chip cooperation plan



Nvidia CEO Huang (right) and SK Group Chair Chey Tae-won. X/@SKHYNIX

Reuters Seoul, June 7

NVIDIA AND South Korea’s SK are expected to announce a plan for cooperation between the two companies on Monday, with the boss of the US chip-maker saying that the ongoing memory shortage would persist for “quite a few years”.

A spokesperson for SK Hynix said group chairman Chey Tae-won and Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang plan to brief media about the plan on Monday morning, confirming a report by Newsis.

Huang separately said Nvi-

dia could make announcements with SK on Monday.

“We’re working across many industries from AI supercomputers to CPUs to new PCs and robotics. So we are here to plan and maybe tomorrow we have some announcements,” he told reporters, without elaborating further.

He also said he did not see an end to memory shortages.

“The whole industry supply chain — everything from wafers to packaging to silicon photonics... everything’s in short supply because the demand is so high. It is going to persist for several years.”

OPEC+ decides on fourth oil quota hike since Hormuz closure

London: OPEC+ agreed on Sunday a fourth increase in its oil output targets in as many months, even though the US war with Iran is still preventing several of the group’s members from pumping more.

The war has cut oil flows via the Strait of Hormuz, creating the world’s biggest-ever supply crisis as key OPEC+ members including Saudi Arabia have been unable to supply customers in full since the end of February.

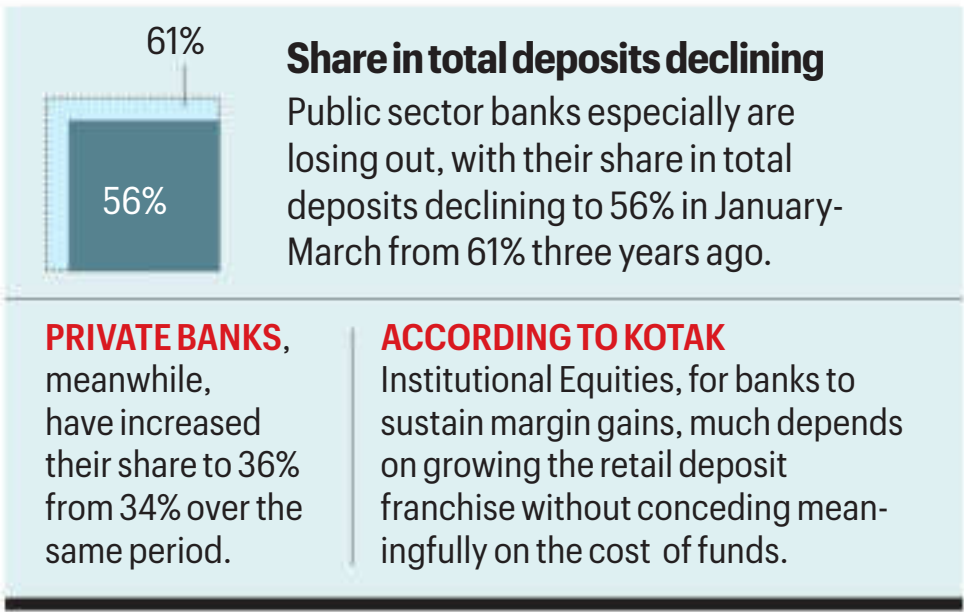
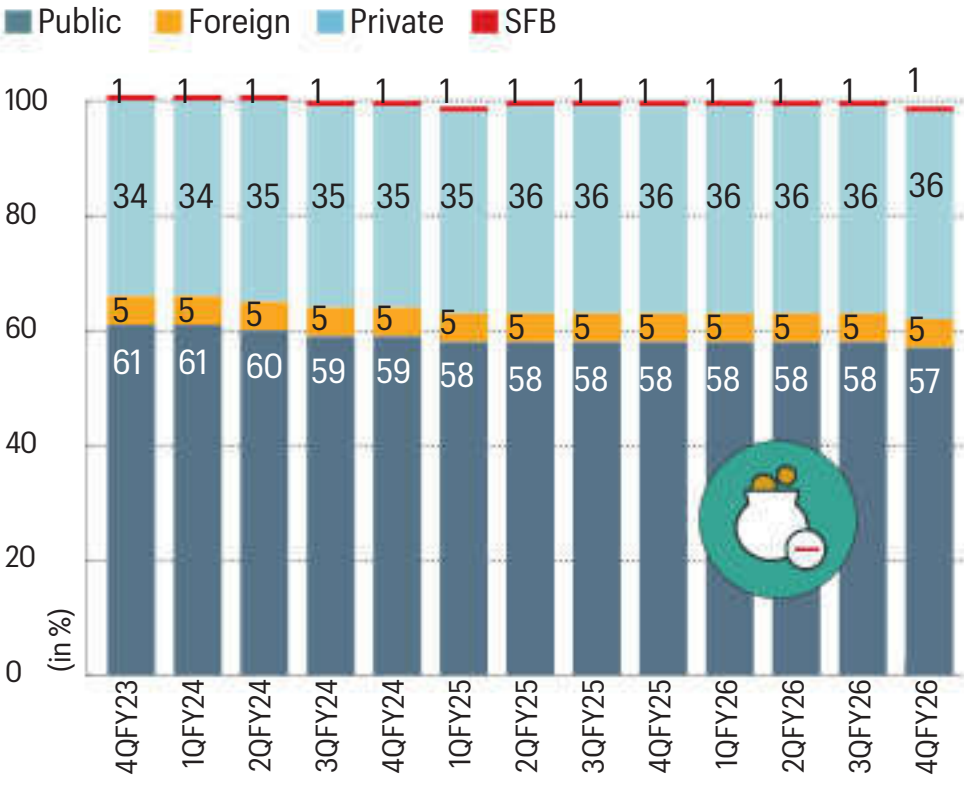
The crisis for OPEC+ deepened when the United Arab Emirates left the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries after almost 60 years.

Seven core members of OPEC+, which groups OPEC and allied producers including Russia, have increased their output quotas from April to June by almost 600,000 barrels per day.

In reality, the group’s production has collapsed due to export cuts by Gulf members, averaging 33.19 million bpd in April compared with 42.77 million in February, according to OPEC figures. REUTERS

SHARE OF PSU BANKS IN DEPOSITS CONTINUES TO DECLINE

With deposit growth slowing for Indian banks, the RBI bearing the hedging cost for new FCNR(B) deposits is important.



SOURCE: KOTAK INSTITUTIONAL EQUITIES

‘Indian cos got far less govt support than Chinese peers in 2005-24’

New Delhi: Indian firms received significantly lower government support than their Chinese counterparts during 2005-2024, according to an OECD (Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development) report.

OECD MAGIC Database of Industrial Subsidies measures

what firms actually receive (not what governments disclose), covering 525 of the world’s largest manufacturers across 15 key sectors over 2005-24, through three instruments: grants, income-tax concessions, and below-market borrowings (cheap state-bank loans).

“Between 2005 and 2024,

Chinese firms received on average three to eight times more government support than firms based in the OECD, a conservative estimate. These subsidies were also considerably higher than the support received by firms based in non-OECD economies such as Brazil, India, and Indonesia,” the report said. PTI

FE Best banks awards

WINNERS LIST

2024-25

Lifetime Achievement
SANJIV BAJAJ, CMD,
Bajaj Finserv

Banker of the Year
K S RAJU, former MD &
CEO, Canara Bank



Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal (front row, fifth from left), The Indian Express Group Executive Director Anant Goenka (front row, sixth from left) and winners of the FE Best Bank Awards, in Mumbai on Sunday.



BRIEFLY

LIC in talks to facilitate long-term instruments

New Delhi: Life Insurance Corporation of India is engaging with key financial regulators, including the RBI and SEBI, to expand the availability of long-term investment instruments as inflows into its annuity products keep on rising, CEO and MDR Doraiswamy said. An Annuity product converts an accumulated retirement corpus into a guaranteed, lifelong stream of income. PTI

‘ATF price stabilisation fund a good solution’

Rio de Janeiro: India setting up the ATF price stabilisation fund is a very good solution to address the problem of higher jet fuel costs being faced by the domestic airlines, a senior IATA executive has

said. While mentioning that the current jet fuel scenario globally is unprecedented in terms of the cost impact, Hemant Mistry, Director Energy Transition at IATA, cautioned that if the situation continues, there would have to be more flight reductions. PTI

OpenAI plans to revamp ChatGPT ahead of listing

Bengaluru: OpenAI is planning its biggest ChatGPT overhaul yet, aiming to turn it into a “superapp” with coding tools and AI agents to boost revenue ahead of a potential stock market listing, the Financial Times reported on Sunday. The overhaul will give greater prominence and resources to OpenAI’s coding product Codex, initially appearing as updates to ChatGPT’s website and mobile apps, FT said. REUTERS

WHY SANJAY JHA

As JD(U)'s working president, Sanjay Jha occupies a pivotal position in Bihar politics at a time of unprecedented transition. With Nitish Kumar stepping away from state politics after two decades as chief minister, Jha has emerged as the principal custodian of the party's future — managing leadership succession, preserving JD(U)'s identity within a BJP-led NDA and navigating questions over the party's relevance. A close Nitish confidant, he now finds himself at the centre of one of the most consequential political experiments in Bihar: whether a regional party built around a towering leader can successfully reinvent itself in the post-Nitish era



ON NISHANT KUMAR JOINING JD(U)

He has been in the house with his father. Based on my interactions, he is sensitive and possesses his father's qualities. Now he has to prove himself. Joining is one thing but public acceptance is another



ON ESTABLISHING PRIORITIES

Establishing the rule of law... especially in places like Champaran, which was a hub for kidnapping... Now the launchpad is ready... Many people living outside want to invest in Bihar

‘Two people destroyed the India Bloc alliance: Mamata Banerjee and Arvind Kejriwal’

JD(U) working president Sanjay Jha on the roadmap for Bihar's industrial future, taking the party forward after Nitish Kumar, and JD(U)'s distinct identity within the NDA. He was in conversation with Deeptiman Tiwary, Deputy Associate Editor, *The Indian Express*



Sanjay Jha, JDU National Working President (right) with Deeptiman Tiwary, Deputy Associate Editor, *The Indian Express*, at the Noida office. RENUKA PURI

response from the youth? Does it show a vacuum in leadership or ideology?

Suddenly they have so many millions of followers but I travel across the country and my state, and I don't see any connection. Despite this following, is there any anger against the government on the ground? No. The results show this. There might be grievances about specific issues but not anger against the government. The Opposition should definitely think about why someone else is taking their space. I don't see any connection between BJP's 22-odd million followers and the ground. This will be short-lived. Many people went to Bihar to do politics but elections are a different ball game. I have no idea if the government blocked their account but I don't see a connection to the ground.

Vikas Pathak: Most current Bihar leaders emerged from the JP Movement and the slogan of 'Total Revolution.' Given that background, shouldn't there be a high level of tolerance for the Opposition and contrary views?

Absolutely. If someone has anger, there must be tolerance. There should always be space for the Opposition and contrary views. This has been the case over time and since we come from Bihar, we have shown this.

Vikas Pathak: Regional parties such as Akali Dal and Shiv Sena have either broken away or split. Mamata Banerjee's or Naveen Patnaik's parties have lost ground. Does the decline of regional parties concern you?

It is a cause for concern. Many regional parties became 'family' parties, which led to their crumbling. Socialist leaders from the JP Movement started with ideology, then became caste leaders, then the family became integrated and then the crumbling began. Nitish ji tried hard to bring all socialist parties together and sacrificed everything for it. I re-

member he called a meeting where Mulayam Singh Yadav ji said, 'Your flag and name will remain, everyone should just unite.' But everyone felt their assets, property, and bank accounts were personalised by the party; they wondered what the point of uniting was. Everyone ran away from it. Probably we are the only party so far that has not practised this, and we won't in the future. For 15 years, people have written that this party will end but it won't, because Nitish Kumar's legacy cannot be wiped out.

Deeptiman Tiwary: You have spoken of JD(U)'s moderation but BJP leaders in Bihar, like Vijay Kumar Sinha, have linked meat consumption to 'violent tendencies.' It seems the BJP is bringing its brand of politics from other states to Bihar while you remain



a silent spectator.

I come from Mithila, where eating meat is almost mandatory, yet people there are very soft-spoken. There is a contradiction there. There may have been aberrations here and there but as far as the government is concerned, we do not agree with all of this. If the ideologies were identical, why would there be separate parties?

Both of us know our boundaries. Even previously, such comments would occasionally come from somewhere, but it was never allowed to affect larger governance. Bihar will continue to run as it has been running.

Manoj C G: Regarding the INDIA Bloc, the first meeting was at Nitish ji's house in 2023. Less than a year later, he walked out. What happened?

Two people destroyed the India Bloc al-

ON COCKROACH JANATA PARTY

They have millions of followers but I don't see any connection on the ground. There might be grievances about specific issues but not anger against the government. The Opposition should think about why someone else is taking their space

liance — I am on record: their names are Mamata Banerjee and Arvind Kejriwal. A consensus had been reached that Nitish Kumar would be the convener. But in the meeting, these two came in — probably as a planned move — and said there should be a Dalit Convener, proposing (Mallikarjun) Kharge *sahab*. This put the Congress on the backfoot. Nitish ji was never desperate to be the Convener. He was bringing everyone onto one platform. But the move was sabotaged. There was no plan, vision or cohesiveness in the bloc. Regional parties felt that Congress only does politics in a few states and it doesn't affect them much. Personally, these two people sabotaged the alliance.

Aakash Joshi: The current government depends on allies, yet we don't see the 'alliance pressure' that existed during the Vajpayee era. Core BJP/Sangh issues don't seem to be set aside for the alliance.

In those days, there were 24 parties. Today, communication exists. If we have a state issue, it gets resolved. If there is a national issue, there is consultation. For the Women's Reservation Bill, we were consulted. In the last meeting after the Bihar results, Nitish Kumar was praised. There is a system for NDA MPs to visit each other. It might not be the old 'Vajpayee model' but we don't have issues that make us uncomfortable. If Nitish ji has an issue, we talk and resolve it.

Samiksha Mishra: Why do so many bridges fall in Bihar? One bridge has reportedly fallen three times.

Some bridges are truly old, like the one in Vikramshila. In the Seemanchal area, rivers keep changing course. You will find bridges where one half was built and then the river moved, leaving it stranded. However, thousands of bridges in Bihar, like the JP Setu and Mahatma Gandhi Setu, are intact. Many bridges built under Nitish ji's

government are solid. It has happened in a few places and the government is looking into it.

Liz Mathew: Regarding delimitation, were you informed that the 50 per cent increase in seats would not be part of the Constitution Amendment Bill?

They had said the 50 per cent increase would be done. There was clarity for everyone. Even the Opposition knew.

Raj Kamal Jha: Regarding the new numbers, Tamil Nadu says their seat count shouldn't decrease during delimitation. How do you factor in Bihar and UP, etc.?

One vote has one value — that is what the Constitution says. But if you link it with the state GDP, how will that work? Bihar has a grievance: when Bihar and Jharkhand were together, all the minerals were taken but Bihar didn't get any benefit because of the Freight Equalisation policy. Our interests must not be compromised.

Currently, representation for the high population in UP and Bihar is low, which is a democratic injustice. If the government feels a middle path is needed, we will agree. But the Congress policy of Freight Equalisation caused Bihar to suffer greatly, and this must be kept in mind.

Akshita Chauhan: You say the CJP isn't grounded but as a youth, I see unemployment as a major concern. Is social media popularity not a wake-up call for how politics views youth issues?

Youth issues like unemployment are real and are being addressed through recruitment drives like the large-scale teacher recruitment in Bihar. But it is easy to flare things up on social media. There is a difference between resentment and a grievance; people still trust the government to do the work. If social media followers equalled votes, Congress would be winning everywhere based on their following. We must check if these movements are genuine or orchestrated by someone associated with a party's campaign.

Shalini Langer: What happens to those whose names were removed from ration cards during the SIR process?

SIR happened in Bihar before West Bengal. Most names removed were people who had passed away or permanently shifted. In some border areas, someone gets married and comes to Bihar, and the Election Commission addressed that. The Opposition tried to make SIR an issue but it didn't resonate. There was no violence and not a single re-poll in Bihar.

Deeptiman Tiwary: You have had 20 years. Beyond roads and electricity, what are your priorities?

Establishing the rule of law was the most challenging work, especially in places like Champaran, which was a hub for kidnapping for ransom. Nitish ji did that. Now the launchpad is ready. Migration is a challenge but in the next five years, you will see significant investment. Many people living outside are starting a 'reverse migration' and want to invest in Bihar. Factories are already being set up in Bihta and Muzaffarpur.

Aakash Joshi: Youth's faith in recruitment is fading due to NEET, NTA and CUET issues. Does JD(U) raise this with the BJP?

Discussions happen. The NEET issue is painful and the government cancelled it immediately upon learning of the irregularities. I feel the government will fix it next year. Bihar's BPSC has become a robust system. You haven't seen an agitation there for 3-4 years. Regarding the Teacher Recruitment Examination (TRE 4), the CM has fixed a timeline: 20,000 teachers every year, totalling 100,000 over five years.

Deeptiman Tiwary: The Opposition alleges you have failed on the diplomatic and economic fronts, especially with fuel prices.

India didn't start the war in West Asia; it has been going on for 90 days. Roughly 25 per cent to 30 per cent of our crude oil comes through the Strait of Hormuz. The government has done tremendous management by finding alternative sources from Africa and Russia. Without this, petrol could have increased by Rs 40.

Deeptiman Tiwary: Regarding diplomacy, Operation Sindoor was meant to gather support, yet we see international leaders still engaging closely with Pakistan. Did our diplomacy fail?

I led one of the delegations after Operation Sindoor. It was a successful move that sensitised the world to Pakistan's involvement in terrorism. Look at what Trump has been saying about India over the last 48 hours. Our management of the oil issue and the safety of seafarers are evidence of diplomatic success.

Manoj C G: If the BJP proposes the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) in Bihar, how will JD(U) react?

When the issue comes, we will respond to it. Today, this is not an issue in Bihar.

{ W E E K L Y C A P S U L E }

New diabetes, obesity pill

Scientists at Karolinska Institutet have developed an experimental diabetes and obesity pill that works in a completely different way from drugs like Ozempic. Rather than reducing hunger, it activates metabolism in skeletal muscle, helping lower blood sugar and increase fat burning while preserving muscle mass. Early clinical results suggest the treatment is safe and well tolerated. Researchers say this approach improved blood sugar regulation and body composition in animal studies while avoiding several side effects linked to GLP-1 therapies. The treatment is taken as a tablet rather than an injection.



Organ that determines longevity

A long-overlooked organ may hold surprising clues to healthy ageing and cancer survival. Researchers at Mass General Brigham used AI to analyse CT scans from tens of thousands of adults and found that people with healthier thymuses — a small immune-system organ once thought to become largely irrelevant after childhood — lived longer and had substantially lower risks of heart disease, cancer and death. The same organ was also linked to better responses to cancer immunotherapy. Located in the chest, the thymus helps train T cells, a type of immune cells that shield the body against infections and disease.



Now, you can reverse anxiety

Scientists have identified a brain circuit that plays a major role in anxiety, depression-like behaviours and social withdrawal. Even more striking, they found that restoring balance within this circuit was enough to reverse several of these behaviours in mice. The research was conducted by the Universidad Miguel Hernandez de Elche. Researchers knew the amygdala was involved in anxiety and fear but now they have identified a specific population of neurons whose imbalanced activity alone is sufficient to trigger pathological behaviour. By normalising a certain gene activity in this region, they restored communication.



What ties French fries to diabetes

French fries may be the real potato problem. A large US study tracking more than 205,000 people for nearly 40 years found that eating three servings of fries per week was linked to a 20 per cent higher risk of developing Type 2 diabetes, while baked, boiled or mashed potatoes showed no significant increase in risk. Swapping potatoes for whole grains lowered diabetes risk while replacing them with white rice had the opposite effect. While previous studies have often connected potato to diabetes risk, researchers noted that the way it is prepared and the replacement foods people eat instead matter the most.



CKD now a silent health threat

As the global population has grown and aged, chronic kidney disease (CKD) has moved into the top 10 causes of death worldwide for the first time. A global analysis found that the number of people living with the condition rose from 378 million in 1990 to 788 million in 2023. The work was led by researchers at NYU Langone Health, the University of Glasgow, and the Institute for Health Metrics and Evaluation (IHME) at the University of Washington. Impaired kidney function was also a major risk factor for heart disease, contributing to about 12 per cent of global cardiovascular deaths.





INTERPRETATION OF MALADIES

DR SURANJIT CHATTERJEE

SENIOR CONSULTANT, INTERNAL MEDICINE, APOLLO HOSPITALS, DELHI



Oversight is a key reason why fatty liver disease is undiagnosed

Why fatty liver warning is easy to ignore

Consult a doctor when bloating is persistent or occurs without a trigger

A 42-YEAR-OLD corporate professional had been experiencing frequent bloating for several months. She assumed it was due to irregular meals, work-related stress and occasional overeating. Antacids provided temporary relief but the discomfort kept returning. During a routine health check-up, an abdominal ultrasound revealed fatty liver disease. Apart from being overweight and having borderline high cholesterol, she had no obvious symptoms. Many like her often experience bloating after a heavy meal, eating too quickly or consuming certain foods. In many cases, it is linked to common digestive issues such as acidity, indigestion or gas. However, when bloating becomes frequent, persistent or occurs without an obvious trigger, it may be worth evaluating further. It could be indicative of fatty liver disease, which is becoming increasingly common among Indians. While bloating alone does not indicate a liver problem, recurrent abdominal discomfort can sometimes be a subtle sign that something more may be going on beneath the surface. The liver plays a vital role in metabolism, digestion, and nutrient absorption. As fat deposits increase within the liver, the organ can become enlarged. While this may not cause significant pain, some individuals may experience a sensation of fullness, heaviness, or mild bloating in the abdomen. If this occurs regularly, persists for weeks or develops without context, it may be worth investigating further.

As fat deposits increase within the liver, the organ can become enlarged. This triggers fullness

Oversight is one of the key reasons why fatty liver disease frequently remains undetected until it is identified during a routine health check-up or imaging test performed for another reason. A major challenge with fatty liver disease is that many people do not experience any symptoms at all. The condition is often discovered incidentally during routine blood tests or abdominal ultrasounds. This makes awareness and regular health screening particularly important for individuals who are overweight or living with diabetes, high cholesterol or high blood pressure. Some individuals may experience non-specific symptoms such as fatigue, reduced energy levels, a feeling of fullness in the upper right side of the abdomen, or difficulty losing weight. Because these symptoms are subtle and can be attributed to several other conditions, they are frequently overlooked. The increasing prevalence of fatty liver disease reflects broader lifestyle and metabolic health trends. Obesity, Type 2 diabetes, hypertension and abnormal cholesterol levels are becoming increasingly common across India. Contributing factors include physical inactivity, excessive consumption of calorie-dense foods, irregular meal timings, chronic stress, and inadequate sleep. What makes the situation more concerning is that fatty liver is no longer a condition seen only among older adults. Increasingly, it is being diagnosed in younger individuals, many of whom are asymptomatic. This underscores the importance of paying attention to seemingly minor health changes, particularly in people with underlying metabolic risk factors. Simple investigations such as liver function tests, blood sugar assessments, lipid profile testing, and abdominal ultrasound scans can often provide valuable insights into the source of persistent symptoms. If left unmanaged, fatty liver disease can progress beyond simple fat accumulation. In some individuals, it may lead to liver inflammation, a condition known as steatohepatitis, which can eventually progress to fibrosis, cirrhosis and even liver failure. The encouraging news is that fatty liver disease is often reversible in its early stages. Managing body weight, engaging in regular physical activity, following a balanced diet, improving sleep quality and maintaining healthy blood glucose and cholesterol levels can reduce complications.

Rinku Ghosh

At 46, Amit Mehra* is doing what he loves most — playing cricket, travelling with his family and maintaining a busy professional life as a chartered accountant. Looking at him today, it is difficult to imagine that eight years ago he was diagnosed with a tumour in one of the most critical regions of his brain. “At 38, my whole world had come crashing down. Now I look forward to my weekend cricket match and know when to log out of work,” he says. Mehra is one of the young Indians reporting brain and Central Nervous System (CNS) tumours in India which have an estimated incidence of 30 cases per 100,000 population. Roughly 30% to 35% of these tumours are malignant (cancerous), while the majority are benign (non-cancerous). Mehra began noticing brief episodes of weakness and numbness in his left hand while playing cricket. Sometimes he would struggle to hold on to objects. The episodes lasted only a few seconds before disappearing. He attributed them to physical strain, poor posture or fatigue. “It felt like numbness from sleeping awkwardly or overexertion,” he recalls. “The symptoms were so generic that I never imagined they could be related to brain tumour.” Mehra was worried because he kept to a good fitness discipline, ate clean, had no diabetes or hypertension and wasn’t a smoker or alcohol drinker. That’s the reason he paid attention to his symptoms, which though fleeting in nature, were replicative. An MRI scan revealed a tumour located in the brain’s eloquent cortex — a region responsible for critical functions such as movement and sensation. What appeared to be transient weakness was actually focal motor seizure triggered by the tumour. A surgery and eight years later, there has been no recurrence. His medications have been significantly reduced and he remains active. “I just got a promotion at my firm for high productivity,” he says. His story reflects a larger shift in brain tumour care. Increasingly, a diagnosis that once carried an almost universally grim prognosis is becoming a condition that can often be treated successfully, with many patients returning to work, family life and even sports.

More cases or better detection?

Brain tumours are being diagnosed more frequently in India than ever before. While the incidence remains relatively low compared to other diseases, neurologists say awareness and access to advanced imaging have transformed diagnosis. “Brain tumours are not necessarily increasing dramatically because of new environmental exposure,”

Brain tumour is not a life sentence

How advances in surgery, molecular diagnostics and multidisciplinary care are helping young patients live longer

says Dr Kapil Singhal, director, Neurology, Medanta, formerly of AIIMS, Delhi. “What has changed significantly is our ability to detect them. MRI scans are more accessible and people are getting evaluated earlier.” He acknowledges seeing more young and middle-aged adults with brain tumours. Unlike diabetes or heart disease, most brain tumours do not have clearly identifiable lifestyle-related causes. The uncertainty surrounding why they occur often makes the diagnosis unsettling for younger patients who otherwise consider themselves healthy.

Understanding brain tumours

A brain tumour occurs when cells within the brain begin dividing uncontrollably. “It develops when cells in the brain or surrounding tissues acquire genetic mutations that disrupt their normal growth controls. These mutations alter the instructions encoded in DNA, causing cells to multiply and survive longer than they should. As these abnormal cells accumulate, they can form a mass or tumour,” says Dr Singhal. In most cases, the exact reason behind these genetic changes remains unknown. While some mutations arise spontaneously during a person’s lifetime, others may be inherited from a parent, increasing the risk of developing certain types of brain tumours. “And we need to bust the myth that routine mobile phone usage causes brain tumours. There is no scientific evidence. Also, most brain tumours are not hereditary. They can happen due to random cellular mutations,” explains Dr Singhal. Contrary to popular belief, not all brain tumours are cancerous. “Many are benign or low-grade lesions that grow slowly and can be completely removed. Modern surgical methods have made longevity and quality of life possible. Low-grade tumours (Grade 1 and Grade 2), which tend to grow slowly have lower recurrence rates. High-grade or malignant tumours (Grade 3 and Grade 4) are more aggressive, have high recurrence chances and require surgery, radiation and



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chemotherapy,” adds Dr Singhal. Mehra’s tumour was classified as a Grade 2 lesion — a category associated with relatively favourable outcomes when detected early and removed effectively. “The words ‘brain tumour’ immediately make people think of death or severe disability. But that is simply not true for a significant proportion of patients. Many tumours are treatable, and some can be cured completely,” says Dr Singhal. Apart from primary brain tumours, there are metastatic tumours, too, which spread to the brain from cancers elsewhere in the body. Perhaps the biggest change over the past decade has been technological. Modern neurosurgery is being driven by sophisticated imaging, computer-assisted planning and real-time monitoring. Before surgery, doctors perform brain mapping using advanced MRI techniques and tractography, which identifies critical nerve pathways responsible for movement, speech and sensation. “We perform the surgery virtually before doing it real-time,” explains Dr Manish Vaish, director of neurosurgery, Medanta. The imaging data is fed into specialised navigation systems that allow surgeons to plan the safest possible route to the tumour. “The tumour’s location in Mehra’s case made surgery particularly challenging. It was situated in the eloquent cortex, the part of the brain that governs movement and sensation. Even a few millimetres of error could potentially result in permanent neurological impairment,” says Dr Vaish. Inside the operating theatre, multiple technologies work together. Special dyes can be administered that are absorbed preferentially by tumour tissue, causing the tumour to fluoresce under specialised microscopes. Four-dimensional ultrasound helps distinguish tumour tissue from normal brain tissue in real time. Electrophysiological monitoring continuously assesses the function of critical brain regions during surgery. In selected patients like Mehra, surgeons may even perform

an awake craniotomy, allowing communication with the patient during the procedure. “We engaged Mehra by talking about cricket and its statistics. Anything incoherent is a red flag,” recalls Dr Vaish. He also describes how advanced ultrasonic aspirators have made a delicate surgery procedure easier over the last decade or so. “In simple terms, this surgical tool has a tip that vibrates at very high frequencies (ultrasound), which breaks soft tumour tissue into tiny fragments. At the same time, the device gently suctions away the broken pieces. This is especially useful in brain surgery because tumours are often located close to critical structures that control movement, speech, vision, or memory,” says Dr Vaish. Depending on the complexity of the case, surgeries may last anywhere from three hours to more than 12 hours. **Changing outcomes** One of the most significant advances in neuro-oncology has come not from the operating room but from the laboratory. In the past, doctors relied on what tumours looked like under a microscope. Today, molecular profiling and immunohistochemical (IHC) analysis provide a far deeper understanding of tumour behaviour. Following surgery, tumour samples are analysed for specific molecular markers and genetic alterations that help doctors predict aggressiveness, recurrence risk and likely response to treatment. “These molecular signatures have become extremely important,” says Dr Vaish. “They help us personalise treatment and provide a much more accurate understanding of prognosis.” Modern outcomes are no longer dependent on surgery alone. Today’s patients benefit from integrated teams of specialised anaesthetists, critical care specialists, radiation oncologists, rehabilitation experts, nutritionists, psychiatrists and nursing teams.

Back to the mainstream

Recovery timelines vary according to tumour location and complexity. Many patients begin walking within days. Those with low-grade tumours may return to work within weeks. “I went home in three days, worked out of home as I was immune-compromised, walked indoors, reduced screen time to avoid stressing my brain. In three months, I was back at the office and in six months, I was driving again,” says Mehra. Even patients requiring radiation therapy for malignancy resume normal activity during treatment. Mehra never misses his MRI scans every six months. “That alone has helped me regain something that many patients fear losing after a diagnosis: Normalcy.”

(NAME CHANGED TO PROTECT PRIVACY)

• DECODING A STUDY

Why Kerala and Bengal face Nipah with varied outbreak risks

Study reveals how ecology, human behaviour and preparedness shape Nipah spillovers

Anuradha Mascarenhas

IN JANUARY, two healthcare workers at a private hospital in Barasat, West Bengal, tested positive for Nipah virus. Investigators traced the outbreak to a 55-year-old woman who had consumed raw date palm sap purchased from a local vendor — a known food-borne spillover route also seen in Bangladesh. She later died of acute respiratory distress syndrome and multi-organ failure. Both healthcare workers had direct, unprotected exposure to the patient — one during routine nursing care and the other while performing cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR). Genomic sequencing showed a 99% match with the Bangladesh genotype 2022 strains, confirming hospital-acquired transmission. The outbreak highlights a key

finding from a recent *Nature* report, “Two geographies, one virus: What recurrent Nipah spillover in India reveals.” It says that although Nipah virus circulates in the same bat reservoir, outbreaks in India follow two distinct patterns in West Bengal and Kerala. “To understand Nipah virus in India, it is important to look beyond virology and consider ecological factors and the strength of health systems in shaping outbreak outcomes,” said Dr Pragya Yadav, corresponding author of the report and director-in-charge of the National Institute of One Health, Nagpur. According to her, Kerala experiences more frequent spillover events but outbreaks are usually contained to single cases or small clusters because of strong surveillance and a One Health approach. In contrast, West Bengal has seen fewer spill-



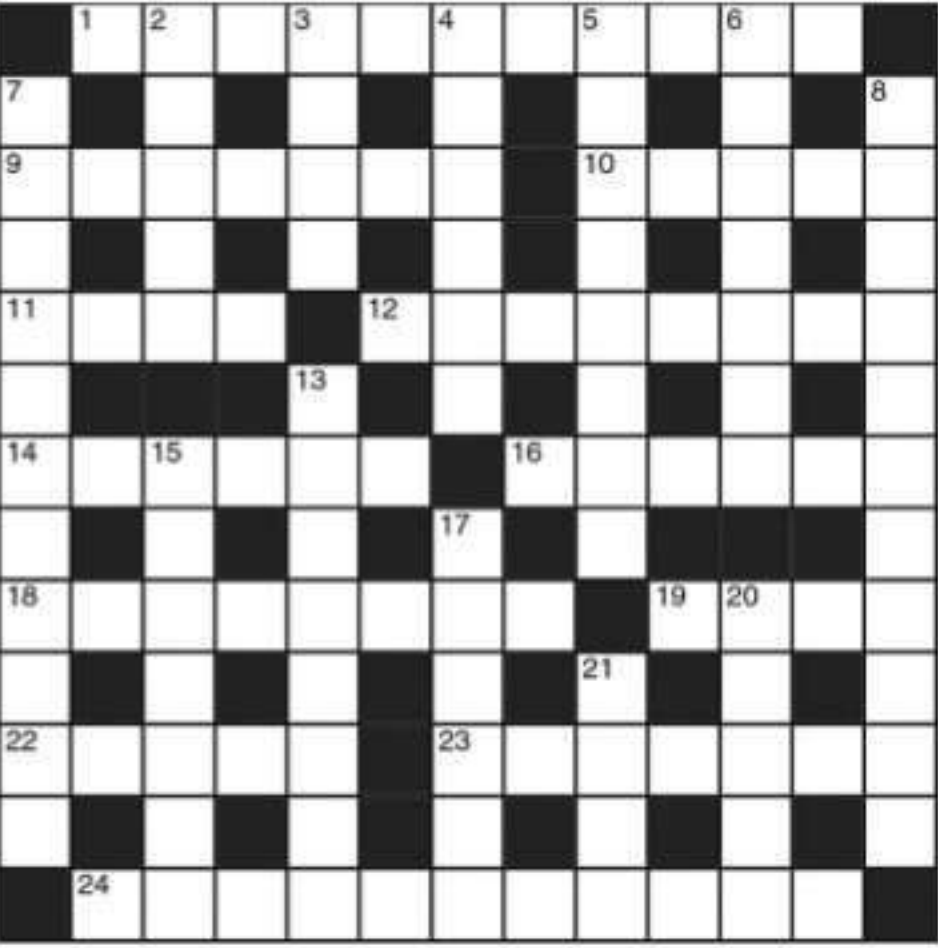
Attempts to reduce risk by disturbing bat populations or removing roosting trees can sometimes worsen the problem

overs, but these have historically been associated with healthcare-related transmission. Enhanced surveillance was critical in detecting the recent 2026 outbreak. “The examples of Kerala and West Bengal show that the same virus, maintained in a common reservoir, can produce very different epidemiological outcomes depending on local ecological conditions, human behaviour and health-system preparedness,” say study authors Deepak Y. Patil, Rima R.

Sahay, Sreelekshmy Mohandas and Dr Yadav. But ecological and environmental factors play a stronger, influencing role, they explain. In Kerala, Nipah outbreaks have consistently occurred between April and September, when hot, humid conditions coincide with fruiting seasons. During this period, bats feed near human settlements, increasing the likelihood of contamination of fruits and surfaces. Bat colonies are also commonly found within residential compounds across Kerala, creating opportunities for direct and indirect human exposure. In Bengal, bat roosts are typically located in peri-urban areas, and spillovers are more closely linked to the harvesting and consumption of fresh or fermented date palm sap. The risk peaks during the sap-harvesting season between November and April. The report cautions that attempts to reduce risk by disturbing bat populations or removing roosting trees can sometimes worsen the problem by dispersing bats and expanding the geographic range of exposure.

CROSSWORD

6009



- ACROSS
- 1 Cold game? (6,5)
9 Excuse the introduction (7)
10 Pure conversion to Eastern currency (5)
11 It helps to make shoes wear well (4)
12 Offer for money (8)
14 Hired hands? (6)
16 Stop in the name of the law (6)
18 Youth with no head for multiplication (8)
19 Just a French mother (4)
22 Gold piece is circular (5)
23 Where in December it really can be hot (7)
24 It may be taken as an indication of health (11)
- DOWN
- 2 Schemes thrown aside (5)
3 Bound to mean a change of diet (4)
4 A quick reply from the laboratory? (6)
5 Go into liquidation when working hard (8)
6 Put out in unusual transport (7)
7 Diligence with which one may seek a job (11)
8 A style we had remodelled acts as a guide (5,3,3)
13 Period added to the end of a sentence (4,4)
15 Can I provide a friendly solution? (7)
17 Conclude with a feature on charm (6)
20 In which one is mistaken (5)
21 Number in an outfit worn by Scotsmen (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6008 ACROSS: 1 Filter, 4 Assemble, 9 Ignore, 10 Dandruff, 12 Gown, 13 Under, 14 Idol, 17 Movable feast, 20 Stage whisper, 23 Emus, 24 Trunk, 25 Onus, 28 Achilles, 29 Polite, 30 Tossports, 31 Plight DOWN: 1 Fair game, 2 Long wave, 3 Earn, 5 Siamese twins, 6 Ends, 7 Bounds, 8 Enfold, 11 Undergarment, 15 Abate, 16 Astir, 18 Spanking, 19 Prospect, 21 Repast, 22 Rushes, 26 Slap, 27 Noel

JUMBLD WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

It is much more important to know what sort of a ___ has a ___ than what sort of a ___ a ___ has. William Osler (7,.,7,.,7,.) (two words twice)

PVEEE

●●●●●

GNAAI

●●●●●

AIINTT

●●●●●

PASSED

●●●●●

ANSWER: It is much more important to know what sort of a patient has a disease than what sort of a disease a patient has. - William Osle

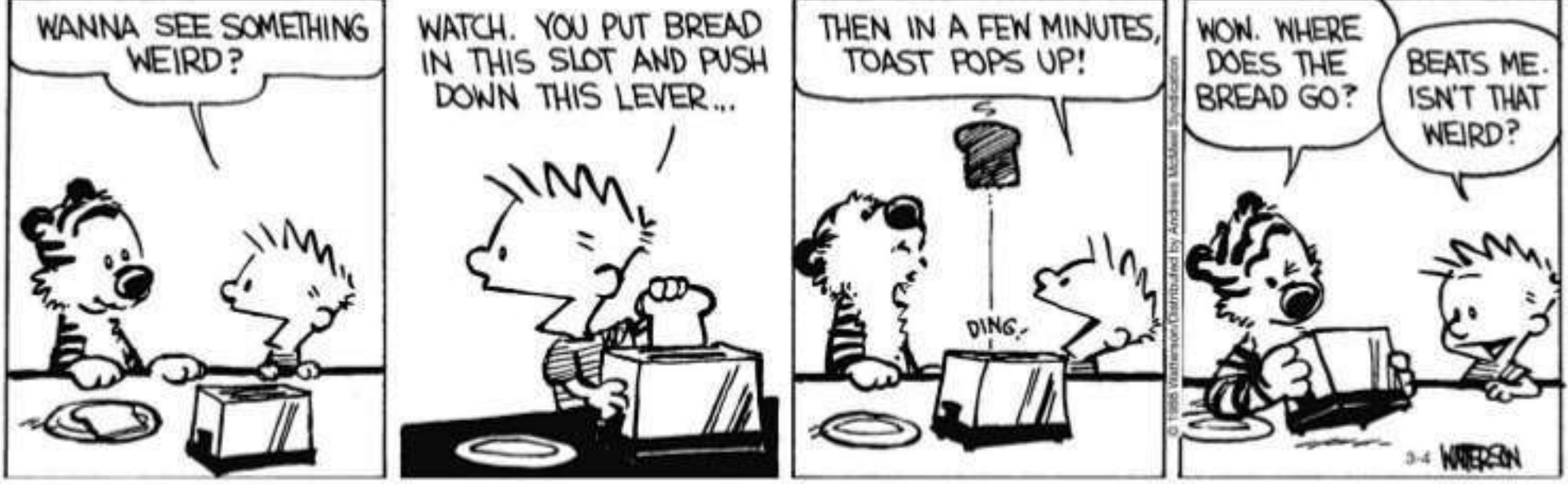
SOLUTIONS: Peeve, Agail, Tiran, Spades

OVER THE HEDGE



BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

CALVIN & HOBBS



BY BILL WATTERSON

MARVIN



BY TOM ARMSTRONG

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s

INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6343

			4		1	6		
6				7	5		8	1
	6	5				9		
4				9				3
		2				8	1	
3	2		1	4				9
			4	2		8		

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6342

9	4	8	6	7	1	5	2	3
5	1	7	2	8	3	4	6	9
3	6	2	9	4	5	1	7	8
8	3	1	5	2	7	6	9	4
2	9	4	1	6	8	7	3	5
7	5	6	4	3	9	2	8	1
1	8	5	7	9	6	3	4	2
6	2	3	8	5	4	9	1	7
4	7	9	3	1	2	8	5	6

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

11 GORKHA RIFLES REGIMENTAL CENTRE

Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave hearts, No 9421595X Late LnkIndraBahadur Rai of 1/11 GR who made supreme sacrifice during OP Rakshak (J&K) on 08 Jun 2006 .

Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks

Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave hearts, No 9422881 Late RfnLinchonPradhan of 1/11 GR who made supreme sacrifice during OP Vijay (Kargil) on 08 Jun 1999.

Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks

BORDER SECURITY FORCE

CONSTABLE S KATHIRESAN

92 BN BSF 25.05.1971-08.06.1992

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable S Kathiresan on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury, while fighting militants in Srinagar, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE

CISF Salutes the Soldiers A tribute to Brave Hearts 08th June

HC/Dvr BRAHMA PRAKASH BSF BHILAI 08-06-2008

CT/GD G. MURMU BSP BHILAI 08-06-2008

CISF proudly remembers the supreme sacrifice of these brave-hearts. On this day, they laid down their lives at the altar of duty. Their courage and bravery would remain an abiding source of inspiration for the force. The force will remain eternally indebted to them for their noblest deeds

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Ram Avatar, S/o Bishan Singh R/o H.No.324, Village Khara, Delhi-110043 at also Near Sanjeev @ Cheta General Store, Lal Dora, Village Khara Delhi-110045** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CC No.2792/2020 u/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Bawana, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ram Avatar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ram Avatar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ram Avatar of CC No.2792/2020 u/s 138 NI Act, P.S. Bawana, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **10.07.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Ld. Judicial Magistrate First Class (05) North Room No.114, 1st Floor, Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/7575/ON/2026

GOVT. OF ODISHA

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER

RURAL WORKS DIVISION, NUAPADA

BID IDENTIFICATION NO. RWNPD-04 (Online) of 2026-27

"e" PROCUREMENT NOTICE

Bid documents consisting of Work, Estimate Cost, Cost of tender Paper, EMD / BID security, Time of Completion, Class of Contractor and the set of terms and conditions of contract and other necessary documents can be seen in Govt. website i.e. www.tendersorissa.gov.in

1. Name of the Work : Building works in the District of Nuapada as mentioned in DTCN

2. Total No of Works : 06 Nos.

3. Estimated Cost : Rs. 88.07 to 136.73 lakhs (Building)

4. Period of Completion : 09 (Nine) Calendar Month

5. Other Details :

Procurement Officer	Bid Identification No.	Availability of Tender online for bidding From To	Last date & time of seeking tender clarification	Date & Time of opening of Tender
Superintending Engineer, Rural Works Division, Nuapada	RWNPD-04/2026-27 (Online)	09.06.2026 at 10.00 AM upto 17.06.2026 at 5.00 PM	16.06.2026 upto 05.00 PM	18.06.2026 at 11.00 AM

Further details can be seen from the website www.tendersodisha.gov.in

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
Rural Works Division,
Nuapada

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Umesh Kumar S/o Vishram R/o H. No. B-38, Metro Vihar, Phase-II, Holambi Kalan, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 1217/2014 U/s 33 Delhi Excise ACT, PS Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Umesh Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Umesh Kumar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Umesh Kumar in FIR No. 1217/2014 U/s 33 Delhi Excise ACT, PS Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.07.2026**.

By order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/7601/ON/2026

Mangalore SEZ Limited

Mangalore Special Economic Zone, Sy.No. 168-3A, Plot No. U1 Administrative Building, Baipe Village, Mangalore - 574 142 Dakshina Kannada, Karnataka

INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST

Mangalore SEZ Limited (MSEZL) invites Expressions of Interest (EOI) from eligible and experienced firms for the following project:

No	EOI Ref No	Name of Work	Last date for submission of EOI
1	MSEZL/4.5MLD TTP/EOI/2026	Establishment of 4.5MLD Capacity Tertiary Treatment Plant at the Common Effluent Treatment Plant in MSEZ	06.07.2026
2	MSEZL/22.7MLD TTP/EOI/2026	Establishment of 22.7MLD Capacity Tertiary Treatment Plant at Kavoor, Mangalore	06.07.2026

Interested firms may obtain detailed information and EOI documents from the MSEZL website: www.mangaloresez.com. All subsequent communications, corrigenda, addenda, clarifications, notifications, and updates pertaining to this EOI shall be hosted exclusively on the above website. Interested firms are advised to regularly visit the website for the latest information.

Sd/-
Chief Executive Officer
Mangalore SEZ Limited, Mangalore

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I arrive at a conclusion not an assumption.

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ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a wonderful day to entertain at home because people feel warmhearted and generous to others. You might spend extra time redecorating. This is also an excellent day for real estate negotiations. Tonight: Enjoy your privacy.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today, you will enjoy the friendship of others. You'll also enjoy your involvement in groups, clubs and organisations. Your everyday activities will be sunny, warm and upbeat. The beauty of your daily surroundings is a blessing. Tonight: Be friendly.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): You make a fabulous impression on others. Not only do you appear to be warm and gracious. This is a great day for financial negotiations. Respect your moneymaking ideas. Tonight: You're admired.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today is highly favourable for you. It doesn't get much better than this! Explore new ideas. Make travel plans. This day can expand to be exciting and adventurous! Tonight: Learn and explore!

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a popular week for you, and today especially, discussions about financial matters, taxes, debt, inheritances and shared property will go well. Your ambition is strong and friends are supportive. Tonight: Check your finances.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Today it's in your best interest to be more than halfway when dealing with others. This is a day of mutual generosity and loving vibes. Enjoy talking to everyone! Tonight: Listen and cooperate.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): Your efforts at work today will be met with support from others. This is because people feel generous and helpful today. It's an excellent day to talk to bosses and people in authority to ask for permission or approval. Try it! Tonight: Get better organised.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is a marvellous day for romance, social outings and fun activities with kids. In particular, the arts will flourish! Plan for a fun outing. Romance is in the air. Your patience with partners and close friends will bring an immediate payoff. Tonight: Socialise.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Enjoy this day in a gentler way. You might want to relax at home. Get comfortable. Take it easy. Discussions with others will go well, especially financial or practical discussions. Tonight: Enjoy familiar surroundings.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): This is a wonderful day to chat with others. It's also a great day to learn something new or take a short trip. Discussions with members of the general public, as well as close friends and partners, will expand your mind with new information. Tonight: Happy discussions.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Financial discussions and negotiations are favoured today. This is a pleasant, fun-loving day. Enjoy yourself. Tonight: Check your belongings.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Today the Moon is in your sign giving you a slight advantage over all the other signs. In addition to which, it's dancing beautifully with both Venus and Jupiter, thereby encouraging fun and social opportunities. Accept invitations to party. Tonight: You win.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Rashid Khan S/o Hameed Khan R/o-2644, Gali Khajoor Wali, Kucha Chelan, Darya Ganj, Delhi-02 Have changed my name to Rasheed Khan.

0071040650-1

It is for general information that I, Veena Nagpal, W/o Late Sh. Om Prakash Nagpal, R/o B-13, B.K. Dutt Colony, Karbala, Lodhi Road, New Delhi - 110003, declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Phoola in my husband's PPO No. AF/S/C/7622/81. The actual name of mine is Veena Nagpal which may be amended accordingly.

0071040653-1

I Amit Yadav S/o Om Parkash Yadav R/o Plot No 1102-y Sector-52 Gurgaon, Haryana - 122001, declare that name of my minor son Yakshit Yadav aged 7 years has been wrongly written as Baby of Neetu Kumari in his Adhar card no.The actual name of my minor son is Yakshit Yadav.

0071040647-1

I, Firoz S/o Mohd Salahuddin Khan, C-403/A, Block-C, Indra Kalyan Vihar, Okhla-1, Delhi-20 have changed my name to Firoz Khan.

0071040648-1

I, Arun Kumar Bimal S/o Harish Chandra Bimal R/o House No. E-586 Block-E DDA Flats Bindapur Uttam Nagar New Delhi-110059, have changed the name of my minor son Aahaan Bimal to Ahaan Bimal aged 13 years.

0071040645-1

I, Asha Rana W/o Sh. Sanjay Singh Jaswal R/o B-87, Gali No.7, Joshi Colony, I.P. Extension, Delhi-110092, informed that Asha, Asha Rana and Asha Devi Rana is the name of one and same Person

40858545-1

LOST & FOUND

LOST CUSAT Btech Civil Degree 8th Sem Marklist Candidate Ajit Kumar Reg 11110005 Last Exam April 2014 Address J block Prayavaran Complex Delhi 110068 Mobile 8891375104 Police LR 346859/2026

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The 2026 FIFA World Cup, spread across the United States, Mexico and Canada, is the biggest the sport has ever staged. As always, there are the favourites and the underdogs; those who arrive as stars, and those who come as unknowns and etch their name in prosperity. The game is played as much on the field, tactically and technically, as in the stands. We cover the proceedings from all angles.

Brazil beyond Vinicius, Neymar: Older, taller, tougher & built to win?

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, June 7

THE FIRST thing that stands out about Brazil's World Cup squad is not Neymar's return. Nor is it Vinicius Junior's rise to superstardom.

It is the birth date column. Brazil will arrive at the World Cup with the oldest squad in the country's history. Carlo Ancelotti's 23-man group has an average age of 29 years and 6 months, older even than Dunga's experienced squad that travelled to South Africa in 2010. In a football culture that has traditionally celebrated youthful exuberance and fearless improvisation, it is a striking choice.

Yet age is only part of the story.

Look closer, and another pattern emerges. This Brazil team is taller, more physical, and comprises a larger contingent of domestic league players than any Selecao squad since they won the 2002 World Cup.

Taken together, it reveals something important about the first World Cup team assembled by Ancelotti: a Brazil side built less around romance and more on reliability.

The squad Ancelotti unveiled feels less like a collection of artists and more like a carefully assembled tournament machine. Fifteen members of the squad were also present in Qatar four years ago. Even Neymar, absent from Ancelotti's plans for much of the past year, has been recalled at 34, while 38-year-old goalkeeper Weverton, who momentarily passed out when his name was announced, is another nod towards experience.

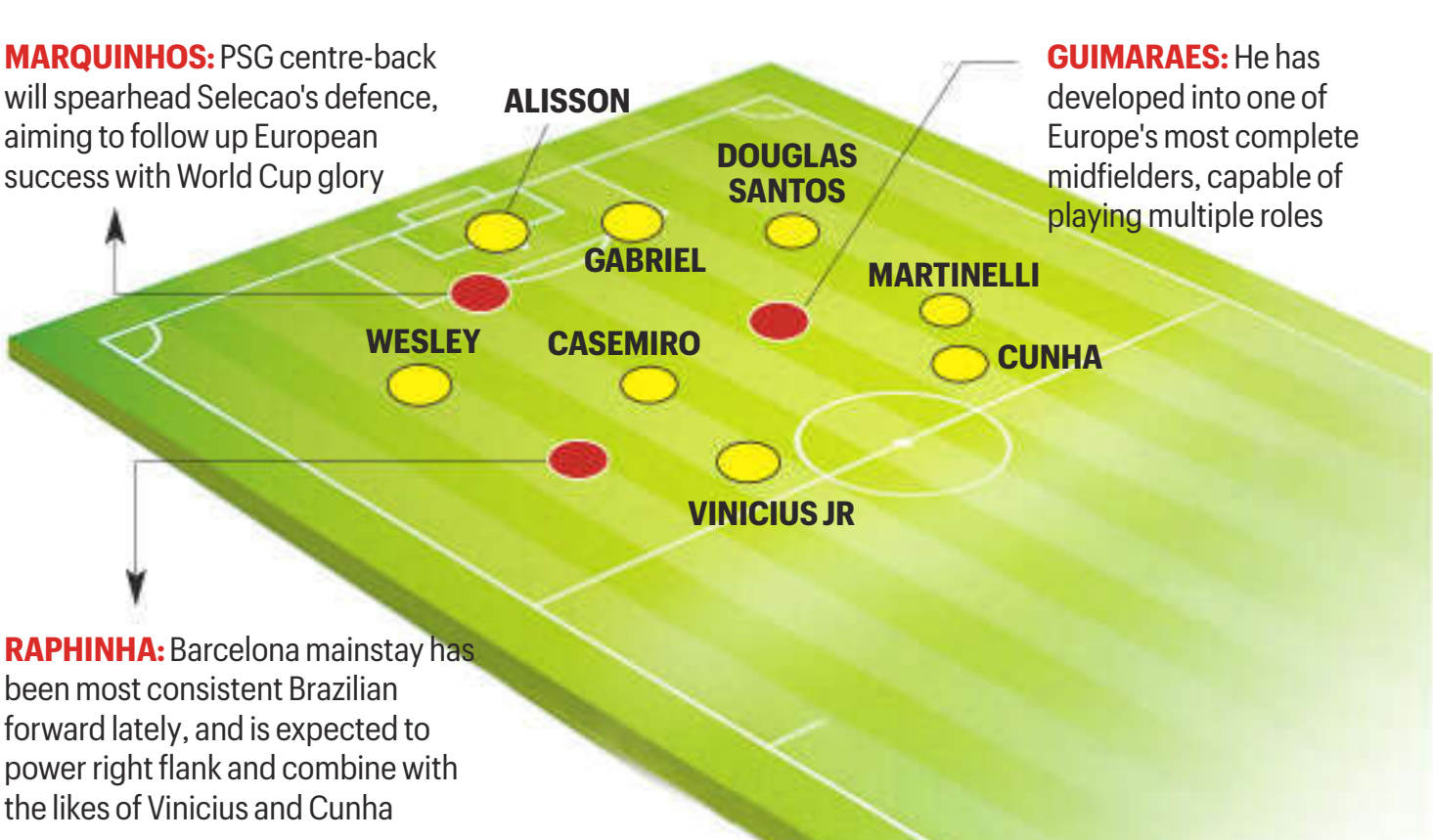
The squad's physical profile offers another clue to Ancelotti's thinking. Brazil's average height is around 1.82 metres, one of the highest in the nation's World Cup history. Modern football increasingly rewards physical superiority, especially in transitions, defensive duels and set-piece situations. The days when Brazil could dominate simply through technical brilliance are long gone.

Perhaps the most intriguing development, however, lies closer to home. Seven players in the squad currently play their club football in Brazil, accounting for almost 30 per cent of the group. That is the highest proportion in more than two decades and reflects the growing financial strength of clubs such as Flamengo, Botafogo and San-

Carlo Ancelotti's squad is the oldest and tallest in Brazil's World Cup history; it also doesn't rely on two superstars – Guimaraes is capable of controlling tempo, Paqueta provides creativity, Marquinhos remains the leader of the back line, and teen forward Rayan brings freshness and unpredictability



Carlo Ancelotti's Brazil are chasing the sixth star on their badge, the glory that has eluded them for the past 24 years. REUTERS



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tos, which have managed to bring established internationals back from Europe.

Yet, this remains fundamentally a European team. Seventeen members of the squad still play on the continent, with the Premier League alone supplying eight players. The result is a fascinating hybrid: a Brazilian team rooted at home but

shaped by the demands of Europe's elite competitions.

Ancelotti's plan

If the numbers explain what Ancelotti wants Brazil to be, the players explain how he hopes to achieve it.

For all the attention surrounding Neymar and Vinicius, this is not a squad designed

around two stars carrying everyone else. One of Ancelotti's greatest strengths has always been his ability to create balance between match-winners and system players, and Brazil's squad reflects that instinct.

The most intriguing inclusion is 19-year-old Rayan, the former Vasco da Gama forward who represents the opposite of

everything the squad's age profile suggests. Tall, direct and fearless, he is one of the brightest prospects in Brazilian football and a reminder that the country's production line of attacking talent remains intact. He is unlikely to begin the tournament as a starter, but World Cups have a habit of introducing young players to global

audiences.

The midfield, meanwhile, belongs to Bruno Guimaraes. At Newcastle United, he has developed into one of Europe's most complete midfielders, capable of controlling tempo, progressing the ball and covering enormous distances without possession. If Vinicius is the player opponents fear most, Guimaraes may be the player Brazil can least afford to lose.

Alongside him, Lucas Paqueta provides the creativity and unpredictability that remain central to Brazil's footballing identity. He drifts between midfield and attack, linking phases of play and creating spaces others exploit. Together, Guimaraes and Paqueta could determine whether Brazil become merely efficient or genuinely dangerous.

Direct style

Further forward, Ancelotti appears likely to favour a more direct style than many of his predecessors. The objective will not be endless possession but rapid transitions, using Vinicius' pace and the athleticism around him to attack unsettled defences. It is a blueprint familiar from Ancelotti's club sides: structured without the ball, devastating when space opens up.

Behind them stands a defensive unit built on experience. Marquinhos remains the leader of the back line, while Alisson Becker provides the assurance every serious contender needs. For years, Brazil's goalkeepers were supporting actors in stories dominated by attackers. Alisson has quietly become one of the finest in the country's history, capable of winning matches when tournaments get tight and margins disappear.

The faces that dominate billboards remain familiar. Neymar is back. Vinicius is the headline act. But the team's identity feels different. It is less dependent on individual inspiration and more invested in collective stability.

That, ultimately, is Ancelotti's gamble.

Brazil's greatest teams were remembered for beauty. This one appears determined to add something else to the equation: control. After 24 years without a World Cup title, the world's most successful football nation seems willing to sacrifice a little romance in pursuit of something far more valuable.

A sixth star.

{ FROM THE SIDELINES }

Cape Verde's link to Goa besides footy is 'Sodade'



Express News Service
Mumbai, June 7

"IF YOU write me, I'll write you... If you forget me, I'll forget you"

Thus goes the melancholic Morna music from Cape Verde, strains of the song "Sodade" which will ring out at their FIFA World Cup games against Spain, Uruguay and Saudi Arabia.

According to Bdnews24.com, the folk song "remembers the tens of thousands of emigrés who have left these 10 islands sprinkled off the coast of West Africa for work and opportunities abroad."

Their football team is

made up of children and grandchildren of these same populations that left the islands for livelihood. The Blue Sharks who won seven of their 10 qualifying games are made up of similarly foreign-based players, even as head coach Pedro Leitão Brito — who was named Africa's Coach of the Year in 2025 and is better known by his nickname, Bubista.

While football looks ahead, Morna music leans on nostalgia, yearning and home sickness.

Sodade (or Saudade, if you dig Goan jazz or blues), is expected to ring out when Cape Verde play at the World Cup.

32 years later, Haaland follows father to FIFA WC



IN A FIFA reel shot ahead of the 2026 edition, **Erling Haaland** is handed a picture of his father Alf-Inge from seven years before he was even born. "He looks so young. So weird to see him. I was thinking it was something like this," he says ahead of his debut, adding, "It's a bit weird to have a father who played the World Cup."

What strikes him the most in the photograph handed to him is Alf-Inge's longish locks. "Never seen him with this long hair in my life. It's a good photo. Wish he had hair a bit longer now as well," he laughs.

The 53-year-old who went by the name Alf-Inge Rasmussen Haaland played as a right back or midfielder for Norway, besides Man City, Nottingham Forest and Leeds in the Premiership in the 1990s. ENS

Friendly called off after Eriksen collapses again

DENMARK'S CHRISTIAN Eriksen collapsed on the pitch in a match against Ukraine on Saturday, leading to the game getting called off. He was conscious, the Danish Football Federation said in a social media post.

"Christian Eriksen is conscious and is doing well under the circumstances," the federation said in a statement on X. In the 65th minute, Eriksen appeared to hold his chest and fall to the ground prompting a pause in play. The Danish football association has since clarified that he is conscious and that the match has been called off.

The incident brought back horrible memories from 2021 when Eriksen had collapsed during a Euro 2020 match in Copenhagen and was given life-saving CPR treatment. After the incident, he spent one week in the hospital where he was fitted with a special heart-starting device known as an Implantable Cardioverter-Defibrillator (ICD), before going home to Denmark to recover. Finland had won the game 1-0. ENS

● PRODIGY TAKES ON WORLD

Yamal's chance to realise his destiny on big stage

Sandip G

LAST MARCH, Lamine Yamal posted a picture of a word file on a laptop, the dimming lights from Barcelona's fading night flickering in the background. The laptop's screen and background are black. The only visible words are the title of the file: "Chapter 1: My Inner Abyss," and the opening words: "I would like to be what everyone wants me to be."

The world wondered at the cause of his melancholy. He was 18, a star already, a European Championship winner, a multiple league champion with a mantelpiece stacked with trophies of personal glory, a millionaire, an inspiration for millions of migrant children in Spain's nondescript backyards.

But despair was gnawing inside. A sports hernia had afflicted him at the start of the season. It continued to haunt him. Towards the end of the season, it recurred, putting his World Cup participation in jeopardy at one stage. He had logged in nearly 8,000 hours of football before turning 18; the club and country blamed each other for mismanaging his workload.

Maybe, Yamal felt burned out; maybe, the implacable

burden of being painted the best player in the world crushed him. But the reason for his melancholia, he said after brightening his mood with a hat-trick against Villarreal — his first in the league, was not meeting his own expectations. "I wasn't happy on the pitch and I think you could tell. I didn't feel like smiling on the pitch," he admitted.

The numbers are glittering for a self-evaluated bad season. Yamal scored 24 goals, half of them cutting from the left and flashing his willowy yet rubbery left leg towards the goal, making humiliation-GIFs and memes out of defenders. He assisted in 18 goals in just 45 games. Yet, he was dejected, because the standards he has set himself are higher.

But he knows what greatness looks like; if not, there are men and objects around him, every blade of grass at Nou Camp and corners of the dressing room, to tell him how footballing greatness looks. It measures five feet seven inches, but its stature and scale are immeasurable. The shadow of Lionel Messi casts itself on his spiritual heir from Barcelona to North America, where Yamal strides out for the biggest tournament yet in his life.



Lamine Yamal will be a key figure for Spain at FIFA WC. REUTERS

The moment Lionel Messi stroled in as a substitute in Argentina's 6-0 rout of Serbia and Montenegro at the 2006 World Cup, the only question that mattered was when he would hoist the World Cup and fulfill the purpose of his footballing life. The Argentine had to wait till his fifth tournament to do it, wore the heaviest burden and anguish for 16 years, endured heartbreaks, suffered criticisms and injuries, retired several times, and saw the moment nearly stolen by Kylian Mbappe.

Yamal has already helped Spain win the European Championship, not least with his incredulous strike against France in the semifinal in Munich, a

strike barged into football's consciousness. But it's the World Cup that would define him, one that would trench his legacy. "I have lifted it a thousand times, in my room or when we won a match at the sports centre in my neighborhood," he jokes in an interview with the Spanish Football Federation. He was referring to a replica trophy in his uncle Abdul's bakery in their hometown Rocafonda.

His days on the streets are long gone; his journey from Rocafonda to Nou Camp was swift. But the sceptre of expectations and the anticipation of the magical will be suffocating, as it was with Messi, his idol Neymar and Cristiano Ronaldo. Every step he

takes will be watched and dissected; his victories glorified, his failures criticised.

He is aware of the pressures. Recently, he posted on Instagram: "Gavi kept telling me he's the youngest Spanish player to score a World Cup goal... So I'm going to try a HAT-TRICK. I'll probably be the youngest Spanish player to do it."

Yamal has a lightness that great sportsmen have. It's not the exuberant bravado of late-teenage that rings in him, but a preternatural awareness of his gifts. He is not worried about what the world thinks of him. "My only enemy is myself, I want to get better than myself," he once told Marca.

He has a stern voice on more sensitive topics, too. In April, after a friendly between Egypt and Spain in Espanyol's RCDE Stadium, where Egyptians were subjected to anti-Muslim chants, he launched a scathing attack on the perpetrators on Instagram: "Football is to enjoy and support, not to offend people by who they are or what they believe in."

Yamal possesses not only a magic wand of a left foot but a discernible heart. He has conquered Spain and Europe. Now, to the world.

Iranians arrive in Mexico amid high tensions with US

Reuters
Tijuana, June 7

IRAN'S NATIONAL soccer team arrived in Tijuana early on Sunday ahead of three World Cup matches in the United States, amid tensions that have turned the world's biggest sporting event into a soft-power contest between the warring countries. The squad touched down shortly after five a.m. (1200 GMT) in the Mexican city, across the border from San Diego, after an overnight flight from Turkey where they have been training for the past three weeks.

Base in Mexico

A cordon of military and police escorted the team from the airport to the Marriott hotel, which will serve as their base.

Soccer is virtually a religion in Iran, a national pastime beloved by people across the political spectrum. But for Iran's team, the tournament has been marred by fraught politics at home, the war with the U.S., and tensions over whether they would actually be able to set foot on U.S. soil if both teams come second in their groups.

Even their presence in Tijuana is politically tinged. The



Close to 20 Iranian fans gather as the national football team is escorted by the local police to their hotel in Tijuana. REUTERS

Iranian federation negotiated at the last minute to move the team's base camp from Arizona to Mexico, due to uncertainty over whether they would be granted visas and a growing feeling in Iran that the squad's presence in the U.S. should be kept to a minimum.

Iran are scheduled to play their first two Group G games near Los Angeles, against New Zealand on June 15 and Belgium on June 21, and then face Egypt in Seattle on June 26. Iran and the U.S. could meet in the round of 32 if both teams come second in their groups.

This is the first World Cup

since its inception in 1930 in which a host nation is set to receive a country it is at war with. But the U.S. tensions are just one of several factors that have turned the World Cup into a political battleground for the Iranian team.

After weeks of uncertainty, the U.S. awarded visas to all the players on Friday, just 10 days before their first match. But several members of the Iranian squad were not given visas, including "key managerial and administrative members," according to Iran's football federation, which accused the U.S. of breaching its host obligations.

